

“Inner Excellence will change your life.”

—Vaughn Taylor, three-time PGA Tour Winner

INNER EXCELLENCE

TRAIN YOUR MIND FOR
EXTRAORDINARY PERFORMANCE
AND THE BEST POSSIBLE LIFE

REVISED EDITION

JIM MURPHY

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& THE BEST POSSIBLE LIFE

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Praise for *Inner Excellence*

“Inner Excellence changed how I see the world, how I think, and how I play golf.”

—Vaughn Taylor, Three-time PGA Tour winner

“Inner Excellence transformed my life—as a caddie, a father, and husband. This book is a masterpiece.”

—Brandon Parsons, PGA Tour veteran caddie

“Inner Excellence has had a dramatic impact on how I approach my life and how I play hockey.”

—Kevin Connauton, Defenseman, Arizona Coyotes

“Inner Excellence is an instruction manual that will teach you how to perform under pressure and live the best possible life. It’s something I’ll refer to the rest of my life.”

—Teddy Scott, 20-year PGA Tour golf caddie, 14 years with Bubba Watson

“I read the first edition of ***Inner Excellence*** ten times. I’ve practically memorized it. Incredibly, this revised edition is even better.”

—Jonathan Michael, Adjunct Professor, Trinity Western University,
Governor General’s Gold Medal award winner

“Inner Excellence changed my life.”

—Ryan Dodd, World No. 1 ranked water ski jumper and current world record holder

“Jim is an expert in his field. ***Inner Excellence*** transcends athletics and will have a profound effect on everyone who applies these methods in their life.”

—John Kehoe, author of *Mind Power into the 21st Century*

“***Inner Excellence*** has profoundly influenced every area of my life.”

—David Bentall, President, *Next Step Advisors*, Adjunct Professor,
University of British Columbia

“And now here is my secret, a very simple secret: It is only with the heart that one can see rightly; what is essential is invisible to the eye.”

—**Antoine de Saint-Exupéry, *The Little Prince***

“Above all else, watch over your heart, for everything you do flows from it.”

—**Solomon, 3rd King of the United Monarchy**

For my father, Donald C. Murphy

To the one who greatly influenced me to
think deeply about what to love
and what to let go of.
I love you. See you soon.

For my mother, Michiko M. Murphy (nee Koyama)

To my role model. I love you.

For Naomi T. Murphy

My sister, my inspiration

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Preface

Koyama Bunpachiro had a difficult decision. Was he prepared to die? Was he ready to sacrifice comfort and pleasure and devote everything he had to the selfless way of the warrior? Would he honor the code?

To be a samurai in feudal Japan was to command honor and respect, embodied from a lifetime of training in moral leadership, duty and grace. Bunpachiro's life, like every other samurai, included daily training for battle and swordsmanship as well as calligraphy, poetry, art and tea ceremony.

The code of the samurai required total commitment. It would involve putting his country and master above himself, to the extent of imagining he was already dead. It meant waking up every day ready to die.

Bunpachiro chose the samurai way of life—and the acceptance of death that came with it. But in 1867, his entire lifestyle came to an abrupt halt. When two and a half centuries of samurai rule ended during his lifetime, he went from having incredible power to feeling powerless. His elite status, and everything he'd sacrificed for, was gone. His heart was crushed. Without a purpose for his life, the bottle became his unsympathetic friend.

If only Bunpachiro had learned what I've discovered, **which is that every human heart has the potential for deep contentment, joy and confidence, and training it is the most important thing you'll ever do.** Your heart is where all your hopes and dreams, fears and anxieties fade or flourish. It's the source of mental toughness and inner strength. If your heart is built around something temporary that you cannot control, your life will be unstable. Bunpachiro's self-worth was attached to his role as samurai and when he lost it, he lost everything.

As you read this book and examine your heart, what you'll find is that your greatest dream is not realized in having millions of dollars or perhaps a house overlooking the ocean. Your dream is how you think these things will make you feel. Perhaps those things will bring happiness as you imagine people complimenting you on your success, or will bring great experiences as you have your friends over to enjoy your waterfront home. But maybe they won't. Besides, money and material possessions aren't actually what you're *really* after.

If you search your heart, beyond the desire for any measure of success, you'll discover, I believe, that what you really want is to feel truly alive, filled with vitality, purpose and meaning—absolute fullness of life. For most of us, perhaps unknowingly, life has been one long search for this fullness. We want deep, enriching experiences and meaningful relationships, a life where we're not constantly shrinking back in fear. We want to live courageously, learning and growing, fueling a fearlessness that awakens the lives of others.

That life is available to all of us, but we so easily get caught up chasing symbols of success rather than the real thing, sidetracked in busyness, losing sight of what we truly want. Rather than seeking fearless authenticity and personal growth directly, we pursue an illusion and get emptiness instead.

The direct pursuit means developing a new mindset and new skills, ones that lead to inner strength, peace, and confidence, independent of circumstances. Your heart may need to re-orient its bearings and redefine success by prizing something that's more stable and powerful than your feelings or status, letting go of how society measures your life.

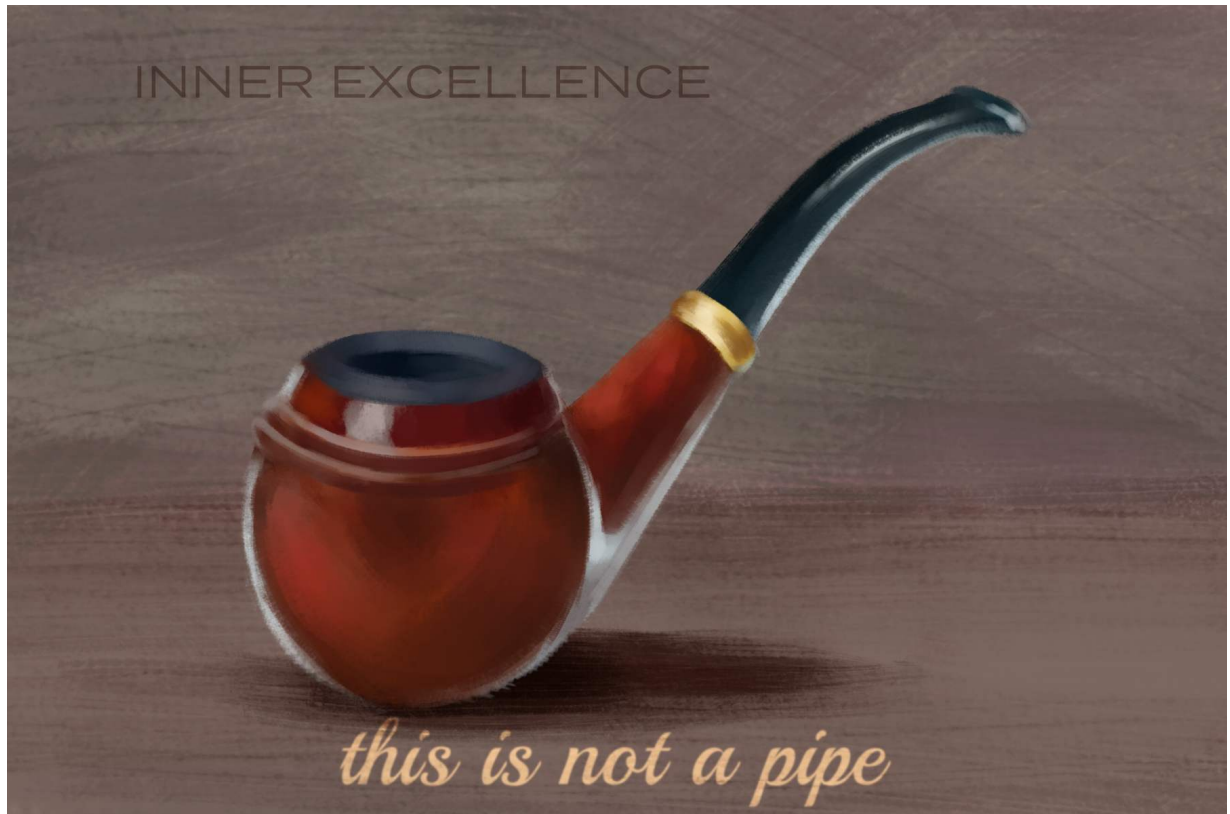
You can learn how to perform extraordinarily, under extreme pressure,

and live a life of deep contentment, joy and confidence. In fact, you'll find that this re-orientation of the heart is the most efficient and powerful way to do so.

Yoshitaka Koyama, (Bunpachiro's son), watched his father, once a great warrior, lose his prominence and become an alcoholic. He saw that his father's identity was wrapped up in status and things he could not control. Yoshitaka began to think deeply about his own life, about what he truly wanted, and what was most important. He realized that what he craved was not power or prestige—he wanted fullness of life. As a result, Yoshitaka changed the course of his life, from one focused on power over others, to one focused on empowering others. Through this shift he gained deep contentment, joy and confidence and lived an extraordinary life.

This book was written by his great grandson.

Presuppositions (Assumptions)



The quality of your *life* is based on three elements:

1. Your inner world of thoughts and feelings, beliefs and desires.
2. Your frame of reference (mindset) from which you see the world.
3. Your relationships.

How you think and feel is the result of the assumptions and beliefs that have formed in your heart (and subconscious, which we'll get into later). These assumptions and beliefs create a certain mindset that impacts how you relate to yourself, to others, and to everything in your life.

The quality of your *performance* is also based on three elements:

1. Your *belief* about who you are and what's possible for you.
2. Your ability to *focus* and be fully engaged in the moment: heart, mind and body (note: **heart and spirit** will be used interchangeably).
3. Your *freedom* to play like a kid, curiously exploring possibilities, excited for challenges that may arise.

The three elements that determine your quality of life, and three elements that determine the quality of your performance, are deeply interwoven.

I started writing the first version of this book in 2004 after moving to the Sonoran Desert in Arizona to live a life of relative solitude. I got rid of my television and over half my possessions, with Winston Churchill's words endlessly floating across my laptop's screensaver:

Those destined for greatness must first walk alone in the desert.

I went to the desert to live deliberately, in solitude, so I could live out Churchill's words. Words that also penetrated my heart were from Henry David Thoreau, who went into nature as well. Like Thoreau, I wanted to...

...front only the essential facts of life and see if I could not learn what it had to teach, and not, when it came time to die, discover that I had not truly lived. I did not wish to live what was not life, living is so dear; nor did I wish to practice resignation, unless it was quite necessary. I wanted to live deep and suck out all the marrow of life, to live so sturdily and Spartan-like as to put to rout all that was not life, to cut a broad swath and shave close, to drive life into a corner, and reduce it to its lowest terms.

I ended up spending five years in full-time research, interviews, and writing, two and a half years of it in the desert. I was obsessed with learning

how the best in the world performed with confidence and poise under the most pressure. The main question I studied—and posed to sport psychologists all over North America—was this: How can an Olympic athlete train for four years, for an event that may last less than a minute, and have peace and confidence under that kind of pressure?

As I dove into research, I realized that helping athletes win a world championship or Olympic gold medal would be meaningless unless it improved their quality of life—their inner life. So I started to study two main concepts:

How to have extraordinary **poise and mental toughness** under extreme pressure.

1. How to live the best possible life, one with deep contentment, joy and confidence.
2. In the desert I had an astonishing insight. I realized that the pursuit of extraordinary performance and the pursuit of the best possible life are the same path.

This realization changed my life.

I only wish I had learned it when I was playing in the Chicago Cubs organization. I could have performed with so much more freedom and confidence. I was playing the wrong game, but didn't know it.

Most of us have been playing the wrong game our entire lives. We've been focusing on short-term wins, temporary happiness, and surface-level achievements, when we were created for so much more. We've been playing a zero-sum, finite game, with a winner and a loser, a beginning and an end, when it's really an infinite one. Life is meant to be a journey

connecting with others, growing together, discovering new and amazing things, rather than a game of constant comparison and competition, always trying to fit in or be successful. We've been setting our sights too low, going for the low-hanging fruit on a single bush, when entire orchards await.

Which game have *you* been playing?

The best possible life—absolute fullness of life—is one with extraordinary experiences, deep, meaningful relationships, and, most of all: love, joy and peace. These three “resources” lead to an abundance of fruit that multiplies into so much more: peace becomes patience, patience becomes kindness, then goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and, ultimately, self-control.

Whatever dream you may have, I believe that in the end, what you really want is to be filled with love, joy and peace and all the other powerful resources that come with them. It's an extraordinary life and it's available to all of us, but the cost is high. It takes clear intention and devotion, and the willingness to be vulnerable in order to develop your inner world.

To develop your inner world is to transform your heart, so that what it loves most is powerful and meaningful. This enables you to grow in **belief, focus and freedom**, the three key elements of extraordinary performance. It enables you to direct your thoughts and create mental patterns around extraordinary possibilities and what you're most passionate and excited about—what you were born for—rather than being caught up in worry, stress or anxiety.

Most of us have had it backwards, trying to be successful in order to be happy. If we focus on improving our inner world, however, we'll achieve far more. We can have joy and peace, purpose and power—which will maximize our performance as well. But we need to get the order right if we

want extraordinary performance over the long term—and an amazing life: heart first, performance second. Inner world first, outer world follows. Besides, an extraordinary outer world is worthless without a meaningful inner one, is it not?

The journey toward the best possible life starts with adjusting the lens through which we see the world. According to Dr. Darrell Johnson, PhD, Teaching Fellow at Regent College:

Every human being has a vision of reality; every one of us looks out at life from a frame of reference. We all have deeply held presuppositions about the nature of reality. We may not be able to name those presuppositions but they're there. They're reflected in the way we treat people, the way we spend time and the way we spend our money. Or to put it more simply, every single one of us wears a set of glasses. These glasses were given to us by our families, by our childhood experiences, by the books we've read, by the experiences we've had, by the movies we've seen. These visions of reality affect the whole of our lives.

The most extraordinary performers and individuals who ever lived, perceived their circumstances in remarkably similar ways. They had a lens through which they viewed the world that was similar to each other's but very different from everyone else's.

This book will help you understand how those amazing individuals trained their minds (and oriented their hearts) so that they were always learning and growing, and how you can train your mind and heart to do the same.

In order to have both sustained peak performance and fullness of life, we

must examine who we are, how we're put together, and what drives us. In my five years of full-time research (post-Master's degree) the same component stood out for both peak performance and having an extraordinary life: the heart. Learning that the heart (or spirit) is the key driver for both was the turning point in my research.

The heart is where we store our hopes and dreams, beliefs and assumptions. Out of the heart comes good or evil, love or fear. It's the source of our deepest motivations and greatest power. If we want to develop confidence and poise under pressure, as well as deep contentment and joy, we need to challenge the assumptions and beliefs we have in our hearts—to see if they are really true. We all have a story we've been telling ourselves over our entire lifetimes, based on assumptions and beliefs that have formed in our hearts. Some of these are empowering and true, some are not. We also have beliefs that allow us to see possibilities and beauty no one else can.

When your life is based on the Truth with a capital T, it expands every day—like the sun's rays filling a welcoming sky—revealing unknown beauties. On this powerful journey of *Inner Excellence*, we're going to direct what you think and how you think towards what's powerful and permanent.

First, however, we must let go of the assumptions (we'll call them presuppositions) that may have limited our lives without our knowing it. A life with unlimited possibilities is only possible when the assumptions that guide our lives are also free from limits.

Here are some old presuppositions we're going to drop (and the reasons why):

- I am my thoughts.
 - Sometimes terrible or shameful thoughts flash through our minds that are not true and have nothing to do with who we really are.
- My value is based on my results.
 - You may have grown up in a culture or family that has instilled this in you, but your self-worth does not increase or decrease based on your performance.
- The best performers were born that way.
 - Whatever abilities you were born with can be improved far beyond what you've imagined, largely through hard work, deliberate practice on specific skills (that I will teach you), and learning to direct and control your desires.

Here are ten new empowering presuppositions that will form the basis of the mindset you'll develop as you read this book:

1. Every circumstance and every person you encounter is here to teach you and help you—it's all working for your good.
 - You were created for glory (infinite, inherent worth).
 - The life you've been given is meant to develop your character and prepare you for that glory.
2. Your life is a reflection of your beliefs.
 - The foundation for extraordinary performance, joy and confidence—and the primary skill to learn—is how to believe.
 - Beliefs are the control panel of your life, a subconscious thermostat,

keeping your life in line with your comfort levels. To improve performance (and your life) in a consistent, powerful way, you must change your beliefs about who you are and what's possible.

3. Self-centeredness is the root cause of fear.

- It leads to self-consciousness (concern about what others think of us), overanalysis, and ultimately, self-rejection.
- Our greatest obstacle is getting in our own way through arrogance or self-rejection, both of which come from self-centeredness.

4. We all have the same deep needs and same deep desires.

- Every human heart desperately wants to be loved and accepted; most of what we do is done in order to meet this need.
- Our deepest need is for unconditional love and our greatest desire is to be fully known and fully loved.

5. Everyone does the best they can with what they have (in their hearts).

- That is... according to their background, their understandings, their beliefs, their fears, their wounds, and their voids.
- Whenever someone (including yourself) acts in a way that is painful or hurtful, it is because they lack resources such as love, joy and peace, looking through a self-centered lens of fear or pain.

6. The map is not the territory.

- The world you see and interact with isn't reality; it's the one your mind created, based on the way you've interpreted and processed the events in your life so far.
- The pipe you saw at the beginning of these presuppositions is not

actually a pipe. It's a picture of a pipe. That may seem like a silly distinction, but actually it's quite important (as Rene Magritte shared with us in his 1929 painting, [The Treachery of Images](#)).

7. You are not your mind.

- Your mind is a part of you that you need to train. You can learn to direct and control your thoughts, just like you learn to control your body.
- The greatest freedom you have is where to place your thoughts. As you realize that you are not your mind, you will be less attached to the useless, negative thoughts that come every day, and direct your mind towards empowering ones.

8. The problem is not the problem, the problem is the way you're thinking about it.

- You're not happy or sad because of your circumstances, but rather because of what you *think* about your circumstances.
- How you feel originates almost entirely from what you think; the state you enter caused by how you think about a problem is the real problem.

9. There's no failure, only feedback.

- Success and failure are highly interrelated, equally important, and labeled as opposites by our culture.
- Your ability to learn and grow and maximize your potential is directly correlated to your ability to embrace failure.

10. The person with the most control of their inner world has the most

power.

- Mastery of the ego is the great challenge (and greatest opponent) in every competition.
- Selflessness—complete surrender—of the attachments, concerns and fears of the self, is the central component to extraordinary performance and cornerstone to creating beliefs that lead to absolute fullness of life.

Note: Inner Excellence definitions for some of the terms throughout the book are provided in the glossary.

These presuppositions are a crucial part of the mindset you'll be developing the rest of your life. You'll be learning a lot of new information and because much of this is new to you, it may seem overwhelming at times. Don't worry, my professional athletes have achieved extraordinary success through this process, and most have felt the same way at the start. Remember, this is a lifelong journey. This is a manual you will refer back to many times.

As you go through the book, mark this section to keep these presuppositions and principles in mind. Commit them to memory and take notes, especially in the first few chapters as we analyze the challenging obstacles that we all encounter. As you do, you'll begin to notice how these perspectives will help you gain mastery over your greatest challenges. This will set the foundation for the tools and skills you'll learn throughout the rest of the book. Ok, it's go time. Let's do this!

Introduction

We are half-hearted creatures, fooling about with drink and sex and ambition when infinite joy is offered to us, like an ignorant child who wants to go on making mud pies in a slum because he cannot imagine what is meant by an offer of a holiday at sea. We are far too easily pleased.

—C.S. Lewis, *The Weight of Glory*

In the early hours of June 27, 2011, Ryan Dodd woke up in an alley outside a bar in a rough part of town in Flint, Michigan. He had a fractured skull. Only hours before, he had been standing on top of the podium after one of the biggest victories of his life, holding the “King of Darkness” gold medal high in the air.

Professional waterski jumpers hit the ramp at 70 miles per hour and fly over 200 feet. Ryan was used to facing danger, but never so much as that night.

At the hospital, he was diagnosed with a fractured skull and bleeding in the brain in three areas. He was rushed to the trauma center for emergency surgery to alleviate pressure on the skull. Twelve hours later they were able to stop the bleeding.

After a miraculous recovery, Ryan not only skied again, but he excelled. He won his first event back on the water in May the following year. Several weeks later he then won the next (and biggest) event of the year, the Masters, which he’d never won before. He went on to have the best year of his career.

Ryan continued to improve and in 2017 he broke the world record, became world champion, and number one in the world. Over the past four

years (2016-19) Ryan won 87% of the tournaments he entered. In August 2019, on a Sunday afternoon just outside Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia, he won his third world championship in a row.

How did Ryan go from waking up in an alley with a fractured skull, to getting back on the water and achieving things he never dreamed possible?

Interestingly, his workouts and training volume stayed about the same. Yet, there was a fundamental difference between Ryan pre-head injury and Ryan post-head injury, one that helped propel him to the top of the world rankings and the world record. Ryan found a different way of living in the world – one that changed how he thought about his performance and entire life.

This book is about that difference.

It's a completely different way of seeing the world, one that transforms not just how we think, but what we think about. It's a different lifestyle, one that revamps our hearts from seeking temporary, surface-level goals to seeking powerful, permanent ones. It completely reverses how we pursue peak performance.

Ryan's life and performance dramatically changed by changing one thing in his life: he learned *Inner Excellence*. This book will teach you what Ryan and other world-class athletes have learned: how to train your mind for extraordinary performance and fullness of life.

Whether we're athletes or not, we're all performers. We all "compete" to have good days, handle adversity well, get in a rhythm that flows with peace and purpose, and get great results. We also all have a certain mindset from which our performance—and daily life—flows.

Your mindset is your overall attitude and way of thinking that comes from how you perceive yourself and the world. These perceptions create certain

attitudes and ways of thinking that become habitual. It orients your heart around what you believe is important and possible in your life. Your mindset sets the tone for everything you do.

The mindset of *Inner Excellence* is this:

I compete to raise the level of excellence in my life, to learn and grow, in order to raise it in others.

We don't pursue peak performance for the trophy or adoration, but to discover something within us and experience something we've never experienced before. We compete for the competition itself, to fully experience the moment and feel fully alive. We do this to help others—including our opponents—do the same thing, so we can all learn and grow and raise the level of excellence in our lives. We crave adversity and challenges as a means of seeing the truth about who we are in that moment and therefore who we can become.

We don't climb mountains to get to the top—we climb to see who we can become in trying to get there. The peak gives us a goal and focus for our behaviors, but the reason for climbing or competing is far more empowering than an expansive view and social media posts.

Consider the journal entry of Olympic speed skater Clara Hughes after winning a gold medal:

In my heart it is clear to me why I go to the line time and again. I can assure you it's not a medal hanging around my neck I'm after. Medals are things I send to my mom in Winnipeg, which she in turn shares with friends and family. They are not what provide the deep sense of accomplishment, which fills my sense of self, in turn

teaching me how to live.

Hughes skates so she can learn how to live. The most powerful way to live is to raise the level of excellence in your life, to learn and grow, in order to raise it in others.

Here's a comparison of how the world sees competition and performance and how *Inner Excellence* views them:

The world's mindset

Winning is everything.

You are your results.

The opponent is the enemy.

Failure is not an option.

Fierce competitors get mad when they lose.

***Inner Excellence* mindset**

Developing inner strength, fully experiencing the moment, and continually growing are far more lasting and empowering.

Results are an inconsistent measure of success and failure: you can perform poorly and win, just as you can perform well and lose.

The opponent is our partner in the dance.

Failure is the key component of growth. There is no real "failure", only feedback.

The best competitors develop emotional control and use mistakes to get better.

Inner Excellence is an entire lifestyle and training system designed to help

you, whether you're a professional athlete or everyday citizen, perform extraordinarily and be your true self so you can live with absolute fullness of life.

In this book, we'll look at how top Olympians and world-class performers train for years for an event that may last less than a minute. Despite not having full control over their results, these athletes perform with peace and confidence under incredible pressure. We'll then look at how you can do the same, whether you're an athlete or executive, baker or blogger.

In my experience talking to and working with world-class performers and leaders, I've learned that what we really want, beyond our tangible goals and pursuits, is to feel totally alive. We crave great experiences and meaningful relationships and we long to reach our full potential. We want to be challenged and creative. We want to grow. We want freedom to live with passion and pursue our dreams regardless of what people think, how much money we make, or what level of status we acquire. Ultimately, we want the best possible life—absolute fullness of life.

Fear takes all of that away. Fear lives in the painful memories of the past and unknown experiences of the future, taking us out of the unlimited possibilities in the present. Instead of challenges, we see obstacles; instead of opportunities, we see setbacks. Instead of experiencing growth, we live in the past. If we want to truly live, we need to embrace our fears and find the courage to be our true selves.

As an outfielder in the Chicago Cubs organization, my sense of worth and identity revolved around my performance, mostly my batting average. When I hit well, I walked tall and felt great. When I hit poorly, my shoulders slumped and my outlook was dark. Life was a roller coaster of emotions. I was a slave to results and it stifled my performance. I was afraid

of failure and that fear kept putting my mind in the past and future.

When I started coaching professional and Olympic athletes, I saw this over and over again: athletes had lost their joy and passion for life as they struggled under the pressure to perform. The fear of failure engulfed their lives.

This book will share with you how some of the best athletes in the world have learned *Inner Excellence*, how it propelled them to extraordinary performance even when they were filled with doubt, and how you can excel in the same way in your life. But far more than that, you'll learn how to live with deep contentment, joy and confidence in your everyday life.

We'll see how the basic principles are the same, whether you're an athlete or an executive, an Olympic team or corporate group. We'll explore the concept of selfless-actualization and the ways in which the study of extraordinary people teaches us to perform our best and truly live.

The first concept to learn is this: This book, this lifestyle, is based on a presupposition:

The biggest obstacle we face, in performance and in life, is self-centeredness.

It's not the morality of it that I speak of. The main issue is that in our preoccupation with ourselves, our vision narrows, our growth is limited, and our failures are amplified. Curiosity and excitement for challenges gets replaced by anxiety and fear of failure. The potential for self-rejection grows.

How you see the world, and therefore what you believe is possible, comes from the beliefs you've created and the story you made out of it about who you are. That story comes from your mind's continual assessment of your past, to which you've become attached. It's that attachment that limits us.

Our biggest obstacle is in our mind, or, rather, the program our mind runs based on who we've subconsciously programmed ourselves to be.

The solution is one that has empowered world-class performers, Olympic and professional athletes, and some of the best teams in the world. It's a model based on three simple words: love, wisdom, and courage. Love is to lead with your heart, wisdom is to expand your vision, and courage is to be fully present. In this model, love becomes passion, wisdom becomes purpose, and courage becomes poise.

If in the pursuit of the extraordinary, you devote your entire life to learning and growing in love, wisdom, and courage, you'll find, I believe, that your heart will slowly transform to value experience more than results. You'll gain belief, focus and freedom (BFF). Soon, fully experiencing the moment will move up in priority over winning or the bottom line, which ironically, will allow you to win more often. Where it once focused on temporary, surface-level goals and desires, your heart will lose self-conscious concern for self and become devoted to what's powerful and permanent. Your performance will take off. Your life will change. Let's go. Amazing awaits.

1

Maslow and the Maserati *The Pursuit of More*

Seduced by the siren song of a consumerist, quick-fix society, we sometimes choose a course of action that brings only the illusion of accomplishment, the shadow of satisfaction.

—George Leonard, Aikido master

If you want freedom, you might consider going into the wild. There's no mortgage, bills, or lawn to mow. If it's stability and security you're after, you might consider the three meals a day offered within the four walls of prison. But if you want a different freedom, the freedom of a life of vision and courage, peace and joy, it's going to cost you. Real freedom is costly.

In order to be truly free, we must have the courage to conform to certain disciplines, face our fears, and connect with our true selves. The path toward real success and long-term fulfillment is a risky one: obstacles of materialism, consumerism, and instant gratification confront us every day. They create a seductive numbness and a false reality that inhibits a powerful life, a life of freedom. As we gradually conform to society's expectations and its definition of success, we become defined by our day-to-day performance (and our results), we lose our freedom, and eventually, we lose our selves.

It's a daunting view, the risky path of our true dreams. It's much more comfortable to follow the easier, wider route of less risk, less failure, and more self-indulgence. We don't like to look at that unknown path of possibility; it's too scary. It's easier to give in to that part of the mind that

wants instant gratification and temporary pleasures, to cover up the bigger, scarier picture of what we really want: the sacred moments that come from feeling truly alive. So we end up using our God-given talents in pursuit of false idols— chasing money or status or numbers or approval—in an attempt to quench our deep thirst to be grounded and fulfilled.

We've all had times when everything came together in perfect harmony: sacred moments, when we were totally immersed in the experience and felt fully alive. When these moments occur, we wish, even for a split second, we had the courage to pursue this risky path with all our heart.

And we can! Often, though, we're so hard on ourselves, amplifying all our failures and regrets, that we neglect to see what's still possible—a life of freedom, filled with deep contentment, joy and confidence, independent of circumstances. We're all human, with the same deep desires and concerns. We all want great experiences and meaningful relationships; we want to be part of something bigger than ourselves. We want to love and laugh and be successful. It's human nature.

But each of us also has a mind that has judgmental thoughts, produces desires that hurt us, and creates beliefs that limit us. This all occurs because our minds have not been trained to manage the one component on which everything hinges: *our thoughts*.

In the pursuit of extraordinary performance, it's easy to succumb to anxiety and pressure, because so much is out of your control. When you learn to live a life that is fully engaged, however, then you can perform your best *and* love the challenge. Every performance, presentation, or problem you face is an opportunity to learn and grow and vividly experience each moment. You will find, as you take this journey with me, that your best moments always come from a clear mind and unburdened heart. This

allows you to take the risks necessary to be everything you were created to be.

The Narrow Road of *Selfless* Actualization

Don't aim at success—the more you aim at it and make it a target, the more you are going to miss it. For success, like happiness, cannot be pursued; it must ensue, and it only does so as the unintended side-effect of one's dedication to a cause greater than oneself, or as the by-product of one's surrender to a person other than oneself.

—**Dr. Victor Frankl, holocaust survivor, author, *Man's Search for Meaning***

In the quest for a life of freedom, there are two basic paths: the popular road, spacious and inviting, offering praise and admiration; and the narrow one that, though difficult, less glamorous, and often rocky, leads to deep contentment, joy and confidence. It's the latter path that sacrifices much but holds the key to extraordinary performance. There you'll find the freedom of an undivided heart, one not attached to your results or what people might think or say.

Psychiatrist Abraham Maslow studied this path in an interesting way. He analyzed the characteristics of successful people, such as Abraham Lincoln, Thomas Jefferson, and Albert Einstein: how they thought, what they dreamed of, how they lived. In doing so, he found that they shared a number of common traits, including a strong sense of self, a close connection to others, and both the curiosity to solve problems and the resourcefulness to do it. They had high self-acceptance and were motivated

to have peak experiences. He called these people, who not only changed the world but also lived fulfilling lives, *self-actualizers*, *fully human*.

Self-actualizers, Maslow noted, with their greater vision, shared a unique ability to engage in moments in which they felt truly alive, creative, and integrated. Maslow's high achievers selflessly pursued a purpose beyond themselves. In light of this, we'll refer to these high achievers as *selfless* actualizers, or people who saw the world through a lens beyond self, and thus had the freedom to live fully. Here are nine characteristics Maslow used to describe them:

1. **Total absorption** They learn to experience key events fully, vividly, and selflessly, with complete concentration.
2. **Personal growth** They don't get hung up on lower level needs or desires (i.e., approval from others), but seek to learn and grow. Their goal is to experience the moment, more so than anything tangible they can get from it. For them, the means *is* the end; the journey is the enjoyment, not the result.
3. **Self-awareness** Selfless actualizers do the work to uncover their true motives, emotions and abilities. They are guided by their own code of ethics, which often makes them feel like aliens in a foreign land.
4. **Gemeinschaft** This German word means fellowship and community. Maslow felt that belonging is a fundamental human need and that connecting with others was an essential part of self-actualization.
5. **Gratitude** Selfless actualizing people have the wonderful capacity to appreciate again and again, freshly and naïvely, the basic goods of life,

with awe, pleasure, wonder, and even ecstasy, however stale these experiences may have become to others. Thus, for such a person, any sunset may be as beautiful as the first one, any wildflower as breathtaking even after viewing a million wildflowers. For such people, even the casual workday, moment-to-moment business of living can be thrilling.

6. **Authenticity/resistance to enculturation** Selfless actualizers are motivated to fulfill their own inner potential rather than society's external rewards; they have greater autonomy and resist passively becoming like everyone else.
7. **Solitude** Selfless actualizers are able to be alone with their feelings. They desire solitude to a greater degree than the average person. Selfless-actualizers enjoy time for quiet reflection and do not always have to have people around them. They are able to be near someone and have no need to communicate with them; being in their presence is sufficient in and of itself.
8. **Purpose beyond self** Selfless actualizers have some mission in life, some task to fulfill, some problem outside themselves which enlists much of their energy, for the good of mankind.
9. **Lack of ego defenses** Maslow felt that we build walls we think will protect us but instead they hem us in. Selfless actualizers are able to identify their internal defenses and then find the courage to give them up.

In the pages that follow, you'll learn how self-centeredness leads to fear,

and similarly, how selflessness leads to fearlessness. For selfless actualizers, their natural concern for self - and all its limits and petty quibbles - were overshadowed by a much bigger vision with farther reaching possibilities than a self-centered mind can envision.

For Maslow, these characteristics and the behaviors associated with them, reveal what's already within you, or, more accurately, what's already you.

Imagine Michelangelo chiseling away the marble block as he sculpted David. He cut away everything that wasn't David to expose this magnificent human form. Likewise, we are the rock with the potential to emerge into something incredible, but we're constrained by expectations, worries, and fears. We've been socialized to value the fame and popularity of success, however fleeting, over the experience that drives it. In this we lose our joy. We get so locked into winning that we become afraid of losing.

Attachment to something you're not in complete control of makes you needy and brings with it the fear of not getting what you want. Concern for self and self-consciousness kicks in, scattering your energy and dividing your power. Back and forth it goes, between the quest to win and fear of losing; tension rises as the pressure mounts. But beneath those constraints lies an undivided heart—the heart of a warrior—your true self. Remove what isn't you and, like Michelangelo unveiled David, you'll discover tremendous strength and poise.

The Affluenza Virus

The true worth of a man is measured by the objects he pursues.

—Marcus Aurelius, Roman Emperor, 161-180 AD

To chisel away what's not you is difficult. It is easy to get sidetracked, seduced by the facade of what looks like your true dream. Western culture exposes us daily to the "affluenza" virus (the most dangerous type of virus—one that can steal your soul). This virus idolizes five things:

- **Possessions**
- **Achievements**
- **Looks** (physical appearance)
- **Money**
- **Status**

Merriam-Webster defines palms as (among other things) symbols of triumph or superiority. These five symbols of success can steal your true dreams by getting you to focus on them instead of what's truly meaningful, empowering, and permanent. The affluenza's virus injects you with the constant desire to gain more and compare yourself with others, and it's never satisfied. This phenomenon divides your heart and distances you from your true self.

Ironically, it's our fixation on the symbols of our dreams that takes us further from the real dream inside us. A nicer car. A bigger house. A million followers. Our natural attraction to things that make us look and feel good is where the road diverts from that which is powerful, fulfilling, and permanent.

According to Maslow, if we spend our life in pursuit of nicer places to live and fancier cars to drive (even if they are really cool), we're meeting only low-level needs. The problem isn't the components of the virus in and of themselves—the money, achievements, and so forth—but rather putting

your trust and identity in something transient and unstable.

The real problem occurs when those external things become your ultimate treasure, because your heart will follow. The focus of your highest desires molds you to have the characteristics of that which you desire. Possessions and achievements, looks, money and status are all fleeting, and a heart built on temporary things will have insecurity as a constant companion.

As others praise or covet your symbols of success, you get a momentary sense of pride and false sense of worth, which spurs you to chase after more of what you were praised for. The more you get, the more you want, and the more you have difficulty enjoying what once was really exciting. That striving becomes a sickness that leads to despair as your identity becomes characterized by what you have, what you've achieved, how you look or how others perceive you. When those things come, you see that they're hollow. It leaves an emptiness.

In Western culture, the affluenza virus is everywhere. When everyone around you has the cold or flu, it's hard not to get it yourself; you must take measures to strengthen your immunity against it, or you will succumb as well. Your immunity, as you'll see as we go along, is strengthened by a strong sense of identity, a purpose beyond self, and a powerful system for managing your thoughts, feelings and desires.

In my visits to other cultures, I've found life to be much simpler. In Costa Rica, for example, lawyers and cab drivers, shoppers and shop owners, all seemed socially equal. A dentist may socialize with a tow truck driver and invite the driver in for dinner after having his car towed, as my host family did while I was there coaching. I still recall my host asking him to stay for dinner—as if this was a normal thing—and getting so excited during the meal when the driver showed him on a map where he was from. The Costa

Rican culture seemed far happier and more content than my own. They work. They eat. They play. In their developing country, they needed little and appreciated much.

Your Deepest Desire

O, God of wonder, enlarge my capacity to be amazed at what is amazing and end my attraction to the insignificant.

—Dr. John Piper, Theologian

About 1700 years ago lived a guy named Augustine Aurelius who was said to love wisdom and have a great thirst for truth. In his studies he shared an intriguing insight: *“We are shaped most not by what we think, not by what we do, but by what we love. For when we ask whether somebody is a good person, we are not asking what he believes or hopes for, but what he loves.”*

In other words, it's our loves that govern our actions and the direction of our lives. What we love most at any given moment controls our lives at that moment. Augustine believed that the basic cause of our discontent was that our loves were out of order. Love popularity most, and insecurity will follow us everywhere. Love something much more powerful, however, like love itself—the unconditional kind—and we will be empowered *and* content.

To live with fullness of life, then, we must get our loves in an empowering order. We must love most what is most powerful.

When I played professional baseball, I thought what I loved most was hitting home runs, the cheers from the fans, being athletic, and competing in the moment. What I've since realized, but didn't know then, however, is

that what I *really* loved, was feeling totally alive. I craved being fully engaged in the moment...playing with passion...being part of a team, growing closer together in a common pursuit.

What you love most is a good indicator of whether or not you're afflicted with the affluenza virus. How do you know what you love most? Ask yourself three questions:

1. What do I dream about?
2. What do I worry about? (What has regularly made me anxious?)
3. What do I get upset about? (What has made me the angriest?)

The answer to these questions reveals what, in the deepest place of your heart, is most important to you. Your life will be as stable as whatever that *thing* is. That thing is what your life is built around. Do you have the virus?

One of the viral symptoms is the sense of entitlement that comes to those who are infected. When you've grown used to a certain amount of worldly success and your identity has become intertwined with it, you'll feel a deep disturbance when someone's words or actions threaten your reputation or status. Those things society says are great—even though they're fleeting—have entered your identity. They've become a part of you.

The most influential part of the virus is not the lust for more, but rather, the lust for more than others. The *more than you* issue is the fire under the simmering viral brew.

We all have an innate desire to grow, to become who we can become. It can be confusing, however, how to interpret what that means and how to go about it. It's so easy to get distracted, to get on the wrong path, pursuing lesser goals and being led by low-level pursuits. We want great experiences

and a meaningful life, but often get lured into desires, comparisons and pursuits that are neither meaningful nor exciting. Life becomes repetitive and numb when your greatest pursuit or desire is ultimately empty.

Pulitzer Prize finalist David Foster Wallace says you're fooling yourself if you think you don't have some that you're worshipping. Wallace explains:

In the day-to-day trenches of adult life, there is actually no such thing as atheism. There is no such thing as not worshipping. Everybody worships. The only choice we get is what to worship. And an outstanding reason for choosing some sort of God or spiritual-type thing to worship — be it J.C. or Allah, be it Yahweh or the Wiccan mother-goddess or the Four Noble Truths or some infrangible set of ethical principles — is that pretty much anything else you worship will eat you alive. If you worship money and things — if they are where you tap real meaning in life — then you will never have enough. Never feel you have enough. It's the truth. Worship your own body and beauty and sexual allure and you will always feel ugly, and when time and age start showing, you will die a million deaths before they finally plant you. On one level, we all know this stuff already — it's been codified as myths, proverbs, clichés, bromides, epigrams, parables: the skeleton of every great story. The trick is keeping the truth up front in daily consciousness. Worship power — you will feel weak and afraid, and you will need ever more power over others to keep the fear at bay. Worship your intellect, being seen as smart—you will end up feeling stupid, a fraud, always on the verge of being found out. And so on.

You might say, *I am my own person. I don't have any attachment or thing I'm addicted to. I just want to be happy.* Then perhaps happiness is your god. If that's the case, happiness will be ever elusive until your life has more meaning and desire than meeting your own needs. Your life will be a continual pursuit of more—more comfort, more acceptance, more followers, or just more busyness.

Pursuing Ghosts

In his thoughtful book *Season of Life*, Jeffrey Marx chronicles the unique coaching style of Joe Ehrmann, former NFL star turned volunteer assistant at Gilman High School in Maryland. Ehrmann's career in the NFL seemed outwardly successful, but it left him feeling empty.

Ehrmann explains:

I had expectations that professional football would help me find some kind of purpose and meaning in my life. But really, all I found in the NFL was more confusion. I kept having the belief that if it wasn't going to be this contract, I would certainly find some kind of serenity or peace in my life with the next contract, the next girl, the next house, the next car, the next award, when I got to the Pro Bowl, when we got to the Super Bowl. And what happened to me I think happens to an awful lot of professional athletes: you start losing perspective. You've kind of climbed the ladder of success, and when you get up there, you realize somehow the ladder was leaning on the wrong building.

Joe realized that he had been socialized to pursue ghosts of what he really

wanted. “The single biggest failure of society [is] we simply don’t do a good enough job teaching boys how to be men,” he says. In his desire to be a man, he pursued a false masculinity by trying to validate himself as he grew up through his athletic ability, sexual conquests, and economic success. Joe asserts:

Masculinity, first and foremost, ought to be defined in terms of relationships. Success comes in terms of relationships. The second criterion—the only other criterion for masculinity—is that all of us ought to have some kind of cause, some kind of purpose in our lives that’s bigger than our own individual hopes, dreams, wants, and desires. At the end of our life we ought to be able to look back over it from our deathbed and know that somehow the world was a better place because we lived, we loved, we were other-centered, other-focused.

Joe’s uncommon approach comes from firsthand experience in pursuit of the American dream, a dream that didn’t deliver on its end of the bargain. What Joe wanted was something more substantial than trophies, more meaningful than money. As he played pro football, he found that the alluring external symbols of success brought instant gratification but diverted his attention away from the qualities that would carry him throughout his life.

The trap Joe fell into, and the virus that afflicted him, is one that ensnares most of us. We all want to be successful, but what does that mean? Often people say they just want to be happy, but even that concept is difficult to define. We’re not very good at knowing what makes us happy, let alone

how to feel truly alive. We want real and lasting joy, peace, and fulfillment, yet every day, we are presented with potential shortcuts that undermine this pursuit. There's always something on the horizon that lures us towards temporary rewards, distracting us from the process necessary to develop inner strength.

If you have inner strength, you move out into the world with peace and confidence, no matter what your circumstances are. If your inner life is unstable, you move out into the world with weakness, no matter how much money or success you have.

It's natural to want to skip the character-developing process of your inner world. Our culture molds us into focusing on temporary, superficial goals. We easily get caught up in robotic numbness, obsessing about getting to the next level in our lives and/or careers; we lose the meaning in the process; all that matters is the bottom line, win or lose, and how we'll be evaluated or viewed by others. We wind up losing sight of the reason we want the things that we do, which are the experiences we have and the growth that results. Rather than using each performance to learn and grow, every performance and corresponding result becomes an evaluation of and constant search for self-worth.

So often we just end up chasing feelings to feel better about ourselves, becoming a slave to our impulses, rather than doing what needs to be done to build a long-term foundation for the best possible life.

The Obsession with Winning

As a young boy and eventual professional athlete, I dreamed endlessly about being the hero—hitting the game-winning home run to win the World

Series or scoring the game-winning touchdown in the Super Bowl. So when the Chicago Cubs drafted me, it was a dream come true. But my obsession with stardom brought immense pressure. I allowed my identity to become wrapped up in the Cubs uniform. My mind was filled with fear of not measuring up and not living the life I was meant to live. As a result, I became defined by my performance. My self-worth depended on how well I performed.

It's easy to confuse the excitement of winning with the experience of learning and growing and feeling alive. What I didn't realize was that what was most fulfilling wasn't wearing the Cubs uniform, hitting a baseball on the sweet spot or making a diving catch.

Winning has a deceptive fascination for us because our social-media-driven world obsesses about it. However, the fact that you won doesn't mean you were great, or at your best, or even good. Winning, you could say, is part of both the solution and the problem—it straddles the line between what you really want and the affluenza-inspired illusion of what you want. Consider a race where one athlete has a personal best time yet loses by a tenth of a second and the winning athlete does not match his personal best. Who ran the better race? While most would say the faster athlete won, perhaps it's the athlete who beat his personal best who really won.

Playing to win is a strong motivator in competition, but when winning holds more value for you than fully experiencing the moment and getting better, you'll realize so much is out of your control, and tension and doubt will be your constant companions.

The price of anything, as Henry David Thoreau said, is the amount of life you exchange for it. To trade your soul for one victory is to get caught up in society's obsession with what's fast and hot and exciting: the 454

horsepower, the Italian mystique, the paddle gearshifts, the wow factor. With no awards (or press coverage) for the discipline, self-control, and hard work that it takes to succeed, the process gets undermined.

Winning the gold medal (or Maserati) isn't great because of the medal itself. The greatness lies in the person you become, the one meant to make a difference in the lives of others, the one who sacrificed themselves to learn and grow and become someone they never knew they could become. The process of learning and growing in love, wisdom and courage—to become more fully you—through all the adversity, is what makes the achievement great.

The best teachers and coaches know that an extraordinary life is possible, so they impart skills such as discipline, courage, and sacrificial love. They value learning and growth far more than the task they're teaching or game they're trying to win. Legendary North Carolina basketball coach Dean Smith relates:

Our North Carolina players seldom heard me or my assistants talk about winning. Winning would be the by-product of the process. There could be no shortcuts. Making winning the ultimate goal usually isn't good teaching.

He adds that former University of Nebraska football coach Tom Osborne believed that focusing on winning could be an obstacle as much as a motivator. Smith points out, "So many things happened in games that were beyond our control: the talent and experience of the teams, bad calls by officials, injuries, bad luck." Defining your success based on factors out of your control undermines the process that got you there, and Smith made

sure his players knew that.

Winning and losing are so similar, yet their emotional effects on us are vastly different. For most of us, we're so attached to the outcome of our performance that it obstructs our vision and focus. We're so fixated on winning that we become afraid of losing, which takes away our freedom and joy. What we really want in life is much more than winning a game or a medal; what we want are permanent life-enriching rewards like great experiences, feeling alive, learning and growing and being challenged.

When we can “meet with Triumph and Disaster and treat those two imposters just the same,” as Rudyard Kipling said, then we won't be seduced as much by the false sense of security that winning can bring, nor will we miss the growth that losing offers. Failure is painful, but the learning and experience of failing is so valuable, we simply cannot grow into our true selves without it.

Winning isn't the best measure of success because you can't control or sustain it, and you might win, but it may not be your best effort, which lures you into laziness. If your goal is to win an Olympic gold medal or become CEO of Google, that's awesome, but as you learn *Inner Excellence*, you'll see the need for a much higher goal than that. You could use the principles and tools in this book to achieve your goal, but still feel empty. As high as those goals are, they are little lollipops when what you're created for is the whole candy store.

Five-time national champion basketball coach (Duke University) Mike Krzyzewski describes his approach:

If we're constantly looking at our win-loss record to determine whether we are doing well, we're not looking at the right barometer.

If you're always striving to achieve a success that is defined by someone else, I think you'll always be frustrated. There will never be enough championships, never enough wins. And when you finally attain them, if you're lucky enough to do so, they'll only be numbers. Somebody will say you were great or successful, but ultimately you'll know it's an empty success. The only way to get around such an unhappy ending is to continually define your own success. Your definition of success should have more depth than the equivalent of winning a national championship. It should be whatever passion moves you deep in your heart.

As Krzyzewski discovered, in the end, the biggest victory isn't about getting something shiny, fast, and lavish, winning a gold medal, a corner office, or a national championship, but rather winning the battle with yourself – the battle for your heart. In every performance we undertake, we choose between our attachment to winning and our deep desire to feel fully alive, to learn and grow and become more at peace, more stable, more able to experience powerful, fulfilling moments. Of course, this frees us up to perform with passion and perseverance—and to win more often.

In the pursuit of a courageous life, we must continually learn about ourselves—who we really are and what's truly meaningful. There's only one way to truly know freedom, and that is to find that part of yourself that longs for it and to find exactly what it longs for, beyond the temporary pleasures and possessions that possess us. We must be determined to be disciplined in ways that empower us, sacrificing pride and status for growth and experience. In this pursuit we can find a freedom that knows no boundaries, one not enslaved to the outcome or seduced by success, but

instead focused on purpose and helping others.

Key Points for Chapter 1

- There are two paths in life: a life of freedom on a narrow, risky path that involves facing your fears to pursue your dreams and true self; or a life where you travel a wider path of comfort and safety to pursue false, temporary rewards with less risk and fewer possibilities.
- Western culture is obsessed with external symbols of success, constantly pushing us to have more and be more, like a treadmill that never stops. This slowly replaces our pursuit of meaningful relationships and personal growth with temporary, superficial rewards.
- The price of fullness of life is costly, an amount we are unwilling to pay. It means doing the hard work of facing the truth about your inner life and relationships, and adjusting the lens through which you've been viewing and judging the world.
- Most of us have gotten sidetracked by our culture's definition of success and become defined by our feelings and performance, obsessing about what we want (good results) but can't control.
- People who have changed the world, according to Maslow, were able to set their hearts and minds on long-term personal growth rather than external rewards. This enabled them to develop inner strength that carried them through the tough times.
- Maslow's *selfless-actualizers* are people aware of their ego's need to

be recognized; they guard against the ego's self-protective measures that isolate rather than enhance their lives.

- Unless you have a clear system for training your heart and mind, you'll get caught up in the cultural illusion of success, moving farther and farther from the inner strength and peace that comes with having an undivided heart that reveals your true self.

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- Examine your life. Which path are you on? If you find your identity through what you do or what you have, does that give you real peace and fulfillment? If those things or achievements were taken from you, who would you be?
- Imagine you're 80 years old, looking back on your life. What was most important to you? If you continue to live your life the way you are now, will that be your legacy?
- When you've performed your best, what characteristics describe how you were feeling and what you were thinking?
- How much freedom do you feel when you're at work or home? What will it take to live and work with total freedom (even in the job you're in now)?

Where the Wild Things Are
Pride and Fear and the Center of the Universe

We Western people are apt to think our great problems are external, environmental. We are not skilled in the inner life, where the real roots of our problems lie. The outer distractions of our interests reflect an inner lack of integration of our own lives. We are trying to be several selves at once, without all our selves being organized by a single, mastering life within us.

—Thomas R. Kelly, *A Testament of Devotion*

For most people, it starts when you are a kid, probably sometime in grade school. You attempt to do something you love—perhaps you’re skilled at kickball or you play a mean recorder—and one day something changes. You start to think about it; your mind starts to butt in. Maybe you’re a basketball player about to shoot a free throw with the game on the line, and previously, you would have been completely focused and nailed it. But this time rather than just going through your routine, you think *I’ve gotta make this*. That little switch in perspective is the beginning of a lifelong battle. You go from enjoying the moment to having to succeed, your heart on one side and ego on the other.

In our consumer-oriented, social-media-obsessed society, thousands of claims on our attention come at us every day, bombarding us from the moment we wake up until the minute we sleep. We have more technology, more time-savers, and less time. This barrage of distractions takes our thoughts in endless directions—we’re constantly preoccupied, mostly thinking about ourselves. This saps our energy and distances us from our

goals, and ironically, from ourselves, in the process. Our thoughts become obstacles.

Our thoughts affect every aspect of our lives. Whether we're focused or scattered, successful or unsuccessful, fulfilled or frustrated depends on how we respond to our thoughts. Every performance we'll ever take part in will largely be shaped by this battle in the mind. We spend most of our lives with a mind doing what it wants, when it wants, and how it wants to do it—not unlike a spoiled child. What we thought was the control center (our minds) has gotten out of control. Like our bodies, our minds need to be trained, renewed daily, and rested when necessary. We need to let go of our preoccupation with self—and all the self-protective, cluttered thoughts it brings.

In this chapter we'll take on the biggest obstacle you'll ever face: your mind, or more precisely, the part of your mind that is constantly comparing and judging, always threatened but never satisfied—the ego.

The Root Cause of Fear: Self-Centeredness

In my experience as a professional athlete and coach to world-class performers, I've found that fear stifles our freedom and hurts our performance more than anything else. Fear of failure, fear of rejection, fear of not being enough. Fear, however, is only the symptom of a more complex issue. The root cause of fear is a virus of the heart: self-centeredness.

You may not think *you're* self-centered, but consider this: is not everything you think, say, and do based on *your* experiences, *your* goals, and *your* beliefs? When you've gotten upset, was it not *you* or something

that was *yours* that was threatened?

Whether you have too high a view of yourself, or too low a view of yourself, both originate from self-centeredness that creates self-consciousness, isolation, and lack of vision.

Self-centeredness shows up early. As newborns we learn that our cries get rewarded with food and attention, creating a world of cause and effect based on our needs and wants. This inherent survival method stays with us for the rest of our lives, and we never think twice about it. Until now.

Self-centeredness, in our discussion, is not about selfishness—it's not a moral issue. Rather, it's a preoccupation with ourselves that limits our options and stunts our growth. We all have a mental process for interpreting events in our lives and assigning meaning. This process looks through a lens of all our past failures and painful memories. This focus on our past and how we compare to others sets the stage for fear to thrive.

Fear is the opposite of love. It separates you from your true self. Your true self, which we'll explore later, is wholehearted, undivided by the world's temptations and seductions. While love connects and integrates, fear separates and isolates. Fear is focused on self and the future. Fear comes from projecting our past failures into the future, seeing more setbacks and uncertainty. Our focus on ourselves and our past failures fuels our fear.

Imagine facing a situation similar to one in which you've failed in the past; perhaps it's making a short putt in golf or remembering your lines during a play. Your mind, in an effort to protect you, will remind you of that failure, and this intrusive, negative memory will affect how you perform. Instead of seeing your present situation through fresh eyes as an opportunity to perform, you see it with anxiety and fear.

Self-centeredness, of course, is only natural. For your entire life you've

seen the world from only your eyes. You haven't seen what I've seen or what anyone else has seen—not from the same perspective, anyway. Moreover, your perspective is skewed based on your perception of what you've seen and experienced. Every experience you've had is compared to similar events from the past, and the meaning your mind assigned to them. This fact is not good or bad, just limiting. *It's through this biased, limited filter that we see the world, and this filter is dotted with memories of past failures.*

David Foster Wallace shares more insights (from his commencement speech at Kenyon College):

Everything in my own immediate experience supports my deep belief that I am the absolute center of the universe, the realest, most vivid and important person in existence. We rarely talk about this sort of natural, basic self-centeredness, because it's so socially repulsive, but it's pretty much the same for all of us, deep down. It is our default-setting, hard-wired into our boards at birth. Think about it: There's no experience you've had that you were not at the absolute center of. The world as you experience it is right there in front of you, or behind you, to the left or right of you, on your TV, or your monitor, or whatever. Other people's thoughts and feelings have to be communicated to you somehow, but your own are so immediate, urgent, real — you get the idea... This isn't a matter of virtue — it's a matter of my choosing to do the work of somehow altering or getting free of my natural, hard-wired default-setting, which is to be deeply and literally self-centered, and to see and interpret everything through this lens of self.

Attachment to your past and previous failures makes you self-conscious, concerned about yourself and what others think of you. If you're shooting a free throw under pressure, for example, the task is difficult not just because of the consequences of missing but also because of the thought that you would be the one who missed it. And you've certainly missed free throws before.

When we become self-conscious, we want to feel better. So, what do we typically do? We compare ourselves to others, using the five measures of worldly success linked to the affluenza virus—possessions, achievements, looks, money and status. We gauge what we have and what they have, what we've done and what they've done. Looks and achievements are especially powerful components of the ego because they're so personal. Inevitably, there is someone who has more success or is better looking, so we want more, because our identity is at stake. The affluenza virus grips us.

The problem isn't the quest for achievement; in fact, this book is about achieving the extraordinary. The problem is placing your security in things you cannot control. It's just like with winning: the problem isn't winning—every champion plays to win. The problem arises when the end result overshadows the process and you lose yourself along the way.

Losing yourself means losing touch with your true self, the one that wants to live and love fully. When we lose ourselves, we have a divided heart, one caught up in trying to please others and be successful in the world's eyes. We're unable to be fully present in the sacred moments of our lives that are sent to teach us lessons and bring us wisdom and beauty.

When our identity comes from society-defined measures of success (eg. PALMS), we become attached to them. Since we can't completely control our goals, we become needy and lose our freedom. Attached to our goals,

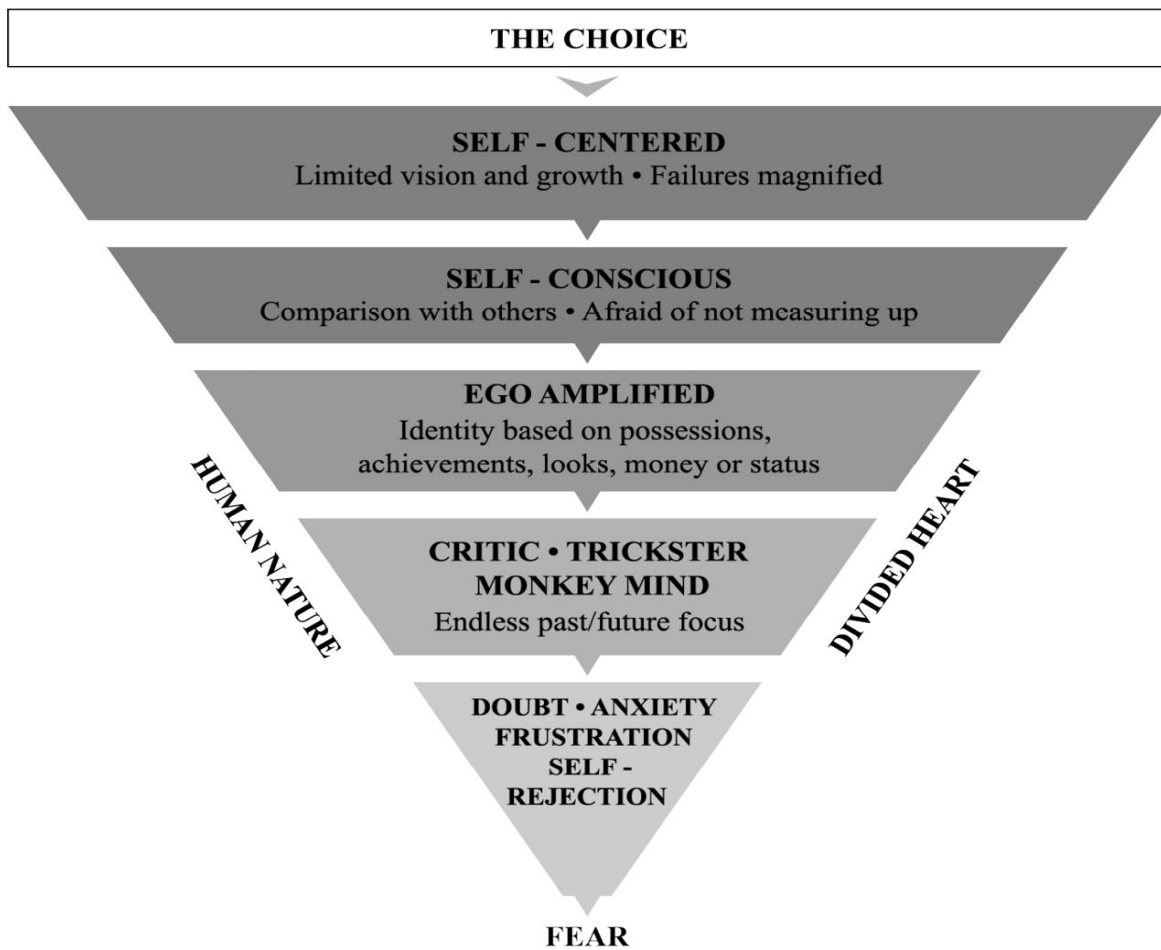
we get attached to our circumstances (life situations) in order to monitor if we're getting closer to or further from our goals—and our circumstances are what we use to measure the distance we've traveled.

As we become attached to our circumstances, and need certain things to happen, we also become attached to our thoughts. Doubtful thoughts have more power to influence when we're attached to our circumstances. (We'll discuss managing your thoughts in Chapter 6.) Frustration and anxiety emerge when what we feel has to happen doesn't happen. The gap widens between how we want to feel and what we are feeling. The doubts move from external (I won't achieve my goal) to personal (I'm not able) to identity (I'm a failure). Unchecked, our dreams get frozen in fear. If you're attached to what you want but cannot control it, frustration or fear is always near.

Self-doubt is a huge challenge, but that too is an offshoot of self-centeredness. Where do the doubts originate? Nobody can make you feel inferior, less competent, or less able unless your own mind thinks the thought, accepts and affirms it. Doubts are powered by your own thoughts as memories of past failures creep in, making you susceptible to negative influences from outside sources.

Every day we wake up with a decision to make. Will we recognize our self-centeredness and take steps away from it and toward fullness of life, or will we (by default) slide towards insecurity, doubt, and fear? With this choice comes the opportunity for courage to take action despite the fear. We'll see in the chapters to come the amazing moments that await those who bypass the easier, wider, self-centered route and choose the narrow path with the much broader field of vision.

Figure 2.1 The Path to Fear



The Obsession with Self

In our everyday life, our thinking is 99 percent self-centered.

—Zen master Shunryu Suzuki

As we see in figure 2.1, self-centeredness leads to self-consciousness, which amplifies the ego. The ego is the greatest opponent you'll ever face because it limits you to your own five senses and the knowledge derived only from your personal experiences. This narrow focus excludes the ideas,

opportunities, and connections that are possible with broader vision. When your vision is restricted by your own needs and wants, your main pursuit becomes self-serving. Life moves from learning and growing, giving and receiving, to self-preserving, hoarding and grasping.

When the ego is amplified, it wants more validation, so it looks to symbols of success. But there's always someone else who has more success than we do. So we judge them (deliver a negative verdict). In our judgment of others, we start to judge ourselves and feel less than, and we get deceived by our own mind. We hear an inner voice that whispers negative judgments about ourselves, ones that say "Who are you to be great? Or, "You're not enough." This part of our mind, the fuel for ego, is what I've labeled the Critic, the Monkey Mind, and the Trickster. We'll get into that in the next chapter.

So the ego gets amplified and turns into pride and fear, both of which steal our joy. In our definition, pride is self-conscious concern for self, or as Oxford scholar C.S. Lewis calls it, *unsmiling concentration on the self*. Pride is always concerned with how you look, how you compare, or how you are perceived. Here's how Lewis describes pride:

Pride gets no pleasure out of having something, only out of having more of it than the next person. We say that people are proud of being rich, or clever, or good-looking, but they are not. They are proud of being richer, or cleverer, or better-looking than others. If everyone else became equally rich, or clever, or good-looking there would be nothing to be proud about.

In our (self-conscious) concern for self, the ego kicks into high gear to

advance itself, but it does the opposite, killing our joy. Dr. Timothy Keller, author of *The Freedom of Self-Forgetfulness*, says pride destroys the ability to have any real pleasure. Keller explains:

The ego is always drawing attention to itself. It is incredibly busy trying to fill the emptiness. And it is incredibly busy doing two things in particular—comparing and boasting... The way the ego tries to fill its emptiness is by comparing itself to other people. All the time. Competitiveness is at the very heart of pride... When we are in the presence of someone who is more successful, intelligent or good-looking than we are, we lose all pleasure in what we had. That is because we really had no pleasure in it. We were proud of it.

Perhaps by now you're asking, what about superstar athletes and CEOs who have out-of-control egos? While fear is, I believe, the primary obstacle we all face, it doesn't stop everyone. Fear can be incredibly motivating; it is a powerful energy, after all. The catch is that for most of us, fear stops us from performing with freedom and passion. How can we be fully engaged in the moment when we're comparing ourselves with others and concerned with what they'll think? This book is about achieving extraordinary performance *and* fullness of life. An ego out of control makes that impossible.

Self-Centeredness Versus Self-Awareness

I'm not a mess but a deeply feeling person in a messy world. I explain that now, when someone asks me why I cry so often, I say, 'For the same reason

I laugh so often--because I'm paying attention.' I tell them that we can choose to be perfect and admired or to be real and loved. We must decide.

—Glennon Doyle Melton, *Love Warrior*

In our discussion, self-centeredness is a trait that blocks our growth with comparison and self-consciousness, frustration and fear. It prevents us from seeing the whole picture and divides our hearts. Self-awareness, in contrast, nurtures our growth by recognizing that we're part of a greater whole. When we're self-aware, we're able to observe our thoughts and behaviors, unattached to them, which enables us to see our place in the bigger picture, inter-connected with others. This is a powerful lens through which we can see clear enough to learn and grow into our true selves.

Self-centeredness is a nearsightedness that can't see beyond our failures and limits. We get filled with limiting thoughts of who we can't be or what we can't do. The broader view of self-awareness, however, sees options that aren't limited to our experience or rational minds. Self-awareness is the wisdom that knows your true self and vast potential are beyond what you are currently able to envision, thus helping view your circumstances objectively as feedback to continually learn and grow.

A self-centered person, for example, walks out of a meeting that went badly and tells herself she is a poor public speaker and will never be comfortable addressing a group. She looks at her peers and thinks, "If only I were more like them, I'd be able to show everyone how good I am and get ahead." She is surprised when a colleague compliments her on something she said during her presentation. She assumes that the colleague is only being nice and will probably talk about her behind her back. When the next meeting is scheduled, she dreads walking into the room. Self-centeredness

is the veil that covers our ability to see possibilities, disconnects us from others, and makes us self-conscious.

Meanwhile, a self-aware person might have come out of the same rough meeting having experienced a similar disappointment in her performance. She looks around and realizes that those who handled the situation better took more time to prepare themselves. She understands that she'll have to do the same to effectively present her ideas. Open to the compliments of her colleagues, she uses them to reaffirm her belief that her insightful ideas just require more work on the back end to be received as she intends them. When the next meeting is scheduled, she is confident. The self-aware person sees more options. There's no failure, only feedback.

The Ego's Obsession with Outcome

The ego is obsessed with winning and can never have enough. It constantly compares itself with others and is always threatened. It makes you self-conscious because it relies on the external world to validate itself. When you have fancy adornments or status or medals, you can look at them and tell yourself, "I am somebody; I've got this, or I've done that." You can project yourself into various roles and wear the masks that cover up who you really are.

When your ego takes over, you become firmly attached to the outcome of your performance and the circumstances leading up to the performance. With so much out of your control, instability gives way to anxiety and fear. Dean Smith, who coached Michael Jordan at North Carolina, said, "It's an absolute necessity for a leader to be able to handle losing. The bigger a person's job, the more losses he or she will have, and the more costly they

will be.” The ego cannot handle losing, because its identity is totally based on outcomes, and losing is a direct blow to the validation it seeks. The ego’s attachment to the outcome ignites the process of doubt and fear.

Extraordinary achievement calls for extraordinary desire and intense training, especially training your mind to focus on the process, not the result. The most productive path is to direct your desires and focus on the process of learning and growing, living out your calling, moment to moment. The ego, however, is always concerned about the future and how we compare to others in that future.

One of the aspects of self[less]-actualization as Maslow said, is to “recognize our ego defenses and be able to drop them when appropriate.” For our purposes, ego is that defensive self-regard, that part of the mind that clings to temporary pleasures, disregarding the reason you want those things. (The part of the mind that’s super confident—what we desperately want—isn’t the same).

The ego is attached to what Stanford professor Caroline Dweck describes as a fixed mindset, in which you’re always in danger of being measured by a failure. A failure can define you in a permanent way. The idea of trying hard and still failing—of leaving yourself without excuses—is the worst fear of the fixed mindset. According to Dweck, many people believe that great geniuses are not supposed to need to put forth effort, and if you try your best and fail, it robs you of all your excuses.

The Battle for Your Heart

Perhaps the question is not so much how to remove your fears, but what will you do with them? How do you manage your thoughts that lead to

those fears? David Foster Wallace discusses our sea of thoughts:

As I'm sure you guys know by now, it is extremely difficult to stay alert and attentive, instead of getting hypnotized by the constant monologue inside your own head, which may be happening right now. Teaching you how to think is actually shorthand for a much deeper, more serious idea: learning how to think really means learning how to exercise some control over how and what you think. It means being conscious and aware enough to choose what you pay attention to and to choose how you construct meaning from experience.

In the battle for your heart, your thoughts are crucial. Every day, you wake up with dreams to be realized and amazing experiences that await. Your mind, with its predisposition toward self-centeredness, will lean toward limitations, be self-conscious and attached to the needs of the ego—unless you train your heart. The good news is that you move towards what you think about, and you can start today orienting your mind and heart towards beauty and great things. Throughout history people have learned to direct their thoughts, focus their desires, and see the world as it truly is. They've learned to harness the wild frontier, where self was the center of the universe.

Key Points for Chapter 2

- Fear of being a failure is the chief obstacle to freedom and peak performance.

- Our natural preoccupation with ourselves and the attachment to our past that it brings is the root cause of this fear.
- This preoccupation with past failures leads to self-consciousness, which fuels the ego.
- In our intense, ego-driven desire to succeed, we get attached to the outcome of our goals, but we can't control them, so we become needy.
- We've never been taught how to manage our minds, and thus doubts and anxiety have more power than they should.
- Developing self-awareness is crucial to becoming the person you were created to be, so you can let go of judgment and comparison and see the world through a wholehearted lens.

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- Practice getting out of your head, focusing on your breathing and using your senses. Can you stop analyzing and just breathe? Just feel?
- How often do you find your mind in the past or future? Keep a 3x5 card in your pocket and spend a full day marking every time your mind got caught up in the past or future.
- Have you found yourself caught up in life's trivial setbacks—cut off in traffic, a parking ticket, a rude comment—or are you able to consistently rise above your circumstances and stay focused on what matters most?

- Here's an exercise to try: *Me, Myself and I*
 - Next time you go to a dinner party or social event where there will be some people you don't know,
 - see if you can go the entire night without saying anything that will put you in a favorable light
 - try to have engaging conversations while avoiding talking about yourself (except to answer direct questions), and don't use the words me, myself, or I.
 - The purpose of this exercise is to develop awareness of your ego and how hard it is to not be self-occupied and acceptance-driven.

3

The Greatest Opponents You'll Ever Face *The Critic, Monkey Mind, and the Trickster*

It is not the critic who counts; not the man who points out how the strong man stumbles, or where the doer of deeds could have done them better. The credit belongs to the man who is actually in the arena, whose face is marred by dust and sweat and blood; who strives valiantly; who errs, who comes short again and again, because there is no effort without error and shortcoming; but who does actually strive to do the deeds; who knows great enthusiasms, the great devotions; who spends himself in a worthy cause; who at the best knows in the end the triumph of high achievement, and who at the worst, if he fails, at least fails while daring greatly, so that his place shall never be with those cold and timid souls who neither know victory nor defeat.

—Theodore Roosevelt, 26th president of the United States

You may have heard that J.K. Rowling, a single mother living on welfare, was rejected by 12 publishers before getting Harry Potter published, going on to become a billionaire. Perhaps you know that Justin Rose, number-one ranked golfer in the world in 2018, missed the cut in the first 21 events of his professional career. You might even know that before Bill Belichick won six Super Bowls as head coach of the New England Patriots, he coached the Cleveland Browns to a losing record for five years and then got fired. But do you know how they overcame their adversity to become successful? Do you know what the actual battle is that *you* are facing to achieve your goals and dreams, and who your main adversaries are?

In my work with world-class athletes and other professionals, I've discovered three adversaries that have a dramatic impact on our ability to be focused and confident. The name of each adversary describes its effects: the Critic, the Monkey Mind, and the Trickster.

The Critic is that judgmental voice in your head. It delivers a negative verdict on some thing (or circumstance) or some person (often yourself), and then reacts emotionally to that judgment. (In our discussion, we define the word judge as “to deliver a negative verdict,” whereas to discern is “to use wisdom to consider the best course of action.”)

The Monkey Mind is that noisy presence in your head. It clutters your mind with too many (often negative or unproductive) thoughts on too many things, frequently leading to overanalysis and anxiety.

Finally, the Trickster is that deceptive voice in your head that lies to you. The Trickster always tries to trick you into believing in your limitations, and constantly accuses you of not being worthy of living your dreams.

The Constant Critic

Shakespeare declared, “There is nothing either good or bad in itself, but thinking makes it so.” In constantly judging and reacting to the outer world, we lose the creativity and curiosity to see the possibilities hidden by our judgments. Judgment and curiosity cannot co-exist. When we judge someone or some thing, curiosity goes out the window, and with it, creativity. Creativity is crucial to extraordinary performance, and when we lose it, we lose a lot. We need a clear mind that can see solutions under pressure, and judgement takes that away.

The Critic is obsessed with (and attached to) our circumstances. Since the

ego derives its identity from successful outcomes that bring awards and recognition, it's always looking at the events leading up to the outcomes to see if we're on track. It judges and compares our outcomes and circumstances with those of others. If it looks like we're getting closer to our goals, we feel good (temporarily); if it looks like we're further away, we feel bad. Even though we don't have all the information, so often we act as if we do, judging each circumstance, and reacting emotionally to it.

In judging our circumstances, a slew of fear-inducing questions arise: What if I lose this game? What if I fail? If my boss or coach drops me from the team? When we absolutely have to have something over which we are not in full control, we become a servant to it. In this we lose our power.

Each circumstance becomes a barometer for the Critic to judge who we are and what we have or haven't achieved. We get enslaved by our performance, or you could say, we get enslaved by the moment-to-moment feedback from the ego on how life is going in comparison to others.

Most people live in a constant state of reaction and thus struggle to reach their goals. Wisdom and insight are lost in the emotions in moments of adversity. We get blinded to the idea that hardship is part of the training we need to grow. The fact is, the effort to overcome adversity is essential for greatness.

If we can learn to let go of our attachment to results, we can stop judging every situation leading up to the results—especially the failures. Then we can see more clearly, learn, and grow.

Monkey Mind Madness

The biggest [obstacle to peak performance] for most performers, in my thirty years, is overanalysis—the tendency, for the right reasons, to start overanalyzing things, which interferes with having a total focus when performing. The second-biggest obstacle is caring too much, getting almost obsessed with having to be successful— caring so much that it interferes.

—Dr. Cal Botterill, Sport Psychologist, Perspective

From the minute we wake up to the moment we go to sleep, our minds are churning out an endless stream of thoughts. Even in sleep, the mind sorts, files, and analyzes the thoughts we had throughout the day. Most of those thoughts are about ourselves and everything that affects us, and unfortunately, many of them are unproductive or negative. These thoughts tend to repeat themselves, day after day, and turn into beliefs about what's possible and what's not, about who we are, and who we can—or probably won't—become. This cluttered, negative state does one thing that really hurts us: it crowds out the space needed to dream great dreams, to imagine possibilities. This is the Monkey Mind.

As we listen to the doubts and fears, we open ourselves up to endless chatter and analysis. Analysis is important for learning and growth, but it becomes an obstacle when we can't turn off the self-talk, especially during performance. Too often we live in our heads, missing the power that awaits when we live in our whole being, head to toe, heart and soul. We are spiritual, mental and physical beings, but so often we are led around by a mind cluttered with unproductive thoughts, missing out on the intuition that comes with a more spirit-led awareness.

Having thousands of thoughts a day, we give most of them little recognition. We have so many thoughts that we become unaware of them;

they just become a part of us. But it's a mistake to miss the massive impact each thought has.

Charlie Maher, mental skills coach for the Cleveland Indians, says a lack of awareness of our thoughts is our biggest obstacle: "Primarily it's the athletes' inability to catch their use of unproductive thoughts, unproductive ways of thinking about the situation they're in. That translates into 'What if this happens?' 'What if that happens?' 'I'm not doing well right now.' The more technical term is fusing with their language. They let their language take on a reality of its own."

Maher describes how it affects professional baseball players: "Fusing with their language is thinking a thought and creating a reality: 'What if this happens?' and 'I don't know if I can get through this inning.' So, they're creating a reality—when the real reality is there's a hitter, there's a catcher, and there may be men on base. So, when you translate that, they lose their focus, lose their composure, and become tense."

We've all created stories about ourselves, distorted by negativity, mostly without realizing it. It doesn't matter what our actual talents are if we create a story about ourselves cluttered with unproductive thoughts.

Tricky Little Lies

Another barrier is that little voice in our heads that whispers untrue thoughts, stirring up doubts and anxiety in the midst of situations we care about. When we're attached to our circumstances and invested in our goals, we don't reject the lies of the Trickster. When we let them hang around, they gather strength and attract other negative thoughts. Often these thoughts convince us that, yes, it's true, we aren't able to earn a promotion,

qualify for the next level, or live up to our potential. We allow ourselves to get tricked into arguing for our limitations.

Whether it materializes in the minds of performing artists, professional athletes, or youthful YouTubers, the message of the Trickster is generally the same: *Your worth is entirely dependent on your results.*

The Trickster says things like:

- *Look at all your failures—you're not the kind of person who achieves lasting success.*
- *You're a fraud.*
- *There's not enough to go around. You have to put yourself first.*
- *You have to self-protect.*
- *You'll get rejected if you try.*

The voice of the Trickster easily leads to overwhelm and self-rejection.

The Trickster has two main components: deception and accusation. The Trickster is so deceptive because it sounds so logical. It always has memories of past failures to support its criticisms. It knows all our weaknesses and how to push our buttons, and it pushes them whenever it can. After years of listening to these lies, it's natural to start believing some of them. In fact, The Great Trick is self-deception. The most common deception is either too high or too low a view of yourself. Either way, we lose sight of who we really are, and we become unsure of how to be authentic. In the uncertainty of who we really are, we deceive ourselves—the easiest person to deceive is yourself.

This is the main game of the Trickster: its ability to diminish our identity. Your identity is your perception of who you feel you really are, and what's

possible (or not) for you. This perception drives your behavior. Thus, we end up on a path constantly seeking validation because the need to feel ok about ourselves is so strong, we'll do anything to fill that need.

High achievers are not immune to the potential for self-rejection. Success creates high expectations and often, perfectionist tendencies. Then when we fail, we may belittle ourselves, and in doing so, be blinded to the learning we were meant to gain. Instead of being motivated to get better, the Trickster exaggerates how far short we always seem to fall and makes us feel bad about ourselves.

When we fail, it can trigger a downward slide through deeper and deeper judgments of ourselves. Sports psychologist Dr. David Coppel calls this sequence of events the D-slide:

The D-slide begins when failure goes from disappointment, "I should have done it and wasn't able to," to feeling devastated, where it spreads out to involve more areas you perceive you can't do, to feeling defeated, which means I'm helpless to change it, and finally you feel defective: "There's something wrong with me." Some people travel down the slide quickly, or in a different order, but after a while, a lot of people go straight from disappointment to defective. For those people, it increases self-consciousness, and every error adds to the bad feeling about yourself, which creates defensiveness and self-protection.

Say, for example, you lose a big sale. You're not only disappointed—a natural reaction—but also devastated because you wanted the sale so badly, you became so attached to it. The Critic tells you, "This is really bad," and

the Trickster steps in and reminds you of all your other failures, then projects even more in the future. You start to feel that you didn't just fail, but that you're a failure as a person.

Another one of the great deceptions of the Trickster is to trick us into going for lesser goals. Instead of going for the whole candy store (fullness of life), we often settle for the little lollipop (superficial rewards). It happens in many ways, but it's almost always the result of being misled. The Trickster whispers various lies and doubts, like "you can't do that," and "who are you to be great?"

Yale professor Henri Nouwen calls the negative voices in our heads one of our utmost struggles:

These negative voices are so loud and so persistent that it is easy to believe them. That's the great trap. It is the trap of self-rejection. Over the years, I have come to realize that the greatest trap in our life is not success, popularity, or power, but self-rejection.

Perhaps for Nouwen, the affluenza virus is caused by self-rejection. Because we feel we aren't enough by ourselves, we're always seeking more success and more promotions so we can have more validation, but it never lasts. Thus, it becomes an endless cycle of trying to be more and gain more, which fuels the Critic, Monkey Mind, and Trickster for more of the same.

Thoughts vs Circumstances

One of the biggest mistakes we make in our stories is confusing circumstances with our thoughts (about the circumstances). Circumstances are the facts of the situation, without opinions or emotions. Thoughts

generally have emotions and judgments tied into them, often without us noticing them. Thoughts are not facts. Thoughts are opinions.

Here's an example:

Circumstance: A global pandemic shuts down schools, cancels sporting events, puts the world in lockdown, and many people get sick and some die.

Thoughts: The world is spiraling out of control. My life is over. Will someone I know die? Everything is falling apart. It's hopeless.

Truth: During a pandemic, life is very different. Social interactions, travel, work, and school are all different. People around you may get sick and die. The truth is, however, that we are all going to die, but the much more important question is, will we fully live whatever days we have left? It's also the truth that a completely different way of life, in this season, may be the best possible thing for you and your family. Rather than judging and rejecting what you've lost or may lose, be present to what's now possible. This very thing (a pandemic) could be the perfect opportunity for you, to think deeply about your life, the path you're on, and what you want most (for you and your kids).

One skill that selfless-actualizers with *Inner Excellence* have developed is that they do not get mentally trapped by circumstances they can't control. They keep in mind two important presuppositions:

All things are here to teach me and help me—it's all working for my good.

As well as:

The problem is not the problem, the problem is the way you're thinking about it.

The Critic, Monkey Mind, and Trickster all take you out of the moment and the chance for full engagement, losing all the learning and growth inherent in it. They continually pull you to the past and future. In the past lie all your failures, in the future lie all the unknowns . It's no different at home or at the office: without knowing how to stop the judgment, deception, and endless stream of thoughts, we'll fall into the trap of limitation and negativity. Thankfully, you're about to learn the three most powerful resources to overcome the Critic, Monkey Mind and Trickster: love, wisdom and courage—and the freedom, belief, and focus that comes with it.

Key Points for Chapter 3

- The three great adversaries we all face in our efforts to be focused and confident are the Critic, Monkey Mind, and Trickster.
 - The Critic judges everything (gives a negative verdict) and reacts emotionally to it.
 - The Monkey Mind overanalyzes and gets cluttered with too many unproductive thoughts.
 - The Trickster lies to us and tricks us into settling for less.
- The Critic has power when you're attached to your goals. If your biggest goal is something you want but cannot control, the Critic will judge every person, thing or circumstance related to your goal, creating frustration and fear.
- The Monkey Mind thrives in a mind that has too many concerns, lacking one central focus or purpose.

- The Trickster is fueled by the Critic and Monkey Mind. It tricks you into believing your insecurities and accuses you of being a fake. If you're attached to your results or what people think or say, then the Trickster will give you trouble.
- Whenever you face a challenging situation, always clearly separate the circumstances (the facts of the situation free of opinion and emotion) and your thoughts about it.

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- Practice observing the Critic, Monkey Mind, and Trickster.
 - When do they seem to appear in your day? What type of circumstances?
- Spend one day each observing the three great adversaries. Journal on what you learned.
- Whenever you find yourself frustrated, ask yourself, "What are the circumstances of this situation, and what are my thoughts?" Once the two categories are separated (and no one can argue about the circumstances), then consider the solution (but not before).
- Set an alarm on your phone for this message to come up at some point during your day: "Where's your mind right now?" Then note if any of the three adversaries were taking charge of your thoughts. If so, do a reset: take two long, slow deep breaths, in through the nose, with the exhale longer than the inhale.

The Daring and the Twilight
Three Pillars of Extraordinary Performance

Love is the triumph of imagination over intelligence.

—H. L. Mencken

On July 15, 2007, Lewis Gordon Pugh stepped purposefully into his quarters on the NS Yamal, a nuclear-powered icebreaker headed to the Arctic Circle. As he put on his tiny Speedo swimsuit, he thought of the danger that lay ahead. The Russian ship swayed in the frigid, pitch-black waters through which Pugh would soon find himself swimming. Fear gripped him. Pugh was going for a world-record attempt at swimming one kilometer at the geographic North Pole, fully exposed to the icy water. It was a journey that he had first embarked on three years earlier—a journey that, in the next half hour, would change his life forever.

Professor Tim Noakes, a South African sports scientist and doctor, entered the chamber to outfit him with his core body temperature gauge. Other than a few armed guards on the lookout for polar bears, Noakes was the only person who could stop the swim; it was, in effect, the reason he was there. When a person is swimming in freezing waters, the brain goes into slow-motion mode. “It doesn’t think clearly or respond normally,” Noakes would later explain. “If the swimmer’s core body temperature reaches a certain point, there is no way to get it back. The swimmer will be swimming one moment and be sinking toward the ocean bottom the next. I had to make sure he never reached that point.” Pugh’s life, in other words, was in Noakes’s hands.

“If there was any way I could have turned back, I would have,” Pugh admitted afterward. “I looked into Tim’s eyes and saw fear, which I had never seen before. His hands shook as he was outfitting me with the temperature gauge.” Scientists around the world had said the swim couldn’t be done, that it would be life threatening. Dr. Noakes was one of the few sport scientists who said it was possible. Yet now that the swim was imminent, Noakes was scared. Maybe the other scientists were right.

Three weeks before his attempt at the North Pole, Pugh had trained at a glacial lake in Norway. The water was three degrees Celsius, significantly warmer than the waters of the Arctic Circle. The farthest he was able to get, however, was only about 600 meters.

Two days before the epic swim, Pugh and his team (he had a 29-member crew) had decided to do another trial run—and results were even more disastrous. He had not even completed a third of the distance before pain overtook him and he was forced to abort. The cells in his hands, as it turned out, had burst. “I can’t describe to you what it was like,” Pugh said. “It felt as if someone had been stomping up and down on my hands for hours.”

After his two failed test swims, Pugh had serious doubts. With his entire crew counting on him, not to mention the worldwide press calling each day for updates, the pressure was mounting. Nevertheless, Pugh was a man on a mission. This swim was bigger than he was: succeeding in his attempt at the North Pole, where the water is normally frozen over by meters of ice, would bring attention to the devastating effects of global warming.

A couple of major setbacks and the very real threat of death were not going to stop Pugh from giving it his best shot. Despite his intense fear, he went through with his bid to swim one kilometer in waters that scientists agreed would kill most people in less than a minute. This time, he

succeeded (watch it [here](#)).

How? Obviously, Pugh didn't become stronger, faster, or cold blooded in two days. The accomplishment was clearly a triumph of inner strength. The difference wasn't physical; there had to be something that clicked in him, something internal that changed everything. What led Pugh from his test-run failures, which left him engulfed in fear, to the confidence and focus that allowed him to conquer the impossible? How had he overcome his fear?

In this chapter we'll delve into how Pugh won his inner battle and how you can do the same. We'll study the three most powerful resources in the world: love, wisdom, and courage, and how they form the basis for the three pillars of extraordinary performance: lead with your heart, expand your vision, and be fully present.

In the pursuit of our most difficult goals and dreams, we all must face our doubts and fears. Fear is potent partly because of the trouble we have in pinpointing its origins, which makes it harder to address. Fear separates us from the truth—of who you are and what's possible in your life. As you familiarize yourself with how your mind works, you can learn to embrace your fear and not be frozen by it. And if your life has a purpose beyond yourself, you will be willing to take more risks than you would otherwise, empowered by a life of connection and meaning.

When the pressure is most intense, and your greatest fears are imminent, there must be something greater to navigate through the fear—something beyond your goal, beyond winning, beyond, perhaps, even death.

The Canadian Kid Who Was Always Bullied

Little George grew up in a small town in Quebec, Canada with an alcoholic father at home and bullies at school. He lived every day with the gut-wrenching threat of getting beat up after class. When he was enrolled in a martial arts class, he felt that he finally found a home, a place where he learned to face his fears. He eventually became a professional fighter, but he was still afraid. George explains:

When I was young, I thought that nervousness and fear would disappear over time. But I realized that not only does it not disappear, it gets even worse. The only thing that changed is now I accept it. I know it's going to be there. I know how to deal with it. Now, with experience, I know I'm gonna be scared when the fight is coming; I know I'm not going to sleep well the week of the fight, but I accept it.

[Early on in my career] I would freak out, sleeping only four hours the night before a fight. I put more pressure on myself, because I thought I wouldn't be able to perform my best because of lack of sleep. But now I know it's normal. I accept it. It's a suffering process that I have to go through before a fight. But it's still as bad as it was, the only difference is that I accept it now.

Georges St. Pierre went on to become world champion and one of the greatest mixed martial artists in history.

We all have fears. The great question is, what will you do with yours? If you're like most people, you move away from that which you fear—it's human nature. But this avoidance really limits your life and the greatness you were created for. We become great not by avoiding our fears or even

overcoming them, but by facing them and being willing to feel whatever emotion that might come up when we do.

The Daring and the Twilight

“Far better it is to dare mighty things, to win glorious triumphs, even though checkered by failure, than to rank with those poor spirits who neither enjoy nor suffer much, because they live in the gray twilight that knows not victory nor defeat.”

—Theodore Roosevelt, 26th president of the United States

Lewis Pugh was afraid. In fact, one thing that didn’t change in the two days between Pugh’s crushing failures and his stunning success was fear. After his second failed test swim, he thought, “At best, I will lose a few fingers; at worst, I will die.” He desperately wanted to turn back and give up. It was not until the moment he stepped out onto the sea ice that his fear turned into aggression. How was he able to overcome his fear, depression, and doubt?

Before we examine how he did it, it may help to look at why he would do it. He asked himself that very question over and over: “What pushes somebody?” he asked. “I’m not a lunatic; I’m not a madman. I’m a lawyer. I have a lot of experience in swimming. What pushes somebody to sail all the way to the North Pole—seven days of sailing—and stand there on the ice, and take the jump, when even the experts say you could very well kill yourself?”

Why would anyone purposely risk death? It seems there are three possible reasons someone may do so:

- For a purpose beyond the individual (some bigger cause, or to save or help others)
- To feel alive in a way that can be experienced only when the risk is high enough, perhaps close to death, where it requires full concentration: to be fully present
- Lack of concern for oneself

What animates [mountain] climbers is not a death wish, but a life wish, a desire to truly live—fully, intensely, completely. I have never met a group of people more truly alive—physically, emotionally, intellectually, spiritually. Rather than courting danger for its own sake, they do so as a means of deepening and enriching their experience.

—**Nicholas O’Connell**, *Beyond Risk: Conversations with Climbers*

Fear is designed to help us; it protects us from danger and helps us focus. However, fear (and other emotions) can get out of control. There is so much energy in fear that it can be crippling. Pugh, on the other hand, was able to use the energy from fear to empower him. When he stepped onto the ice at the North Pole, a sense of confidence and intensity came over him. Something clicked when he felt the bitter cold: “I was in a totally different zone. I walked off the ship, and somehow, for the first time ever, I felt so confident that this thing was going to happen.” His “self” faded to the background and he became so connected with the mission and his team that he was again ready to risk his very life to accomplish his purpose.

What Pugh did was connect with something bigger than himself. The swim was his way of using his gifts to make a positive difference in the

world. Pugh found something that was so compelling to him—the devastation of global warming—that he was willing to give his life for it. In doing this, he found a way to face his fears and truly live.

Self-Mastery and the Pursuit of Greatness

To truly live, according to Maslow, is to seek self-actualization. It's the final stage of personal development. In Chapter 1, I relabeled this stage *selfless actualization* and defined it as achieving the highest calling possible—being your true self as you serve others and live with fullness of life. There is a Greek word that describes this phenomenon: zoe.

Zoe is the state of being possessed of vitality, with absolute fullness of life, real and genuine, active and vigorous. It's the full potential of your inner life, the generator of intense beauty and passion.

Zoe is the full expression of love, wisdom, and courage. These three resources are intimately interconnected—you can't fully experience one without some of the other two. When you experience all three together, zoe unfolds in wholehearted, sacred moments.

Often our lives are entangled in pursuits and motivations that seem alluring but take us away from what we want most. These pursuits divide our hearts as we try to fill our lives with success and happiness, but every achievement brings only temporary satisfaction. Most people don't actually know what they want most, besides material success.

I know, however, that as you're reading this, you're realizing that the greatest possible life is one filled with love, wisdom and courage. Love is fearless, wisdom creates the best long-term decisions and courage does it all with boldness and grace under pressure. These three virtues are the

foundation for fullness of life, as well as extraordinary performance.

The three crucial characteristics to master any performance are:

1. **Belief**
2. **Focus**
3. **Freedom**

Just like the acronym best friends forever, BFF stands for something memorable as well: the three vital aspects of high performance. *Belief* separates the best from the rest; *focus* is your ability to have heightened awareness in the present moment; and *freedom* is your ability to be bold and take risks, holding nothing back.

To play with freedom means to play your sport or instrument or role like you did when you were a kid on the playground, with no concern for people's opinions or how you compared—playing with unconditional love, not loving it *if* you did well or may get some award.

The word compete comes from the Latin *competere*, which means “to seek together; strive in common; coincide.” True competition means two (or more) rivals are playing the game they love together. Great performers love competition in and of itself—it's an opportunity to feel alive.

Genuine competition isn't an event to see if you can beat your opponent or to see who is better, but an event in which people who love the same thing get to experience how well they can push each other to develop self-mastery by learning and growing in love (freedom), wisdom (belief) and courage (focus).

Consider the Olympic Creed: “The most important thing in the Olympic Games is not to win but to take part. Just as the most important thing in life

is not the triumph but the struggle. The essential thing is not to have conquered but to have fought well.” We might add this: “...to learn and grow to be your true self, to fill your heart with love, wisdom and courage in order to live an extraordinary life.”

To live among the daring rather than the gray twilight requires a different mindset and way of living. Those who do so are unique in three primary ways:

1. They know who they are (created for glory).
2. They think, talk and act differently from everyone else.
 - a. They have strict boundaries around their routines, around who they associate with, what they talk about, and what they focus on.
 - b. They continually re-orient their hearts away from surface-level rewards and the shiny things the world says are prestigious, instead preferring to build something that lasts: a powerful inner world.
3. They crave greatness—and the glory they were created for. Rather than conforming to the world and its version of success, they surrender their very lives, sacrificing temporary pleasures, acceptance and comfort. When the rest of the world is sipping hot cocoa next to a warm fire, they’re out facing their fears in a way the world says is crazy.

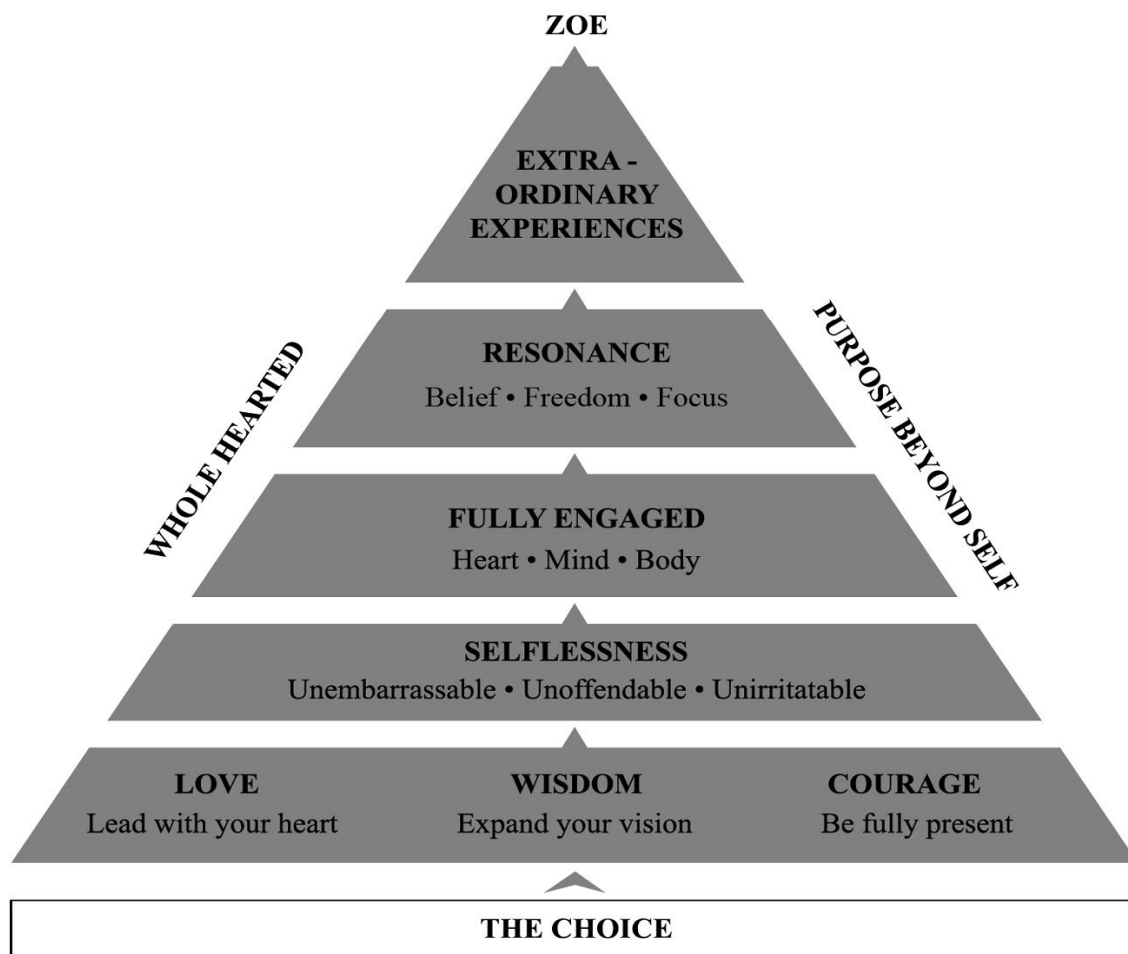
When you realize that every material possession and award you obtain on earth is but a faint glimmer of a life filled with love, wisdom and courage, you’ll crave that fullness of life first and foremost, and let everything else be added to you (your success and accolades will all be by-products). This pursuit doesn’t take away from time spent working on your craft—in fact, it may increase it. It provides a deep inner strength to go directly for what

you're ultimately after.

An extraordinary life doesn't necessarily mean you break world records or that you need to be a professional athlete. Your extraordinary destiny may be as a makeup artist or a monk (or both). You can be a janitor or an Olympic champion. Whatever your role or status, your life can be filled with deep meaningful relationships and great experiences. We can all pursue and live with zoe—absolute fullness of life.

Let's look at the choice you have each day and the path to zoe. See figure 4.1.

Figure 4.1 **The Path to zoe**



Leading with your heart is developing the self-awareness needed to live with passion and be your true self. It means clarifying how you want to feel and live and who you want to become—who you were meant to become. It means learning to love unconditionally, because this kind of love—the only real kind—is fearless. Leading with your heart brings freedom.

Expanding your vision is seeing beyond yourself; having a purpose beyond your goals, being part of something greater than yourself, and continually expanding your belief to drive your growth. Expanding your vision brings wisdom.

Being fully present is being fully engaged in the moment, having a clear mind and unburdened heart, with no needs or self-concern. Being fully present brings courage and reveals beauty that creates a sense of gratitude.

To continually lead with your heart, expand your vision, and be fully present is to seek self-mastery. Mastery is the pursuit of personal growth, to learn how to live with love, wisdom and courage, and ultimately, zoe. Thus, self-mastery is to pursue zoe directly as your greatest goal; this enables you to let go of attachment to every other goal, which gives you the greatest chance of achieving them.

Mastering the Ego in Pursuit of Zoe

As I've shared with you, your biggest adversary is your ego, the part of your mind that is always threatened, always comparing and never satisfied. The ego is in direct opposition to your pursuit of mastery and zoe.

Here are some reality checks to see how much your ego is influencing you:

- You're worried about what people think of you.
- You're nervous about doing or saying something embarrassing.
- You're more concerned with being right and appearing smart than learning the truth and being wrong.
- You're obsessed with winning more than fully experiencing the moment and getting better.
- You're offended or angry when you felt embarrassed or humiliated.

Here are some ways to recognize if you're learning self-mastery:

- The rhythm of your life has more space in it, with more compassion and less impatience.
- You're becoming less caught up in your mind, developing non-judgmental awareness, knowing that you don't know what is truly best for you (circumstance-wise).
- You're less attached to your results, wanting to learn and grow and get better more than being recognized for your accomplishments.
- You're becoming more concerned with empowering others than you are with having your own power, status, or recognition.
- You listen more than you speak.
- You're developing strict daily routines that help you lead with your heart, expand your vision, and be fully present.

The ego has certain needs and when those needs aren't met, we get embarrassed, offended, or irritated. The ego says we need to always appear graceful, smart and successful (not embarrassed), respected (not offended), and comfortable (not irritated). That's why the five factors of the affluenza

virus are so attractive, because they seem to increase how smart and successful we appear. We can look more beautiful, gain more respect, and be more comfortable. Or so the ego will tell us.

When I think of self-mastery, I envision mastering the ego by becoming three things:

1. Unembarrassable: to be completely humble/selfless, where nothing you or anyone else could say or do would embarrass you or reduce your sense of well-being.
2. Unoffendable: to be completely humble/selfless, where people's words or actions don't push your buttons or make you angry; to have self-control, not be self-protective.
3. Unirritatable: steadfast, calm and compassionate (to other people's flaws); fully present to the beauty and possibilities that always await.

To be unembarrassable is to get to the point where no mistake or foolish words or actions (by yourself or others) can make you feel less of a person, making you want to run or hide. When you're embarrassed, it's simply concern for self. The more embarrassed you are, the more worried you are about your image. Humiliation is a mental construct. Otherwise, how can two people experience the exact same thing where one person is traumatized and the other simply laughs it off? Humility isn't thinking less of yourself; it's thinking of yourself less, reducing the self-protection and fear that comes from a self-centered life.

To be unoffendable is to be so selfless (and therefore fearless) that no one could say or do anything to threaten your sense of self and steal your peace and presence. When you're unoffendable you have the freedom to live life

unattached to the words or actions of anyone you might encounter. In our social-media-directed world, the new normal is a life of comparison. When we're constantly comparing, we often feel not enough, which causes self-protection, which leads to being easily offendable. When this is the case, we're always one comment away from conflict, just a puppet on a string, pulled in whatever direction someone's words or actions may direct us.

You might say, well, what if someone is totally rude to me or takes advantage of me? Then the best course of action is to use wisdom to discern how to proceed; don't allow their lack of wisdom to become yours. The purpose of your life should always be what's guiding your life—in every single moment—not letting the ego push purpose aside for some temporary circumstance or event. If you want to live an extraordinary life, you cannot let other people's words or actions take you out of your rhythm or flow.

Most people set their sights way too low, and if you're reading this book, your dreams are probably larger than average. The bigger your goals are, the smaller your group of peers becomes. Less and less people will be willing to sacrifice what you're willing to sacrifice. They won't have the same discipline or boundaries as you. This does not mean you're better than them, it just means you need to be careful who you spend time with, because you're becoming like the people you spend the most time with. It also means there may be more people who can't relate to you or will judge you. You need to be emotionally prepared for this if you want to do extraordinary things. You can't get caught up in the negativity and irritations of little lollipop lives if you want to live the best possible one for you.

To be unirritable is to be at a place where no person or circumstance can take away your presence. It's freedom from having to have things a certain

way. Perhaps it's being tailgated (someone driving close to your bumper behind you) or when people are late to meet you or maybe the Wi-Fi is slow or intermittent. Maybe someone's choice of words are inappropriate. Life is full of moments that can steal our focus and freedom. It's easy to let some person or event hijack your emotions. When that happens, you've gotten consumed by the circumstance; some words or event unrelated to your true self took away your options and got you out of your flow.

As we work on mastering our egos, we move towards the ideals of becoming unembarrassable, unoffendable, and unirritable. In this we become unstoppable. It may not be something you ever completely master, but it's a pursuit worthy of your energy because the closer you get to it, the more freedom, focus and belief you'll have.

Dreams Versus Goals

The words *dreams* and *goals* are often used interchangeably, but here we differentiate. Goals are external outcomes that are not in your full control: get a raise, win a match, hit .300, become CEO. Dreams are feelings. We set goals in order to get the feelings we want. Winning a championship is amazing because of the feeling of happiness in the moment and satisfaction for all the work we put in. It's not the trophy or medal that does it—that's just the symbol. What we really want are ways to use our gifts and passion to feel truly alive—that's living our dreams.

Dawn Staley was a professional basketball player who won three gold medals in the Olympic Games. She describes her perspective in preparation for the Olympics:

Winning the gold medal is my goal, not my dream. My dream is

about playing to win as often as possible with and against the best women basketball players in the world. Winning the gold medal as a goal gives me some direction, but my dream is something I need to live every day. And I'm doing that each time I play to win... When I'm playing to win, that's when I feel resonance. If I win, that's great. I want to win, and having the gold medal as my goal forces me to play to win. But what I love to do, what my dream is, is to play to win.

Dawn loves playing to win; that's when she feels alive. When the game is over, it's over. Wins or losses are just feedback—the real joy and passion is in the playing. If you can truly play—without attachment to what happens when it's over—it creates such a positive energy that it resets the nervous system (totally recharges you). If there's one art that has become more and more lost in our busy lives, it's the ability to play like a kid, completely free.

Another way to think of this positive energy, the kind similar to a kid playing with complete freedom, is *resonance*. In physics, resonance is a state in which frequencies align. It is a dynamic force, able to produce the world's most beautiful musical harmonies at one end of the spectrum and shatter glass at the other. To be fully engaged in the moment, with a clear mind and unburdened heart, is to experience resonance.

Resonance has moments that are so amazing they can best be described as sacred. When you have resonance, your performance is effortless, and the outcome takes care of itself. Extraordinary performance is merely a subset of extraordinary experience; great results are the by-product of resonance. The key to extraordinary performance, then, is to build on a foundation that

creates the conditions for resonance.

The pursuit of self-mastery is the pursuit of mastering your ego so you can be your true self. Your true self follows from being fully engaged and whole-hearted, creating the energy of resonance. This energy is the rhythm of the zoe life.

Love: Lead with Your Heart

What your true self is and why it's important

Leading with your heart is striving to be your true self, who you were born to be, so you can experience absolute fullness of life. Leading with the heart connects with the most fundamental law of the universe:

If you cling to your life, you'll lose it; but if you give up your life for others, you'll find it.

Human nature is self-centered. If you live your life on the default setting, you'll constantly be trying to gain more for yourself in an attempt to be happy, but it never fulfills (remember Maslow and the Maserati?) You'll end up going in the opposite direction, living with anxiety and stress. However, if you devote your life to a purpose beyond yourself, and commit to raising the level of excellence in your life in order to raise it in others, you'll gain fullness of life. Then you can perform with freedom *and* achieve extraordinary things.

Consider the nine characteristics Maslow used to describe the high achievers from Chapter 1: total absorption in the moment, personal growth, self-awareness, Gemeinschaft (building community), gratitude, authenticity, solitude, purpose, and lack of ego. These characteristics exemplify leading

with the heart. While it's a very selfless way to live, in a way it's also very selfish because it has by far the greatest personal rewards. It's very costly, however. It takes intention and sacrifice, and the willingness to give up comfort and self-concern. It means letting go of neediness and entitlement so you can do great things.

Clinging to your life comes from seeing the world through a zero-sum, finite lens. Zero-sum means we're all eating one pie, and there's only so much of the pie to go around: when the last piece is taken, there's no more bites of apple, no more whip or cream. Until you realize that the best possible life (with the most freedom, confidence and joy) is had when you let go of self-protection and personal gain, your vision will always be limited, continuously comparing and constantly threatened. Giving up your life for a greater purpose creates an expansive awareness as you remove self-concern, connect deeply with others, and see unlimited possibilities. In this way, you can have the whole pie, and not just apple, but pumpkin, and cherry pies too. And cheesecake perhaps.

Leading with your heart starts by pursuing the self-awareness necessary to develop your true self. Your true self is the greatness within you that sees clearly, loves deeply, and lives fully. Your true self has unknown, unlimited possibilities. You bring to the world something no one else in the world can. No one has your gifts, your connections, and your unique energy and lens through which you view the world.

To be fearless you must be selfless, otherwise you'll always fear losing some thing, or some part of yourself. To be selfless you must develop inner strength to walk by faith, not by sight, to end your reliance on stable circumstances or what others think of you. The more you do this, the more your life becomes a spiritual one of faith and fearlessness, rather than a

physical and mental one of fear and scarcity.

When you lead with your heart you have the capacity to see beauty and make connections only you can. You can connect ideas and people and dreams that no one else can. Leading with your heart gives you the courage to be bold and perhaps risk looking foolish if it means living your purpose and pursuing your dreams.

Here's a comparison of a typical competitive mindset vs leading with the heart:

Typical Competitive Mindset:

I want to beat you—whatever it takes. If you trip or make a mistake, all the better. I just want to win, that's all that matters.

Leading With the Heart Mindset:

I want to bring you my best so I can push you to be your best. I am relentless in my pursuit of excellence. This helps me in every area of my life, not just sports or business. I don't want you to make mistakes, I want you to learn and grow and be excellent as well. I want to win, but even more I want to devote myself to a worthy goal, which in this moment is the pursuit of excellence, to be unconditionally grateful, to be humble so I can see clearly, to have a heightened awareness of truth and beauty. I want to share that truth and beauty with you and the world—even while you're desperately trying to beat me.

Leading with the heart is about unconditionally loving your work, your opponents, your teammates, and yourself. It doesn't mean high-fives all day long (although lots of high-fives are pretty awesome), or that you always like your work or everyone around you (you don't have to like someone to

love them). It means your standards for what you believe is possible match your level of respect for others and yourself, and so you set strict boundaries around your thoughts, your training, and your environment (more on that in Chapter 6). It means you don't change your actions and habits based on circumstances or feelings, they change only when needed to stay true to your purpose and your pursuit of excellence.

Unconditional love and why it's important

Our hearts are wired for love and connection. It's our deepest need and greatest power. Love is the lens that sees great possibilities and the interconnectedness of life. To love unconditionally means to bring fearless energy to situations you face without judging it. It means living according to your purpose and greatest values, independent of circumstances that continually change. Fear is a self-centered, future-oriented feeling, whereas love is an others-centered, present and powerful energy. When fear and love go head to head, love always wins, if it's relentless.

This unconditional kind of love—the only real kind—has no concern for self. Ironically, when you have no concern for self, you're able to take much greater care of yourself. Your awareness gets heightened and possibilities are revealed that were previously overshadowed by problems.

With no concerns for self, worries evaporate, and anxieties and fear retreat. When you love yourself (in a grateful, humble way), you devote your life (sacrificially) to others, raising the level of excellence in your life in order to raise it in others.

Let's consider an example of unconditional love in everyday life. Imagine it's rush hour and you're driving in heavy traffic. You let someone cut in front of you. That's a loving thing to do. If you're looking for a wave of

thanks, then your love just became conditional. It's like walking down the street and giving a smile to a stranger. That little act of love is conditional if you gave it but got upset when they ignored you or gave you a nasty look in return. What if you let someone go in front of you in heavy traffic, or smile at someone with no attachment to their response? Then you've stepped into your power. You became a little more fearless because you've generated a powerful energy that wasn't reliant on how the other person responded.

To lead with your heart is a journey towards greatness. It's the path of passionately pursuing (sometimes painful) growth over outcomes, to seek out your true self in order to live and love fully. Leading with your heart is to be on a mission to find out what's possible in your life, to discover who you can become and how you can raise the level of excellence in your life in order to raise it in others. It's setting strict boundaries around your energy and what you focus on, guarding your heart from comparison and resentment, fear and frustration. Paradoxically, this path of love towards others (and consequently, yourself) leads to the greatest outcomes in your own life.

If you're a performer, leading with your heart means embracing with gratitude every aspect of your work unconditionally, including the discomfort and perhaps suffering that may be involved in training. It means loving your work not just for what you can get out of it (perhaps a corner office or a big payday) but for who you can become while pursuing self-mastery. When you practice your sport or craft with unconditional love—especially the mundane or painful parts—then you can perform extraordinarily, because outcomes won't define you and failure won't finish you.

Wisdom: Expand Your Vision

With the Bulls I've learned that the most effective way to forge a winning team is to call on the players' need to connect with something larger than themselves," Jackson said. "Even for those who don't consider themselves 'spiritual' in a conventional sense, creating a successful team—whether it's an NBA champion or a record-setting sales force—is essentially a spiritual act. It requires the individuals involved to surrender their self-interest for the greater good so that the whole adds up to more than the sum of the parts.

—Phil Jackson, NBA Hall of Fame basketball coach

Expand your vision, beyond your own thoughts and experiences, and you'll see more of reality. The truth is, if you were to see ALL of reality, you would be overwhelmed by beauty—it would be too much to comprehend. However, to see more of reality, and thus more beauty and more possibilities, is essential to extraordinary performance and fullness of life.

We often miss so much of reality (and its beauty) because we're caught up in the distractions of the Critic, Monkey Mind and Trickster. To see the most beauty (and possibilities in our lives), we must pursue wisdom. Wisdom is the deep truth about who you are, why you're here, and what's possible in your life. Wisdom and an expansive vision go together.

To expand your vision is to find a purpose beyond yourself—even if it's just to experience fullness of life and share it with others. As you develop more awareness, you'll see the interconnectedness of all humanity, which will increase your compassion and deepen your relationships. Your awareness will help you recognize the blinding effects of self-centeredness,

pride, and ego, and will show how humility is the foundation for extraordinary experiences.

When you are completely humble, you cannot be humiliated. There's no ego to be wounded. Without the threat of embarrassment or humiliation, you're free to explore possibilities, to risk failure and be able to get up quickly when you fall.

Humility is an accurate view of self; freedom from self-inflation or self-rejection.

An accurate view of self is to realize that 90% of anything good in your life that you have or have done, was given to you. You might say, "You're crazy, I've worked hard and never gave up and did this and that." But where did you get the mind and energy to work so hard? You didn't choose the country you were born in, or your family or coaches, or your teachers or genetics. What if you were born in Afghanistan during the Mongol invasion, or in 1840s Ireland during the potato famine? It wouldn't matter how hard you worked, your life would be a struggle. An accurate view of self always leads to gratitude.

Humility and confidence are not often linked, but they should be. To be fearless (in the same regard—to face your fears) is to be selfless, so there's nothing fear (or anyone) can steal from you. Humility takes self out of the center of your universe and puts love in its place. Love is fearless. This trade of self-concern for love greatly expands your vision. The most powerful person is the one who has nothing to lose and everything to gain, who has no self to defend and a great purpose to pursue. This is humility.

The self-actualizers Maslow studied (discussed in Chapter 1) learned that to reach their highest goals meant to connect with others, learn from them, and help them. University of Chicago professor Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi

(pronounced chick-sent-me-hi), who has studied thousands of top performers in his research on flow and creativity, concluded, “To achieve peak performance you should have a strongly directed purpose that is not self-seeking.”

When you connect deeply with others, you capture their vision and see further and greater things. It gives you more power to expand your beliefs and overcome the adversities you face. The power within is your freedom of choice, to choose to see beyond your temporary needs and desires. First, though, you must let go of temporary things so you can get a hold of the greatness awaiting you and let your true self emerge.

As I shared earlier, Lewis Pugh swam at the North Pole not for the glamour or money, but for the effects of global warming, specifically the dying coral reefs he saw up close through his goggles. It was a purpose beyond himself that gave him the courage to face death.

Pugh’s connection to his team was another major factor in his epic achievement. After his failed attempt just before the big swim, his performance coach, David Becker, took him to the front of the ship and devised a plan:

Your team consists of 29 people from ten nations. I’m going to put one of their flags at every hundred-meter mark. The first flag will be the Norwegian flag, because that will get you into the water. [Pugh is British, a rival of Norway.] The second flag will be the Swedish flag, and then the Russian flag, and then the Canadian flag, and so on and so forth, until you get to the British flag at the end. All I want you to do is to think about those people who have sacrificed so much for you, who’ve inspired you so much that you’re actually

here today. And when you stand at the start, all I want you to think about are the Norwegians on your team. Just think about the hundred-meter mark. Please, Lewis, do not think about doing a kilometer; you will never make it. Break that beast down into little manageable chunks, and when you get to the Norwegian flag, forget about the Norwegians and just think about the Swedes, and so on until you get to the end.

When you find a purpose that provides you with its own reward simply by the act of pursuing it, then you'll be empowered. If that purpose serves the greater good, it will provide meaning in your life. A purpose beyond yourself moves your identity from what you have and what you've achieved to serving others; your value increases and your concern for self decreases.

Lewis achieved what he did because of unconditional love. If it was conditional on feelings or admiration or outcomes, he would have given up. It was for a purpose beyond self, about important truths not temporary transactions.

Courage: Be Fully Present

The courage of a master is measured by his willingness to surrender.

—George Leonard, *Mastery*

Lewis Pugh had to be fully present in order to swim in freezing waters. He couldn't think for a second about how cold the water was, or about the likelihood that most people would die in a minute or two in water that cold. To be present like that under life-and-death circumstances took a lot of

courage.

Courage is the ability to be fully present in adversity. Being fully present allows you to learn the lessons that life brings to teach you; you can gain the wisdom on how to live with passion and lead with your heart. This isn't an easy undertaking, however. It's difficult to be present when fear and comparison exist all around you. It requires serious mettle to be present and true to self in a world trying to make you like everyone else. If your goal is to perform extraordinarily, you need to learn how to be fully present in the most intense situations.

If your focus is outcome-oriented, something in the future that you don't have full control over, then it can be hard to have courage. But if your focus is to share something beautiful with the audience, then courage comes easier. Sharing something beautiful, even if it only takes the form of perseverance in the midst of adversity, helps you focus on being fully present.

Courage is gained by setting key process goals you can control so you can improve and be successful every day. Rather than obsessing about the result (or having your best performance), redefine success by focusing on the process of daily improvement. At the end of the day ask yourself how you did with these four process goals:

The Fearless Four

Daily Process Goals

1. Give my best (100% of what I have today).
2. Be present.

3. Be grateful.
4. Focus on my routines and *only* what I can control.

When you realize the absolute dependence extraordinary results have on your inner world, you'll learn to focus on the crucial components (like these four process goals) that lead to extraordinary performance. Like Lewis Pugh and his flags placed every hundred meters along his one-kilometer route, break your goals down into little manageable chunks. You'll find, as Lewis did, that the results will take care of themselves.

In 2019 one of my PGA Tour golfers began a routine of meeting his caddie before every round and going over these four goals for the day. After reviewing the goals, they took a minute of silence to visualize themselves pursuing those goals that day. After several weeks of doing this, it paid off. They won (over \$1 million USD).

We all want to win. The question is, what's the best process to win and be your best? Being your best occurs most often when it's a by-product, not the end goal. Sometimes athletes confuse giving their best vs being their best. I spoke to Frosty Westering, Hall of Fame football coach, to help us clear that up.

Frosty Westering Defines the Three Types of Best

The question is, doesn't everyone want to be number one? Well, we all want to win, but it depends on how we define winning, and how we understand the joy of competing, without the fear of failure. Defining what best is, is a key thing. Society says we won four national championships, but we also lost four; but the ones that we

lost were great games, just terrific games. What I've done is try to take the three definitions of best and lay them out in a way that our guys understand it.

First is being *the* best. That's what everyone talks about. Being the NBA champion. When you win it, you're everything; when you don't, you go home a loser. I don't believe that at all, but that's something you've got to challenge. Being the best is a by-product of other things.

The second definition is being *your* best. Well, how do you know what your best really is? I think that's really the key in coaching—to try to help a person reach his or her potential, whatever that is. So, you ask, "How do you measure potential?" There's all these fitness tests that they run—speed, agility, things at the combine—but there's another one, the inner game, the inside test, which is even greater than these.

(Note: the combine is a week-long showcase for prospective NFL football players to be evaluated by NFL teams).

[In football] you gotta be able to run, you gotta be able to hit and do all these other things, but the bottom line is, those are not what really make the difference. Parents tell their kids to do their best, but so many times we aren't our best. We try hard, but we're not our best. So, we have to figure out another way that you can deal with competing, and again understanding that we may not be the best, we may not be our best, but we can accomplish one thing, and that's the

third definition . . . which is your best shot.

Your *best shot* is just preparing to do what you've gotta do and going out and loving doing it, even if you aren't doing very well. You love doing it because you've worked hard, and you understand that that's what makes you better. And when you do that often enough, even when you're not doing it very well, and you're surrounded by others that believe that, you start bringing out the best in each other. That's what I call the double win.

The double win is bringing out the best in teammates and yourself. When you do that, even though you're not your best, they help you bring that out, because on a given day, you never know who it is that's gonna be right there. You learn to give it this best shot in everything you do, even when it isn't very good. So, then you take a look at how that relates to being the best. By giving it your best shot all the time and loving to compete, you start doing your best more of the time, and you become the best more often.

**—Frosty Westering, Pacific Lutheran University football
coach, four-time national champion**

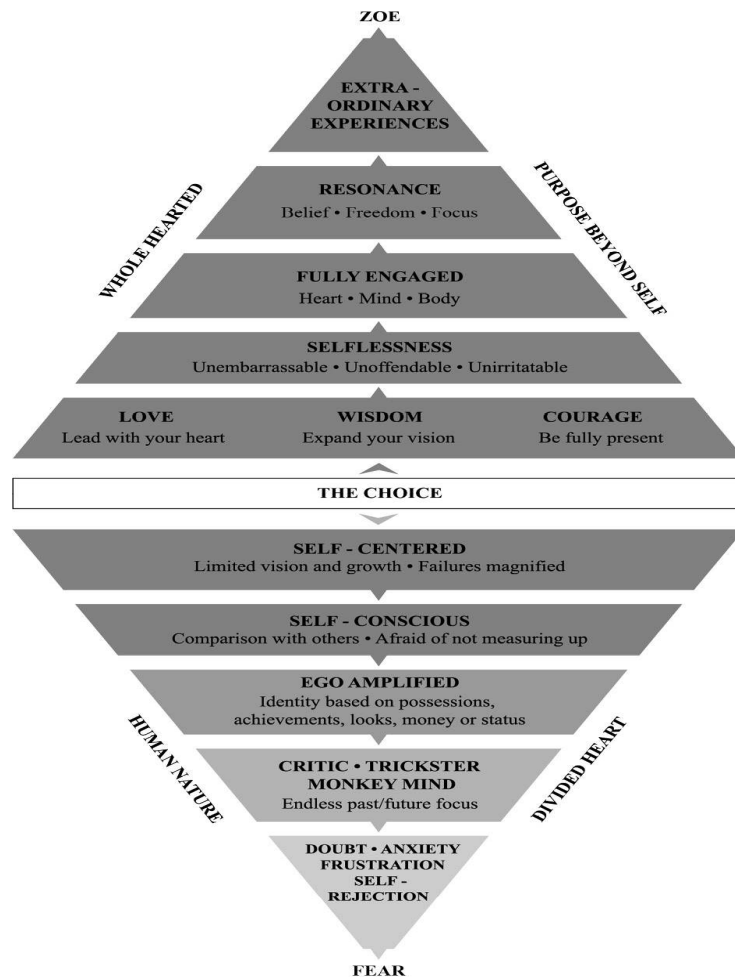
In the four daily performance goals above, to give your best means give your best shot—the best of whatever you have that day. It may not be very good. You may be only 40% of your regular self today—perhaps you have a nagging injury, a bit of a cold, and your pet turtle just died—but you can give 100% of that 40%. If you do, then that's success.

The Life Diamond and the Pursuit of Zoe

Every day, we wake up with a choice: do we let our natural self-centeredness and ego lead us toward doubts and fears, or do we choose to focus on love, wisdom, and courage? If we don't make a conscious decision, we'll inevitably follow our natural inclination down the pyramid.

We covered the self-centered path toward fear in chapters two and three and the purpose-filled path towards zoe in this chapter. Let's see how it comes together in the Life Diamond shown in Figure 4.2.

Figure 4.2 The Life Diamond



In summary, fear is overcome through love, wisdom, and courage. These

three pillars are the foundation for the self-mastery that enables us to be true to ourselves and live with passion, purpose, and poise. Mastery reveals itself in our ability to be fully present with a positive energy. This positive energy is enhanced by focusing on the process of daily improvement (not the outcome) and the purpose of your life.

The Purpose and the Process

To focus on the process (of daily improvement) and not the result is to target the three pillars of *Inner Excellence*—love, wisdom and courage—as described above. Love, wisdom and courage help you live out the purpose of your life.

When I say the purpose of your life, I mean what you value most and what makes you come alive. For me (the author) my purpose is to share God’s love, wisdom, and courage with athletes and leaders around the world. There is no one more filled with life than someone who is living out a purpose built around sacrificing self to serve others. It’s a very powerful, positive energy.

The journey toward zoe, absolute fullness of life, becomes more about the experience than the outcome, more about relationships than circumstances. The pursuit of zoe is to go directly after what matters most in your life. For this you seek a purpose for your life beyond yourself, which is the key to the fearlessness that’s waiting for you. When the end of your life draws near, you’ll look back with no regrets, with peace and fulfillment. This is zoe.

Key Points from Chapter 4

- There are three pillars of excellence that overcome fear and form the foundation for mental strength and an extraordinary life: love, wisdom, and courage.
- Love is to lead with your heart, wisdom is to expand your vision, and courage is to be fully present, all of which lead to resonance and extraordinary experiences.
- Pursuing the three pillars of excellence is to pursue self-mastery.
- Redefining success is crucial to reaching your potential. Focus on the four key process goals every day.
- Your best shot (best effort) is something you can do no matter how you feel, which helps you stay present and have courage.
- Self-mastery is mastering the ego, the part of you that wants to look good, not be good, the part that's always threatened, always comparing. To master the ego is to be:
 - Unoffendable
 - Unembarrassable
 - Unirritatable
- Resonance is to be fully present, using your gifts, challenged and connected to your true self.
- There are two critical components to being fearless: a purpose beyond yourself and unconditional love.
- Zoe is absolute fullness of life, the selfless-actualization of those who

are true to themselves.

- The greatest freedom you have is the freedom to choose your thoughts and the greatest power you have is to love unconditionally.

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- Write in your journal how you want to live, feel, and compete.
- What sort of growth choices can you make that will expand your vision? Make a commitment to put yourself in new situations in which you were previously uncomfortable. Can you let go of your self-consciousness amid the discomfort?
- Consider what it means to feel resonance. When you're in the midst of the work or sport you love, what leads you to resonance? What takes it away?
- What does it mean for you to pursue absolute fullness of life?

5

Code of the Samurai

How a group of warriors mastered their ego

A warrior considers it his foremost concern to keep death in mind at all times, every day and every night... As long as you keep death in mind at all times, you will fulfill the ways of loyalty, avoid myriad evils and calamities, be physically sound and healthy, and live a long life. What is more, your character will improve and your virtue will grow.

**—Taira Shigesuke, written four hundred years ago in a guide
for young samurai**

In Chapter 1 we discussed the trap of a materialistic, transactional society and how it deceptively distances us from our true selves. In Chapter 2 we looked at the root cause of fear, which is self-centeredness, the myopic lens through which we view the world. Chapter 3 revealed the three great adversaries in our lives: The Critic, Monkey Mind and Trickster. Chapter 4 presented the solution to self-centeredness: love, wisdom, and courage.

Now we'll see how a group of warriors lived by a code of those three virtues and how that enabled them to be fearless.

The Paradox of the Samurai

You must die anew, every morning and every night. If you continually preserve the state of death in everyday life, you will understand the essence of Bushido.

—Tsunetomo Yamamoto, samurai

In feudal Japan, samurai warriors ruled the land. They were legendary for their loyalty, self-discipline, and commitment to honor. The samurai lived by an unwritten code of ethics known as Bushido, which means “way of the warrior.” Their way was to place virtue and character above all else. The code, as with *Inner Excellence*, was based largely on three values: love, wisdom, and courage. In love, they served; in wisdom, they saw the impermanence of this life; in courage, they put honor and integrity over material concerns and rewards. The framework for their training was to prepare each day to fight to the death. In order to be fearless in battle, the warrior had to be prepared to die.

This isn’t an easy picture to imagine in our comfort-driven Western culture. While much of the world lives in poverty, we eat at fast-food restaurants (if in a hurry), sit down to fine dining (if we want to relax), and get anything and everything delivered to our homes. We’re always looking to make our lives easier and be more comfortable. Entertainment is a multibillion-dollar industry that capitalizes on our ever-increasing needs for comfort.

The samurai, on the other hand, found pleasure in improvement, freedom in discipline, and connection in service to others. While Western society’s professional athletes may be known as much for cheating as for performing, the samurai had no need for the money or status that cheating may bring. In their preparation to die each day, the samurai focused daily on that which was most important: their spirit. The paradox of the samurai is that they learned how to fight to the death by focusing on love—love of honor and service more than self.

The Spirit of Mastery: Love Over Fear

Mastering others is strength. Mastering yourself makes you fearless.

—Lau Tzu, Chinese philosopher

In Chapter 4 we learned that self-mastery is the pursuit of personal growth, to learn how to live with love, wisdom and courage, and not let your ego be your master. It's surrendering concern for yourself in order to see what's possible and who you can become when you let go of self-protection. Self-mastery is the quest of how to live true to yourself, seeking to walk in love rather than fear, having an expansive vision, and living in the present moment.

To master yourself, like the samurai, is to let go of the fears and attachments that have mastered you—to surrender them to a power greater than your own. The most powerful force there is, is love. Love is fully present and fearless. There's no fear in love—perfect love drives out fear.

Good and Evil and All Things Beautiful

Love is our greatest need. Rejection is our greatest fear. We spend our lives seeking love and avoiding rejection.

—Stephen Klemich and Mara Klemich, PhD., *Above the Line*

The two primary forces in the world are love and fear. We're always living in some form of one or the other. Either we're in self-protection mode (fear) or self-expression mode (love)—expressing our gifts. There's no one on earth who can bring to the world what you can bring. You're the only one. You were created for glory, to be your true self so you can express these gifts, but they are hidden and remain so in accordance with your willingness

to face your fears and live empowered by love.

You can make a lot of money, win trophies, and perhaps have a million followers, but until you confront your ego and the fears that follow, you'll never bring to the world what you are capable of bringing.

If we want to be fearless and live with freedom, the only lasting way is to have love be the driving energy in our lives—that is, to live life with greater energy and purpose than our own well-being. It seems backwards to give up your life in order to gain freedom but that's the law of the universe in action (if you cling to your life you'll lose it, give up your life to gain it). Again, it's not a moral thing, it's something that the greatest who ever lived have learned. Clinging to your life brings comparison and judgment, tension and separation. Giving up your life brings joy and peace, freedom and connection.

To walk in love not fear is to live by faith, not by sight. It's to live by what's deeply meaningful and timeless rather than what's superficial and temporary. There's no other way to live with fullness of life. The most important things—the most powerful things—are things unseen. Every other path may bring trinkets of trivial pleasures or monetary rewards, but they'll never bring lasting peace, purpose, and power. The greatest lives ever lived had extraordinary belief. They believed in love.

E. Stanley Jones, Theologian and close friend of Gandhi, explained:

No person is free until he or she is free at the center. When we let go there, we are free indeed. When the self is renounced, then one stands utterly disillusioned*, apart, asking for nothing. If anything comes to us, it is all sheer gain. Then life becomes one constant surprise.**

* When Jones says disillusioned, I think he means free of illusions (non-illusioned).

** By constant surprise, I believe he means constant gratitude at beauties that never cease.

To be free at the center is to let go of self-concern, and the way to do that is through love.

Q and A

This brings up some questions:

1. What does it look like to have love be the driving force in all I do?
2. How can I train my heart to stay on that path in the midst of stress or crisis?
3. How do I get back to the path of love when fear comes in?

And some answers:

1. It looks like resonance, where your main pursuit is to learn and grow and share your gifts, not accumulate trophies, awards or success (those are always the by-products of *Inner Excellence*).
2. Fuel your heart every day with the words, ideas, and stories of those who have gone before you and lived in love. Then when crisis hits, what's in your heart will come out. The strength of those "mentors" will be with you.
3. Keep in mind the *Inner Excellence* presuppositions and tools to reset

yourself and get back on track.

Perhaps the greatest thing that separated the samurai from the average person was their willingness and preparation to die as a sacrifice for others. The greatest thing you have is your mindset and single-minded devotion to the purpose for your life.

Life is continually throwing challenges at us; to be creative and find solutions, we must have a clear mind, with no need to react nor threats to defend against. The ideas come when we're fully present, able to see beauty, and not living in a constant state of reaction.

Most of what we do in the quest for self-mastery comes down to the ability to surrender self-protection and self-concern for love, so we can be wholehearted—fully engaged heart, mind, and body. It may help to compare self-mastery and ego to better understand the characteristics of each.

A Comparison of Mastery and Ego

Mastery

Selfless

Strong sense of self

Grateful

Unembarrassable

Unoffendable

Unirritatable

Compassionate

Ego

Self-centered

Self-conscious

Entitled

Easily embarrassed

Easily offended

Easily irritated

Judgmental

Mastery

Always learning
Win the battle within
Process-oriented
Best shot
Willing to look foolish
Fully present
True to self
Willing to sacrifice
Able to suffer/ be uncomfortable
Feeling of control
Freedom and passion
Embrace the opponent
Humble
Seeks growth
Broad vision
Sees beauty first
Walks by faith
Centered
Seeks wisdom
Few needs
Purpose beyond goals

Ego

Always comparing
Win at all costs
Outcome-oriented
Win or lose
Afraid of humiliation
Living in the past and future
Unaware of true self
Seeks instant gratification
Comfort seeking
Controlled by results
Fear and tension
Hate/fear opponent
Arrogant
Seeks validation
Limited vision
Sees flaws first
Walks by sight
Scattered
Seeks status
Needy
No real purpose

Mastery

Unlimited imagination

Transcends circumstances

Stable

Ego

Bounded by experience

Attached to circumstances

Unpredictable

Renew the Mind

Your time is limited, so don't waste it living someone else's life... have the courage to follow your heart and intuition... Remembering that I'll be dead soon is the most important tool I've ever encountered to help me make the big choices in life.

—Steve Jobs, Founder, Apple Inc., after being diagnosed with cancer

It's hard to stay focused in the pursuit of mastery when your environment is affluenza-infected and ego based, in opposition to mastery. Because of this, you must constantly renew your mind, so that you can revisit your purpose and be prepared to sacrifice, even suffer, in order to develop awareness of your true self. Each day, the mind gets filled with needless clutter, and so you must clear out what's not you and reboot the system (which you'll read about in Chapter 6). Renewing the mind is about continually going back to the Truth with a capital T (e.g. who God is and who you are), as well as capturing your thoughts, keeping the good ones, dismissing the others. Rather than letting thoughts come and go mindlessly, we develop more awareness of them, intentionally focusing on empowering ones (related to the Truth) and releasing the negative ones (or outright lies).

The samurai spent much time in meditation, knowing that the slimmest mistake in moral judgment or self-centeredness, which we take for granted today, would be fatal. If one samurai publicly disgraced another with harsh words, he might have been called upon to take his own life. Knowing this, the samurai had to keep their minds sharp, seeing beyond themselves—ready to sacrifice—because their code demanded constant and severe accountability.

Renewing the mind starts with the awareness that human nature is self-centered and that every morning when we wake up, the ego wants to compare ourselves with others, to feel a little better. This so often leads to stress and frustration, since so much is out of our control. Here's a routine you can do before bed to renew your mind:

Beauty Before Bed: A 5-Step Tool to Renew Your Mind

1. Review your day. At the end of the day, go over your day from start to finish. Think about what went well and what you learned.
2. Recall three beautiful moments. Find specific moments during the day that you can be grateful for, the smaller the better. Being grateful for your health is neither specific nor small. Being grateful for the moment during your workout when you realized you weren't anxious is specific and small. And beautiful.
3. Reprogram the mistakes and let go of the day. See yourself changing anything you didn't like about how you acted or performed, doing it exactly how you wish you would have done it. (Chapter 9 will share

specifics on how to do this). Then let go of the day. You might see yourself taking all the events of the day, thanking God for them, and tossing them into outer space.

4. Preview tomorrow. See yourself waking up and going through your day, executing your routines. This step ensures you remember the routines you will follow and tools you will use in various situations the next day.
5. Visualize tomorrow. Step five is about getting the feelings. Picture yourself in some part of your day, feeling exactly how you want to feel, doing your routines, using your tools, embracing every challenge with gratitude. This step primes your subconscious (which you'll learn in Chapter 6), giving it a kick-start for the energy and feeling that you want to experience tomorrow.

After you're done, you might want to write your thoughts in a journal. A lot of us have carried our worries and concerns to bed with us. This is a mistake. When we sleep, our subconscious minds process the day's events and consolidates our memories. If we haven't dealt with the day in a positive manner, our subconscious mind may embed the mistake or painful memory even more. This is one reason prayer before bed is so powerful: it's letting go of your attachments and letting God take over. This is also why taking one day out of every seven to completely recharge is so important (no work or errands done on that day). Then your subconscious can focus on creative possibilities rather than dwell on fearful outcomes.

Fear and anxiety are two of the great roadblocks to creativity and possibility. Because fear separates and isolates, it divides our hearts and

makes it difficult for our subconscious minds to imagine possibilities. When we deal with our mistakes and fears each night, however, then the powerful subconscious can creatively imagine unforeseen solutions.

To Share in the Glory, We Must Share in the Suffering

“Will having a newborn distract from the time we have together?” she asked. “Don’t you think saying goodbye to your child will make your death more painful?”

“Wouldn’t it be great if it did?” I replied. Lucy and I both felt that life wasn’t about avoiding suffering.”

—Dr. Paul Kalanithi, *When Breath Becomes Air*, (a young neurosurgeon dying of cancer, deciding with his wife whether or not to have a child before he dies)

Wouldn’t it be great if death was more painful? Such a crazy statement at first glance. But I think what Dr. Kalanithi was saying is that the more valuable something is, the harder it is to lose it. To experience an intense loss means you were given something incredibly valuable. Don’t reject a gift simply because of the pain you know you’ll feel if you lose it. In fact, the greater the pain of the loss, the greater the gift you were given. It’s better to have loved and lost than never to have loved at all. Everything has a beginning and an end, with every end a new beginning. Don’t lose out on beauty and joy because you’re afraid of pain.

One difference I’ve noticed in my travels to developing countries is that they are less attached to comfort and pleasure and less afraid of pain. They

are joyful, and grateful for what they have. Perhaps it's Western culture's obsession with happiness that limits our joy and gratitude.

Happy, Happy, Joy, Joy

Happiness, in our discussion, is a positive, temporary feeling attached to a circumstance; feeling good based on what's happening. Joy, on the other hand, is a deep sense of well-being, freedom and gratitude, independent of circumstances; deeper and broader than any pleasure.

Joy is possible when unhappy about the circumstances, even in the midst of suffering, since it's not based on circumstances or even feelings. Joy is based on love and hope and truth, about who you are, created for glory, filled with infinite, inherent worth and unlimited possibilities.

It's difficult to not put happiness on a pedestal. Western culture says happiness is success. Success is supposedly about making you and your family happy and comfortable. Happiness has become The Great Pursuit. But in reality, chasing happiness is The Great Mistake. The pursuit of *Inner Excellence* (and fullness of life) quickly becomes the path to Inner Mediocrity when you spend your life trying to find happiness to fill your lack of joy. You'll end up chasing your tail and losing out on so much. It'll make you dizzy.

As humans, we're led around by our eyes, which creates attachment to our circumstances. If we see good things in our lives, we feel good. However, if your car is breaking down, your best friend is leaving town, and your health is unsound, you're probably not happy. So, in an effort to feel better, you end up chasing better circumstances so you can get better feelings. Life becomes reactionary and emotional, making decisions based

on lack and scarcity rather than abundance and beauty. Long-term benefits get cast aside for short-term feelings.

In an attempt to be happy, it's easy to spend your life constantly trying to make it more comfortable with fewer problems. But that's the great mistake. We get so busy in our problem-solving that we spend our entire lives putting out fires, living lives of reaction, rather than dreaming big dreams, living lives of creativity. We miss out on incredible beauty because we spend so much time focusing on problems instead of possibilities.

When I think of happiness and joy and how they're different, I always think of two scenarios:

Scenario A

Marching in Opening Ceremonies.

I was the hitting coach for the South African Olympic baseball team at the Sydney 2000 Summer Olympics. We had just received an encouraging talk from Nelson Mandela. It was the second Summer Games since Mandela was democratically elected as South Africa's president, ending centuries of white minority rule. He spent 27 years in prison for opposing the racist government. His imprisonment and suffering were not meant to be his end, but rather a means of changing the world. As we entered the stadium, a surreal quiet filled the arena. It was an incredible moment.

Scenario B

Sitting in Ricky's little apartment in Los Angeles.

My friend was playing a spiritual song of gratitude on his guitar. There was nothing special about the circumstance or moment. I was deeply in debt, having just finished five years of full-time writing and research for the first

version of this book.

The feeling I had marching in Opening Ceremonies was elation (“this is amazing”), but it covered an overall anxiety (“my life has so much uncertainty.”)

In Ricky’s apartment I felt a deep sense of well-being, that I was loved by the creator of the universe, and that nothing I’ve ever done or could ever do would change how much He loved me. Feeling fully known and fully loved, by someone of immense value and glory, filled my soul with life—fullness of life.

Scenario A had amazing circumstances, while scenario B had nothing to write home about. But the way I felt inside was indescribably different. Scenario A was happiness on top of anxiety, while scenario B was joy independent of the unstable circumstances in my life.

As Westerners we’re so driven to be happy, we’re on a constant search for better circumstances that can bring more comfort and pleasure (since happiness is dependent on comforting circumstances). This is why suffering and death are taboo in our culture—it’s the opposite of the happiness that we esteem so much. Suffering feels like failure, since happiness is supposed to be linked to success.

Other cultures also have a different attitude toward suffering and death. During my time in South Africa, I sensed that death was a more integrated part of the circle of life, whereas in North America suffering and death is greatly resisted and not discussed; it’s a shock and pity when it comes.

Death in Africa

One time in South Africa I was riding in the back seat of a pickup truck (or

bakkie as they call it) on my way to a game reserve. There was a big exotic bird in the middle of the gravel road about 75 meters in front of us. The closer we got I assumed it would fly out of the way but when we got to it, I heard a thump and saw feathers fly.

A few minutes later we arrived at the reserve's security gate and the driver said something to the guard (perhaps in Zulu?). The guard walked to the front of the bakkie, reached down and picked up the large (and now dead) bird from the grill. What happened next pushed my comfort zone a bit.

The guard held the bird in both hands, seemingly with respect, then handed it through the window to the passenger, like he was passing over a plate of spaghetti. The passenger held it with both hands and gave it a little sway, as if getting a sense of the weight of it, then handed it to the driver, who did the same thing. I was afraid they were going to pass it back to me! I never found out what they were saying or why they each held the dead animal, but it was a much different reaction than my North American upbringing was used to. It was not the extreme avoidance of suffering or death to which I had grown accustomed.

If we can accept that suffering is a part of life, and that we will die, perhaps much sooner than we wish, we can start living and get past our fears.

To learn self-mastery and live extraordinary lives, we must embrace discomfort. Without pain, there's no growth. We can never become who we were born to become when we resist the adversity and challenges necessary for our development. If we want to be physically fit, there's no way to do so without some level of discomfort. Mediocrity may find ways around sacrifice and discomfort, but this is *Inner Excellence*, not Inner Mediocre.

Inner Excellence is the pursuit of true glory—the brilliance and weightiness of infinite, inherent worth, which comes with real joy. But to share in the glory, we must share in the suffering. That is, we must not be slaves to comfort and pleasure, but rather be selfless so we can be fearless. When we're selfless, we aren't led around by our feelings and desires, which, unchecked, continually increase, but we become disciplined enough to embrace discomfort and adversity. Then we can see clearly the beauty that always awaits discovery.

The more comfort in your life, the harder it is to face discomfort. This doesn't mean comfort is bad, it just means the more time you spend on the couch, the harder it is to get off it. "And the more people on the couch with you, the harder it is to get off it as well," adds Joshua Medcalf, author of *Chop Wood, Carry Water*.

More comfort also makes you soft if you're not careful. One empowering routine is to see if you can spend as much time with homeless people as you do with those with more status. It's a helpful habit, so you don't get addicted to comfort and stay grounded and humble, or you may get too big in your own eyes, which is a fast track to mediocrity.

The more pain in your life, the more gratitude you have for when you don't have pain. (Note: we're talking about the pain of discipline and pushing yourself to become someone you've never been before, not the pain of abuse, which may need immediate intervention. You may have had really bad things happen to you but remember this: You can carry your past with you in bitterness, or you can let it go in forgiveness).

The Little Boy and His Roller Skates

In Federal Way, Washington, a little Japanese kid used to get up at 330am before school to go roller skating. Dad would wake him up, put a miner's light on his head, and take him to the parking lot to train. "It was miserable," the youngster admitted. But the little boy became Apolo Anton Ohno, Olympic speed skating champion, the most decorated Winter Olympian in U.S. history.

In preparation for the Vancouver Winter Olympics, Apolo asked his strength and conditioning coach to move in with him so he could train without ceasing. "We'd spend 8-12 hours a day on physical training, and that does not include mental training, rehab, and recovery work that I did as well," he explained.

When asked why he thought he was so successful, Apolo answered, "I'm willing to do what nobody else is willing to do." He said he may have over-trained his body, but what it did for his mind was invaluable. Apolo was willing to suffer in order to be the type of person who felt so prepared that he deserved to win.

Apolo fell in love with the process of improvement. Going into the Vancouver Olympic Games he never set his eyes on breaking a record. "Obviously, I wanted to win races and compete to my full potential, but I've never been one to focus on the outcome. For me, the process is much more important and meaningful.

"The conversation doesn't end when you fail. That's when the conversation starts,"

–Apolo Anton Ohno, Olympic champion

If you want to be great, you must pay the price. We're all created for glory,

but the path to glory is blocked by obstacles of ego, comfort and pleasure. The challenge is that we all have a body that always wants to be comfortable, and never wants to get punched in the gut. That's where champions separate themselves: they over-ride their human tendency for comfort—to sleep a little longer, to quit at a reasonable time—knowing that the most important thing they're doing is training their minds and hearts – to sacrifice, to not be led around by their feelings, to be relentless in the pursuit of excellence.

Suffering gets our attention in a way that other experiences cannot. It is often the only mechanism that can break through our shell of self-centeredness, expanding our awareness, inviting compassion and connection with others.

Sport psychologists Terry Orlick and Shaunna Burke interviewed mountain climbers who successfully reached the summit of Mount Everest. When asked what it took to achieve that goal, one climber acknowledged:

The greatest most single thing is to experience hardship. I have suffered a lot on other expeditions before going to Everest. People often ask me what it takes to do Everest and to be honest it is a lifetime of suffering. That is what you draw on, that ability to say I can sustain the suffering. Climbing Everest is like an aching tiredness that goes right into the depths of your soul. So the first time hardship shows up on Everest, and it is a very long suffering period, you are able to endure because you say, “Yes, I have suffered like this before and I have suffered for protracted periods of time.”

Barriers to learning from suffering

In Western culture suffering is the opposite of success, to be avoided at all costs. This perception prevents us from embracing, and learning from, suffering. The value we see in an experience affects how we go through the experience. If we see suffering as meaningless, something we don't deserve, then we magnify our suffering.

A large part of suffering is the thinking that we shouldn't suffer. There's the pain that comes with life, then there's the interpretation of that pain. If you're depressed, there's the depression, and there's the interpretation that you shouldn't be depressed, which doubles the depression.

One of the things we learned to do in the Wim Hof Method cold therapy training (you'll read about it in Chapter 8) is to focus on the parts of the body that were cold, rather than try to ignore them. Often when in pain, we try to wish it away or ignore it, whereas we learned to concentrate on it and embrace it. Fear gains power when we try to ignore it.

Fear is one of the main barriers to learning from suffering. It focuses on the self, the future and the unknown. What's going to happen to me? Or, when will it stop? Fear of not being able to endure, and ultimately, fear for your survival, triggers a need to escape suffering.

The Happiness Addiction

When we reject or run from pain and adversity, we travel the slippery slope of addiction. Addiction—be it sex or chocolate, meth or heroin, shopping or people pleasing—is essentially all the same issue. It's the avoidance of (often emotional) pain, finding a substitute to enable us to avoid our fears. The problem is that the situation doesn't go away when we avoid it, it gets worse. It doesn't go away because it's sending you a message: *Stop running*

from discomfort and emotional pain. When you face it, you'll find out you're far stronger than you thought you were.

Regardless of the addiction, the same process happens in our bodies. The food, drug or other addictive agent enters our mind/body, a chemical reaction occurs, and we get a feeling that we become addicted to.

Don't think that because you're physically fit or have a big bank account that your addiction is any different than the overeater or drug abuser. In many ways your unseen addiction is much harder to break, because it's socially acceptable or even invisible. Consider the addiction of pride or needing to be recognized. It's a hidden addiction that impacts every area of your life, but most people will carry it to their graves, never to get well. The reason is they don't see it as a problem; this is its power. What's your addiction?

Another common but overlooked addiction besides pride (and wanting to be recognized or be right), is the addiction to comfort. It all goes back to The Great Pursuit (aka The Great Mistake), which is the pursuit of happiness...the belief that I must be happy and comfortable and free of pain. Pride and pleasure, ego and comfort, are all potential obstacles to the transformation that awaits those who are willing to face their fears.

Why we should embrace/accept suffering

Suffering isn't something I avoid. It's something I love—I love what it brings, what's on the other side of it. When we're climbing Mt. Everest, we're all suffering together, facing the same battle, chasing the same dream. Suffering makes the accomplishment that much more fulfilling.

**—Elizabeth Rose, Youngest Canadian to climb the Seven
Summits**

Suffering need not be an obstacle to fullness of life. In fact, suffering can actually become the means to joy and peace. To embrace suffering is to silence the Critic, since to the ego and the Critic suffering is bad. What is the Critic's greatest fear? Is it not the fear of life going in the wrong direction, failing—or worse—suffering? When we embrace suffering, we can transcend our circumstances; we're no longer shackled to what's happening, having been liberated from our mind and body and all the associated ups and downs. We can see further, from a new angle, with more meaning and clarity. It may be only with eyes rinsed with tears that we can truly see who we are.

Suffering produces perseverance, perseverance produces character, and character is the basis for the hope needed to see through the pain of the temporary circumstances to the glory of the future that awaits.

The people throughout history that lived the most extraordinary lives (e.g., Gandhi, Mandela, Martin Luther King, Jr., and Mother Teresa) all had character built out of suffering. They knew the value of sacrifice, and thus were prepared to suffer.

Dr. Viktor Frankl saw in the death camps that those who were the most resilient were not the physically strongest or the loudest, but those who had a deeper meaning that could not be taken away by brutal conditions. Part of their strength was the desire to respond to their life the best way they were able, which was to be worthy of their sufferings; to accept the pain with honor. Frankl explains:

[Russian writer] Fyodor Dostoevsky said, “There is only one thing that I dread: not to be worthy of my sufferings.” These words frequently came to my mind after I became acquainted with those martyrs whose behavior in [concentration] camp, whose suffering and death bore witness to the fact that the last inner freedom cannot be lost... They were worthy of their sufferings; the way they bore their suffering was a genuine inner achievement. It is this spiritual freedom— which cannot be taken away—that makes life meaningful and purposeful... We had to learn ourselves and, furthermore, we had to teach despairing men, that it did not really matter what we expected from life, but rather what life expected from us. We needed to stop asking about the meaning of life, and instead to think of ourselves as those who were being questioned by life—daily and hourly.

When Nelson Mandela spoke to the South African Olympic Team in the Olympic Village, his arrival caused quite a stir; meeting him was an amazing honor. As he stood there giving a little talk and wishing us luck, I couldn't help but consider his incredible sacrifice for his country and willingness to put his people's needs before his own. Mandela was willing to suffer, and through his suffering he became one of the world's greatest leaders.

How did Mandela suffer through 27 years of unjust imprisonment only to emerge without bitterness toward his captors and end centuries of racist rule? Daily suffering molded him. Who could have known what awaited Mandela—that he would become president, lead South Africa out of apartheid, and change the world? Who knows how your suffering will

develop you and shape your future?

We will suffer. Every moment of discomfort offers the chance to resist or embrace the suffering. When we resist hardship our perspective narrows. The suffering seems worse and we feel victimized. “Why is this happening to me?” we ask in self-pity. Learning and growth are impaired as self-protection moves in and fear takes over. Whenever you face adversity, remember the presupposition:

Everything is here to teach me and help me—it’s all working for my good.

When we embrace hardship with the belief that everything is here to teach us and help us embrace the glory we’re created for, our perspective widens.

One of the biggest differences between the journey towards absolute fullness of life and a life of frustration and fear is this: fullness of life is on the other side of selflessness, which includes the willingness to suffer. When you completely give up your “self” for a powerful purpose, to love others first and foremost, that selflessness gets you out of your head and silences the Critic, Monkey Mind and Trickster. It helps you be fully engaged, heart, mind and body, and reveals a peace and joy that is addictive. It’s an addiction that empowers—one that reveals the glory you were created for.

When you completely sacrifice your *self* for others, or some worthy cause, or if you face your fears and are willing to suffer in order to learn and grow, then incredible grace and beauty are revealed in a way that’s obscured to the world but shared with you. Through your journey, you open up this beauty to the rest of the world.

The Most Dangerous Position

We've become so obsessed with comparing well and being successful—so we can know that we're somebody, that we're ok— that we often choose the wrong path in pursuit of our dreams. In his book *Zen Mind, Beginner's Mind*, Shunryu Suzuki shares the following lesson:

In our scriptures, it is said that there are four kinds of horses: excellent ones, good ones, poor ones, and bad ones. The best horse will run slow and fast, right and left, at the driver's will, before it sees the shadow of the whip; the second best will run as well as the first one, just before the whip reaches the skin; the third one will run when it feels pain on its body; the fourth will run after the pain penetrates to the marrow of its bones.

You can imagine how difficult it is for the fourth one to learn to run. When we hear this story, almost all of us want to be the best horse. If it is impossible to be the best one, we want to be the second best. But this is a mistake. When you learn too easily, you're tempted not to work hard, not to penetrate to the marrow of a practice.

If you study calligraphy, you will find that those who are not so clever usually become the best calligraphers. Those who are very clever with their hands often encounter great difficulty after they have reached a certain stage. This is also true in art, and in life.

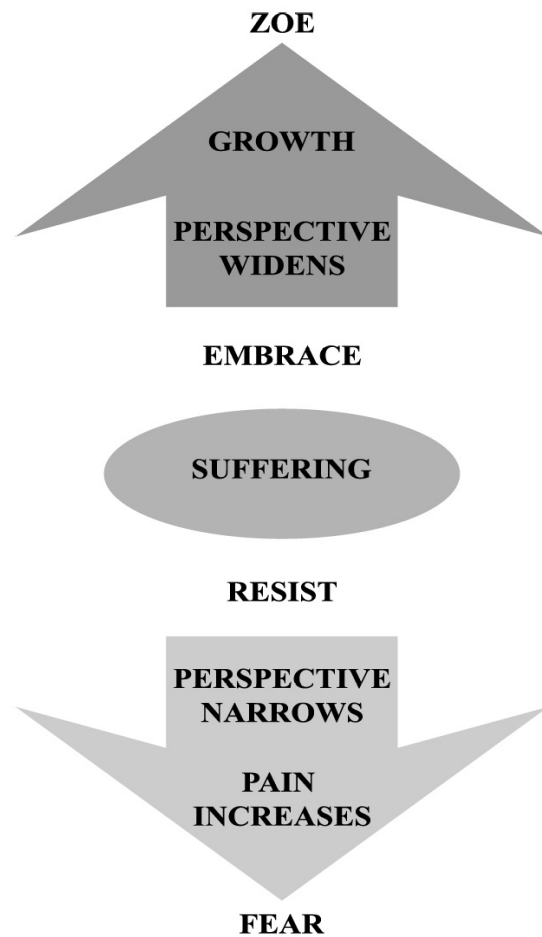
When we win, we are like the best horse. There's no sting of the whip. This is a very dangerous position—perhaps *the* most dangerous—a position where it's tempting to slack off. Victory is always dangerous, because it

puts us in a place of potential pride and arrogance that overlooks our shortcomings. Failure is also dangerous, because we are inclined to internalize the failure and go down the path of self-rejection.

The route of a champion is very narrow, and few are willing to travel the path. It's the path of risk and failure, learning and growth. The champion is not the one with talent, but the one with grit (passion and perseverance); perhaps not even the grit you have right now, but the grit you'll gain from facing your fears today and being willing to fail.

So what's your story? Are you feeling the sting of the whip? Is the pain that penetrates to the marrow of your bones causing you to shrink back—or renew your mind?

Figure 5.1 The Lifeline of Suffering and Growth



The 12 Steps to Life Change for Millions

Another group of people who know suffering found a method to not only transcend their afflictions but also conquer their demons and change lives all over the world. During the economic depression of the 1930s, Bill Wilson became an alcoholic and was introduced to a powerful way of life that enabled him to overcome his addiction to alcohol. As cofounder of Alcoholics Anonymous (AA), Wilson, along with Dr. Bob Smith, built a 12-step program that has been adopted all over the world to overcome myriad addictions and sufferings.

The program addresses the three dimensions of the human experience: physical, mental, and spiritual. Physically, individuals cannot change under their own power. Mentally, they know that how they're living is hurting them, but that knowledge along with the desire to change is not enough. The root of the problem is spiritual.

The illness in all 12-step groups is self-centeredness. Working through the steps replaces self-centeredness with a growing moral consciousness and a willingness to engage in self-sacrifice and unselfish constructive action. The 12 steps help the members overcome their self-centeredness through the following principles:

- A willingness to die to their old nature and its way of doing things
- A search for self-awareness to see things as they really are
- Surrendering control and the idea that you can do everything yourself
- Having a vision beyond themselves to connect with a higher power and others

(See Appendix A for all 12 steps)

Ryan S. used to dull the emotional pain he felt in his life with alcohol. Eventually he ended up in rehab at a facility that practiced AA principles. His life transformed. I asked Ryan how he was able to overcome his alcohol addiction and what the key was to changing his life. He reflected, "Upon learning that I didn't have control over other people, situations and things, I stopped trying to control everything. I realized that my life would be unmanageable until I surrendered control." Ryan continued, "One of the greatest moments of my life was the serenity I had as I walked out of the facility [after finishing treatment]. I surrendered control of my life to a

power greater than myself. My life went from a physical and mental one to a spiritual one. I realized what true peacefulness was.”

While in treatment, Ryan had a prayer/mantra that he recited every day, hundreds of times, that helped him so much. It was the serenity prayer:

God, grant me the *Serenity* to accept the things I cannot change,
Courage to change the things I can, And *Wisdom* to know the
difference.

What Ryan realized is the same thing the samurai learned: we will all die. That is not in our control, just like so much of the rest of our lives. Thus, Ryan decided, I’ll control only what I can control and leave the rest up to God. Ryan chose the most powerful path he could choose: to walk by faith, not by sight.

Service to Others

These same principles have worked in other programs all around the world—in Japan with the samurai, as well as with elite athletes. Former New York Giants football star David Tyree knows about dying to self. As a pro football player, Tyree went down a road of self-centered behavior that led to drug use and then jail time. One day things changed. The wide receiver known for his miraculous helmet catch in the 2008 Super Bowl (watch it [here](#)) said the turning point for him was to accept “a certain level of surrender” to forces stronger than football or its players. “Surrender is not a popular term when you’re talking amongst men,” he said, “but, honestly, that’s really what it takes.”

When you see how a powerful team sacrifices the needs of the individual

for the overall good, and how this approach helps each team member, then the value of sacrificing yourself (and the self-centeredness that leads toward fear) becomes more apparent. As described in Chapter 4, Lewis Pugh overcame his fears and doubts through a powerful connection to others and a purpose beyond himself. He was thereby able to face his own possible death with confidence and aggression. The samurai lived in service to others with a selflessness that took precedence over their own lives; they were even willing to die for these ideals. AA members have a covenant based on dying to their old selves, humility, service, and connection to others.

The Eight Attachments

I never prayed to make a putt. I always prayed I'd react well if I missed.

—Chi Chi Rodriguez, Hall of Fame golfer

While writing the first edition of this book, the University of British Columbia (UBC) men's golf team, pursuing a national championship, fell apart amid high expectations. During the four-day tournament, they desperately wanted to win but lost their joy and their presence, and as the rounds progressed, they became more nervous and self-conscious. They lost. The following year was a different story as they began to learn *Inner Excellence*. They became the first foreign team in history to win the National Association of Intercollegiate Athletics (NAIA) national championship, and they followed up a few weeks later by winning the Canadian national championship.

Team captain Sean Hurley explains what changed: "Last year we were a

bunch of individuals trying so hard to meet expectations and win. Everything changed this year. Working with Jim, winning wasn't a 'materiality' to us anymore. We focused on playing with passion with and for each other and let the chips fall where they may. Our mantra was, 'The score is for the fans—we play for the love of the game.'"

To gain maximum freedom, you must be willing to fail and not be attached to your desires. With no expectations of how things need to unfold, you're free to handle any obstacle. In the pursuit of mastery, these eight attachments, in no particular order, affect you the most:

- How others see you
- Your money and possessions
- What you want (goals)
- Comfort
- Your past
- How things are (status quo)
- Expectations
- Your self (and all the parts that you associate with "you.")

The key is to live as if you'll die tomorrow and prepare as if you'll live forever. That said, how do we rid ourselves of these attachments and obsessions? Or, you could say, how do we achieve self-mastery, since self-mastery is largely a matter of dropping your attachments?

The Superstar and the Sucker

I was talking to a superstar athlete (top 10 in the world) and he told me he was too attached to the results of his performance. He realized it was

causing him to lose focus when he needed it most. “How do I not be so attached?” he asked. I asked him, “Can you think of a way to easily take away a lollipop, without any resistance, from a kid who loves lollipops?” “There’s one easy way,” I told him. “Give the kid a bigger lollipop in exchange.”

One of the main problems with athletes, performers, and goal-oriented individuals is that they set their goals too low. They set winning as their highest goal, whether it’s an Olympic gold medal, a world championship, or a position as CEO of a major corporation. You might think, those are pretty high goals, and they are, but they’re too low for *Inner Excellence* standards. Those goals are all only symbols of what you really want, which is a meaningful, fulfilling life—becoming the person you were created to be. What good is it to win Olympic gold or become CEO and earn \$30 million a year if you’re filled with anxiety and live in constant fear of losing it?

What I help people do is to go directly for what they really want: absolute fullness of life. Go for it by building who you are as a person so you can have both extraordinary performance and fullness of life—the whole candy store. Pursue the gold medal as your highest goal and you’ve got a very scary road ahead of you with so much out your control and slim chances of getting it. Seek fullness of life as your highest goal and you’ve got an exciting journey ahead of you and a very high chance of getting it. As an added bonus, going for fullness of life as your highest goal also gives you the best shot of getting the gold medal.

To pursue the whole candy store—absolute fullness of life—is the direct pursuit of self-mastery by pursuing love (leading with your heart), wisdom (expanding your vision), and courage (being fully present) as your highest goals. This means surrendering self-concern as you find a purpose beyond

yourself for which you can dedicate your life to. A purpose beyond yourself helps you form powerful connections and begin your journey toward self-mastery. Your joy will increase along with the joy of others.

As you develop self-awareness and pursue love, wisdom and courage, you are better able to see the match between your place in the world and your higher purpose. The journey of self-awareness and higher purpose is the path toward freedom. In your quest for success, the ultimate triumph is to be your true self—the best part of you, fearless and fully present, constantly seeking to learn and grow and to help others do the same. To do this, you must be willing to die, by way of sacrificing your old, self-centered nature and putting your ego aside for something greater. It's hard, because you'll have to face your fears. You'll suffer, but in embracing the suffering, you'll gain discipline, and with discipline comes honor. If there's something that's so valuable and meaningful that you'd sacrifice your life for it, then you've found a way to be fearless.

To live fearlessly is to live a life of freedom, one uninhibited by societal restraint, one of taking risks, of going to the edge and looking over the cliff simply for the more expansive view, without trembling or hesitation. It's not for everyone. In fact, it's not for most. It's a challenge for the courageous.

What I'm asking you to do is to put your self on the line, heart and soul, to test who you are. I want you to see if you're being true to yourself or are instead filled with attachments to external things and the self-consciousness that comes with trying to please others and fit in. In preparing for today as if it were your last day alive, you're choosing a life filled with growth and sacred moments.

Key Points from Chapter 5

- Self-mastery is comprised of self-awareness, self-discipline, and personal growth.
- Self-mastery comes from surrendering concern for self to serve others.
- Extraordinary success is the by-product of self-mastery.
- Self-consciousness and attachment to circumstances and results are two of the biggest obstacles to extraordinary success. They lead to overanalysis and constant judgment of circumstances. The ego amplifies those obstacles, and mastery diminishes them.
- To learn self-mastery and live powerful lives, we must embrace suffering.
- Remember the presupposition: *Everything is here to teach me and help me—it's all working for my good.*
- The ego is caught up in temporary pleasure, while mastery is focused on permanent and powerful virtues.

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- What are your attachments? What are you holding on to so tightly that it affects your relationships, growth, or performance?
- What's the little lollipop you've been holding onto? Are you willing to let go of it in exchange for the whole candy store? Are you willing to have scary feelings?
- How does self-consciousness affect you? In which roles or life

situations do you compare yourself with others?

- Use your journal to record your attachments and how you can pursue your goals without letting doubts, fears, and neediness stall your growth.
- Each day when you wake up, ask yourself how you would live if this were your last day.
- How can you shift your focus from outward success to self-mastery? What limits your pursuit of mastery?

Change Your State, Change Your Life

How to Control Your Emotions

What's running your life at any given moment is not your external circumstances, not your thoughts, not your intentions, not even your feelings, it's your soul. The soul is that aspect of your whole being that correlates, integrates and enlivens anything going on in the various dimensions of the self. You don't direct the soul, you feed it, then the soul directs you.

**—Dallas Willard, PhD, Director of Philosophy, University of
Southern California**

Change or die: what if you were given that choice? Could you change your life if you really had to? Amazingly, people often cannot. You may realize that you need to eat healthier or exercise more often but find yourself struggling to turn those good ideas into habits. Obstacles arise and bring you down emotionally, causing you to lose the discipline needed to make good decisions. In order to be wholehearted and courageous, you must be able to adapt to circumstances you cannot control. If you want to make positive changes that last and live with fullness of life, you must learn to direct how you feel.

Feelings run our lives. When we feel good, we take setbacks in stride, see more opportunities, and find beauty to be just a little more apparent. When we feel bad, obstacles become larger and more difficult to overcome. We constantly react to circumstances and to the thoughts and feelings that result. Everything pivots on how you feel, so you must learn to direct and

change your state, which is what and how you feel overall.

The word “state” comes from the Latin *status*, which is the condition something is in. In our discussion, state is the sum of your feelings and physiology, the overall vibration of energy in your heart, mind and body. How often are you aware of your overall state?

In this chapter, you’ll learn how to control your state. It begins with understanding that your results come from your behaviors, your behaviors come from your feelings, and your feelings come from your thoughts. While may seem fairly straightforward, understanding this model will help you learn how to control your state.

In order to get in a better state more often, we need to examine (and perhaps transform) the source of our feelings: they overflow from the heart.

Before we get into the heart, let’s look at your thoughts and how they form.

The Juicy Lemon Drop

We don’t have power because we are constantly reacting to the outer world. You are either consciously creating your life or you are reacting to it.

—John Kehoe, *Mind Power into the Twenty-First Century*

Think back on your day. Was anything frustrating or fun? What were the circumstances that created that feeling within you? The way we experience life seems pretty clear cut: something happens, and we respond to it. If it’s a good thing, we feel happy; if it’s a bad thing, we feel upset. But what’s the underlying cause of how we feel?

We take in information about the world through our five senses: sight,

smell, taste, hearing and touch. Our perception of the event creates thoughts and feelings that become beliefs about the event. These beliefs determine how we experience the event. Sometimes the beliefs limit us. Over time, we establish patterns in our beliefs that determine whether we can overcome difficulties in our lives or give into sadness/despair. What we believe, and therefore how we perceive our world, is all-important.

We experience the world not just by our senses, but through our imaginations. An idea enters our minds, and our brains form a picture of it. Since the brain cannot tell the difference between what's vividly imagined and what's real, it often processes the imagined thing or event as if it were real.

Let's say I invite you into my kitchen, and we walk over to my cutting board. I have a bag of big, juicy lemons, and I cut one in half. Now I'm going to ask you to tilt your head back, open your mouth, and close your eyes for a few seconds. What happens next? Imagine the lemon being held over your mouth and a hint of citrus in the air. A drop of juice hits your tongue. If you vividly followed along, you undoubtedly started to salivate. Your imagination can create reality anytime, anywhere.

The world you see is a projection your brain made based on the information it had. It takes the new information, sorts it through your memory, and creates your own—specific to you—experience of the event. What you experience is not how the world actually is: your experience is your interpretation of the world based on your past and what you've come to believe about yourself and the world.

Diagram 6.1

**Circumstance X → Filtered through our memories and beliefs →
Thoughts → Feelings → Actions → Results**

Note: For our purposes, results are the circumstances created in your life based on your actions. Results are a part of your circumstances.

Beliefs stem from the meaning your mind assigned to each event in your life. It's completely biased. Some people's perception maps are rugged and mountainous, with dangers around every turn, while others are smooth and beautiful, with opportunities waiting around every corner. This bias explains why two people can live through the same event and have totally different experiences. As the story goes, two men looked out through prison bars, one saw mud, the other stars.

Our perception maps determine what we see, which greatly impacts the meaning we create and therefore the options we have. So many possibilities exist for us in the world. But these possibilities can be embraced only if we can see them, or at least know they exist: If all you can see are chickens and chicken scratch, it doesn't matter if you're an eagle—flying won't be a part of your world.

To have your perception map match the world perfectly isn't necessary and certainly would make things difficult—it would just be too much to take in. Our visible spectrum is limited to seven colors—we cannot see what eagles or owls can, nor can we hear what a leopard or lop-eared rabbit hears. This is for our good, so we can manage our lives without being overwhelmed. It is extremely important, though, for us to learn how to recognize beliefs that limit us, and strive to stay open to possibility, if we want to live a life of freedom with love, wisdom, and courage.

How Your Brain Makes Decisions

The proper emotional response to a problem is 75 percent of the solution.

—**Jim Loehr, Ph.D.**, *Mental Toughness Training for Sports*

The brain continuously takes in and processes information. There's so much information, it must be organized to figure out what it all means. The main way the brain organizes information is by finding and storing patterns. Our brains are meaning-making machines, constantly jumping to conclusions in order to find patterns. When an object is viewed or event occurs, the brain looks for all available patterns it might match. Once the pattern is recognized, the brain uses the information it has to guide you through the event or experience. Our brains seek patterns through four processes: assumptions, generalizations, deletions, and distortions.

Assumptions

Assumptions are a big part of how we process information. Assumptions are things we accept to be true without proof. The brain doesn't need proof, it needs a pattern. The brain learns to recognize patterns and remember them, whether they are helpful or not. Assumptions are made in order for us to process information without spending hours in deliberation. If I were to scramble the words in this sentence, you would still understand what I wrote if the first and last letters of most of the words were in the correct order. For most of us, the brain quickly snaps to the closest appropriate word and unscrambles the letters (to read: "If I were to scramble the words in this sentence, you would still understand what I wrote.") That's how optical illusions work, because the brain jumps to conclusions. The brain

doesn't care so much if something is true or false, but rather if it fits the pattern of what it already "knows."

If we see the leg of an elephant, for example, the brain quickly assumes that the leg is connected to the body of an elephant and to three other legs, two big ears, and a long snout. In this case, we are able to see a piece of something and fill in what's missing to create a complete picture.

The problem is, we don't always want a complete picture. Sometimes we need to narrow our view and focus on a small part of the picture. Because of the way the brain takes in information (looking for patterns), it keeps wanting to jump to the surrounding environment instead of the task at hand. An opera singer wants to sing beautifully, but her brain wants to judge her performance as she sings or gauge how the audience will react. A baseball player tries to keep a simple mind when he's at bat and focus on one quality swing, yet his brain wants to jump to the future.

Here's a test you can try:

1. Find a painting or photograph of an object or scene on the wall.
2. Look at only the bottom right corner of the picture.
3. Try not to allow your mind to jump to the entire picture. Don't let it think of what's attached to the small part that you're viewing.

It's difficult!

The key message here is that your focus improves when you can break down a task into its most basic element and concentrate on that alone. If you're a golfer, make one good swing. If you're a musician, play one good bar. Recognize that your mind may want to continually jump to conclusions and make assumptions that may not be helpful or true.

Generalizations

Like assumptions, generalizations are based on patterns stored in your brain. Memories of similar events form a pattern that you learn from and use to make predictions about future events.

Here's an example:

1. You walk into a dark room and flip on a light switch.
2. The room lights up.
3. You walk into dark rooms several times. Every time you flip on the light switches, the rooms light up.
4. Your brain eventually connects light switches with rooms lighting up.

This is a generalization.

Generalization is extremely helpful—without it, we would continually have to relearn simple things. The problem is that this process can go too far. Imagine you spoke poorly and fumbled for words at an important presentation. Your brain may generalize that you will always have problems during important presentations—which is not necessarily true. Generalizations that contribute to a negative view of yourself and what you can do limit how you see the world and how you perform.

Deletions

We perform best when we dismiss unnecessary thoughts and let our intuition take over during an event. Paying attention to some aspects of our experience while ignoring others is called deletion.

This process is crucial in performance, where multiple things are happening at once. The performer must focus on the task at hand and not

get distracted. The problem with deletion is that this process narrows our vision and may cause us to miss opportunities.

Imagine walking around New York City. In the flurry of lights and images, vendors and street performers, there's so much information flooding your senses. To avoid being overwhelmed, your brain deletes much of the information it takes in. What it keeps or deletes is based on your unique map of the world/way of seeing the world. Deletions, in limiting what you see, affect what you believe is possible. You may aim too low if you can't see enough possibilities, or aim too broad if you can't see the right path.

Distortions

Distortion occurs when your brain gives too much meaning to a pattern. Let's say, for example, that you got nervous and forgot what you were going to say during your last two presentations. This minor setback triggers negative thoughts such as "This always happens," or "I never catch a break." In this example, *always* and *never* are words that distort, or exaggerate the truth. The problem with distortions is that we don't recognize when we're doing it. Negative thoughts directed at yourself or your performance may make you frustrated, anxious, or depressed. It's important to realize that our mind distorts things, and we can't always trust our minds. We need to train it and learn to recognize when it does.

The Story in Your Heart

What's controlling you at any given moment are the stories and ideas that have settled into your heart, especially the overall story you've come to

believe about who you are: what's most valuable, what's most important, and what's possible in your life. These all have a tremendous impact on your moment-to-moment energy, or your state.

Selfless-actualizers (see Maslow in Chapter 1) have developed a keen awareness of their thoughts and learned to manage their thoughts well. They've done this by organizing their environment and filling their minds with empowering stories and ideas. These stories and ideas support positive moment-to-moment thoughts that help create uplifting feelings. *Selfless-actualizers* still make assumptions and generalizations, and experience deletions, and distortions, but they recognize and manage these processes. They control their thoughts; their thoughts don't control them.

“Do you want him angry?” he was asked. Roach said, “No, I don't want him angry. We have a plan—I want him to follow the plan.”

—Freddie Roach, legendary boxing trainer, after being asked if his pupil Oscar de la Hoya was getting angry with his opponent's constant verbal jabs before a fight.

What Gets Your Attention Gets You

It is the mark of an educated man to be able to entertain a thought without accepting it.

—Aristotle, Greek philosopher, 384-322 BC

As I mentioned earlier, one powerful thing that *selfless-actualizers* do is organize their environment. They're very intentional about what they see

every day in their home and workplace as well as what they pay attention to. They focus on nurturing relationships and desires that inspire, teach, and empower. They intentionally fill their hearts daily with love, wisdom and courage. Dr. E. Stanley Jones, a friend of Gandhi's, said it well: "What gets your attention gets you." It *gets* you. In other words, what you focus on directs where your thoughts go, and those thoughts become feelings, actions, and results. It controls your life.

Imagine you're watching a movie. If the movie is engaging, your whole being is caught up in it. Your heart rate speeds up as if you're the one being chased, or your eyes stream with tears as if you're the one with the broken heart. Your mind, unable to differentiate between reality and what you vividly imagine, feels it as real. What you watch, listen to and read has a huge impact on what you think, feel, and believe, so choose carefully.

Prime Time

There's just one way to radically change your behavior: radically change your environment.

—Dr. B.J. Fogg, Director of Stanford Persuasive Lab

Your environment—the things around you that your senses engage with each day—has a major impact on your state, from which your behavior is generated. Your environment is also crucial to developing emotional control. Without your conscious awareness, the seemingly insignificant events and people you encounter every day impact what you think and feel and therefore how you act.

In a 2008 Yale study, students were asked to participate in a behavioral

study where they answered questions about various individuals. The students, however, didn't know that the study had already started in the elevator as they were being taken to the lab.

In the elevator, a confederate (who only knew her role, not the purpose of the study) asked the student if he or she wouldn't mind holding her coffee for a moment. The student was asked to hold either a hot coffee or an iced coffee.

When the participants arrived in the lab, they received a questionnaire about their impressions of people's personalities. The people that received the hot coffee perceived the subject as being significantly warmer, with more positive qualities than those who held the iced coffee.

In a follow-up study, participants held heated or frozen therapeutic packs as part of a product evaluation and were then told they could receive a gift certificate for a friend or a gift for themselves. Those who held the hot pack were more likely to ask for the gift certificate, while those who held the frozen pack tended to keep the gift. In other words, those who held the hot coffee tended to be more generous than those who held the iced coffee.

Drs. John Bargh and Lawrence Williams, authors of both studies, were trying to see how much the environment affects our thoughts, feelings, and behaviors. Their conclusion was that we are greatly affected by subtle things in the environment, often without our conscious awareness.

The studies demonstrate priming—a technique in which the introduction of a word, image or physical stimulus influences behavior. Mention the word *professor* to someone before taking a general knowledge test and they score better. Prime them with a word associated with lack of intelligence and they do worse.

Objects that come through your field of vision affect you immensely.

Whether it's a beautiful sunset, a masterful piece of art, or a stunning photograph, they all stimulate feelings. To feel good more often, you need more positive images consistently running through your mind. They can take the form of words, symbols, songs, or pictures. Of course, you can combine them as well: a collage with pictures of your goals associated with positive words is powerful. You can use those words to make affirmations (see Chapter 7), or add pictures and a soundtrack to make a movie. (Go to www.innerexcellence.com for the latest *Inner Excellence* tools and tips in your inbox.) However you do it, organizing your environment so it's oriented towards habits that help you live out your purpose and principles—and how you want to feel—is a key component of training your mind and heart.

Remember, we move towards what we focus on. When Charlie is learning to ride a bike, if she focuses on the rock in front of her, she'll run into it. If you tell four-year-old Clarence to stay out of that mud puddle, should you expect the little guy to avoid the picture you just put in his mind?

Direct Your Heart's Desires

Desires—especially what our heart longs for most—are extremely powerful: they influence how we see the world and what we strive for. They fill our heart with feelings and fears and move us to fight or flight. Desires out of control create addictions and obsessions that cause us to lose out on the joy and passion of performance and life. When we're hungry, we must eat; when we want chocolate, we must have it (actually, that part is true). Desires are very powerful, but they can turn on us. Human nature always leads us to seek immediate gratification. Discipline is the ability to delay

gratification, to reject some desires and accept others. Desire is a marvelous motivator and terrible master. If we were to continually give in to all of our desires, we'd overeat, oversleep, and max out our credit cards. We'd become slaves to our desires. Desires lead to feelings, and feelings generally win out over willpower. In other words, we may know what we should do, but we don't do it.

We've all been able to reject some desires because they were out of the question in relation to our values. You may desperately want something, but will not steal to get it. The problem comes when we continually give in to our desires such that we can no longer reject the ones we used to, because we let our desires get out of hand.

According to Dr. Dallas Willard, "Those dominated by the ego believe their feelings must be satisfied." The problem with this is that when you don't get what you "have to" get (to satisfy your feelings), you become frustrated and anxious. What you need is access to more "get to" feelings, instead of "have to." This is possible when you stop being controlled by your ego. As you increase self-mastery, you'll no longer be a slave to your feelings. You'll have more self-control, which will help you reject desires that are not empowering (e.g., temporary rewards and status) before they become too much to handle.

Our deepest desires control us. Therefore, we must make sure our desires are empowering and meaningful. Victor Frankl found that the people who survived the Holocaust weren't the strongest or loudest. Those people who had deep meaning in their lives, something that couldn't be taken away from them, survived.

Just as eating healthily creates a desire for more healthful food, and exercising creates a desire for regular exercise, we can increase our desire

for empowering habits. So how do we change what we desire? Start by thinking deeply about what you want most, beyond worldly success. In the end, what you'll find, I believe, is that what you want most is absolute fullness of life—to be filled with deep contentment, joy and confidence, independent of circumstances.

The Choice

The summer of 2018 I took my sister and parents on a ferry ride in Seattle to Bainbridge Island. I went to the top deck to smell the fresh air and water. As I looked at the islands around me, I saw a beautiful house on the ocean. Then the thought occurred to me: Would I rather have a ten million dollar house on the ocean, and have the normal stresses and anxieties of a person with that life, or would I rather live in an apartment, paycheck to paycheck, but be guaranteed to live with deep contentment, joy and confidence, independent of circumstances, the rest of my life? When asked, most people told me they want both the house and the peace, but if you *had to* pick one or the other, which would you choose?

Take some time to think of your answer. If you chose the house, would you still choose it if no one else could ever see it? Movie star Jim Carrey said he wishes everyone could become rich and famous and have everything they could ever want so they'd see it's not going to make them happy.

When you realize that the reason you want to be world champion, CEO, or have that beautiful home on the water is because you think they will bring you freedom, peace and joy—shouldn't you go for those things directly? What if going for those things directly *also* gave you the best

chance of extraordinary success (world champion, CEO, etc.)? Wouldn't you be crazy not to pursue the direct route, and let those other things be added to you?

The direct route to a life of deep contentment, joy and confidence is to desire most what is most powerful and stable. So, what's most powerful and stable? Unconditional love. It's always present, always fearless, and never fails. It has strict boundaries and utmost respect for God, self and others. If the basis of your life is to love and empower others, you'll find it easier to reject unstable desires and embrace love, wisdom and courage. Your freedom will increase, your vision will expand, and you'll be more courageous. This will help you in every area of your life, especially performance.

Learn How to Focus and Relax

Here are three important skills that you'll learn to help you control your state (feelings and physiology):

1. How to focus (the mind) softly and sharply.
2. How to relax (heart, mind and body) moderately and completely.
3. How to go back and forth between focused and relaxed.

Soft focus is the ability to have a relaxed focus, one where you don't need to be completely focused on the task, but you will need to be soon. Soft focus is needed during a performance between sets or periods of action (e.g., between serves in tennis, between innings in baseball, and between plays in football). If you aren't able to soft focus, that means either you're not focused at all, or you're too focused and won't be able to maintain it

over the entire performance. Either way, you'll run into problems without this skill.

Sharp focus is the ability to focus intently on the task at hand, bringing the energy and presence needed to perform your best. Sharp focus is needed during a performance, especially when in key moments (serving, pitching, or in making a tackle in football).

Moderate relaxation is generally done at the same time as soft focus. Relaxing moderately means dialing down the energy levels and reducing the amount of thoughts in order to save energy for when sharp focus is needed.

Relaxing moderately isn't just needed for between plays or sets however. It's essential before and after the performance, on off-days—whenever you're not performing.

Relaxing completely is the ability to rest fully, with naps and sleep. When we sleep, our brain waves slow down (delta waves). When we're dialed-in during performance, our brain waves are at moderate speeds (generally alpha). When we're anxious our brain waves are going too fast (beta waves).

One of the major challenges with focus in western culture today comes from lack of sleep. Golfer Gareth Bale (and Real Madrid superstar) generally sleeps nine to ten hours a night and takes a nap for one to two hours a day, waking up exactly four hours before game time. To sleep that well takes the ability to turn off the mind and relax completely.

The third skill is to be able to go back and forth between focused and relaxed. As mentioned above, you'll want to softly focus (and moderately relax) between sets, and sharply focus during sets.

S-L-O-W

Most people, most of the time, walk around like they're driving: gas pedal pushed down, rarely relaxing in the slow lane. They're caught up in the circumstances and details of life, rarely giving the creative right brain the freedom to dream. If we want to learn emotional control, we first need to learn how to relax. This doesn't mean slacking off. Instead, it means letting off the gas pedal, slowing down your mind and body. This is important in the down times so you can be more focused and in control during the peak times.

One way to practice slowing down and becoming more aware is using your peripheral vision. You might try this right now, whether you're sitting still or driving a car. While looking straight ahead, see what you can be aware of in the far left and right sides of your vision. Don't move your head or your eyes, just stare straight ahead. What do you notice on the far sides of your periphery? As you do this, you can also practice detecting all the various sounds you hear. As you practice using your peripheral vision, you'll simultaneously practice observing more of what you hear, as well as improve your ability to relax and focus, and go back and forth between the two.

Soft Focus

At the Princeton Biofeedback Centre, students learn a concept called Open Focus, developed by Dr. Les Fehmi. It's a way of focusing attention, to help people reduce stress-related symptoms and enhance well-being. Open Focus is a broad, immersive style of paying attention, as opposed to the stressful narrow focus like those mentioned above with the gas pedal always down.

He explains: “The flexible awareness of Open Focus permits us to move in and out of full rest, allowing our body to restore itself and thus prevent and heal many stress-based problems common today.”

The basic idea that is that most stress comes from repressing and limiting the number of sensations we experience while in a constant mode of narrow focus. The main way to learn to soft focus is to practice paying attention to various senses in multiple ways.

Open Focus is a powerful way to practice how you pay attention as well as how to relax, and go back and forth between narrow focus and broad focus. Dr. Fehmi explains:

Open Focus attention training encourages awareness of how you attend to the wide array of sensory experiences-and the space between those experiences. Learning to foster attention that is nonexclusive and nonjudgmental supports in integrating your experiences with openness and flexibility. These techniques will help you relieve stress, manage physical pain, regulate emotions, and set the stage for peak performance and transcendent moments. Practiced regularly, they can bring about dramatic changes in your life.

Practice a softer focus

Stop for a moment and imagine your jaw and all the facial muscles that support it. Focus on your jaw area as you relax all the muscles around it.

Now imagine the space and distance between your eyes. Try to experience the sensations in the region in and around your eyes.

Next, imagine the space between the page or screen and your eyes.

Imagine the three-dimensional space between your eyes and the words.

Now increase your awareness of space to the left and right borders of the page or screen. Gradually allow your perceptual field to expand to include the top, bottom and sides of the page or screen. Continue to read, and as you do, slowly expand your awareness to include the space your body occupies. What parts of your body do you notice while you're sitting there or moving about listening to this? Expand your awareness to include the whole room or vehicle you're in right now.

Here's an exercise Dr. Fehmi suggests:

Can you feel the space inside and around your thumbs and index fingers, as well as the space they occupy? Closing your eyes allows you to more easily be drawn into feeling.

Get Centered: Reboot the system

Another way to practice “attending” (focusing/paying attention) is through breathing.

You can do this by learning to:

- Control your breathing with long, slow, deep breaths
- Focus your mind on one simple task

Why do it

Remember how the ego, Critic, Monkey Mind, and Trickster are always trying to pull you to the past and future, disrupting focus? Centering keeps you present by focusing your mind on your body. Deep, focused breathing brings energy to the center of your body, just below your belly button. Your mind, empty of past or future thoughts, is able to recharge during this

process.

Centering exercises are to be used throughout the day, every day, not just when you think you need to be at your best. If you want to have a clear mind when you perform, you need to practice controlling your focus and your energy daily so that you can do it under pressure when you need it most.

Here's a few exercises for you to practice:

The Reboot (Basic Reset):

Use this tool anytime you're not present (e.g., stressed, frustrated, angry, or nervous).

1. Stop whatever you're doing (walking, talking, etc.).
2. Pick a spot above the horizon (cloud in the sky, branch on a tree, etc.).
3. Stare at the spot and don't take your eyes off it.
4. Stop all thoughts as you stare intently at that spot.
5. Take a long, slow deep breath in through your nose (count of 4 or so).
6. Exhale, relaxing your jaw and all facial muscles (count of 6 or so).
 - a. The exhale must be longer than the inhale.
 - b. While letting go of your breath, also let go of all desires and concerns.
7. Do this twice. If you only have time for one breath, that's fine.

This is the basic reset that you will want to practice and use regularly.

Box Breathing

1. Find a good posture, ideally sitting up straight. Close your eyes.
2. Take a deep inhale through your nose (count of 4), expanding your ribs, allowing the air to fill your lungs.
3. Hold (count of 4).
4. Exhale through your nose or mouth (count of 4), deflating your diaphragm, allowing your belly button to approach your spine. As you do this, note any tension in the facial muscles, and let them relax. Allow your jaw to hang loose. These are both crucial elements, as tension is often stored in the jaw and in the muscles around it (a helpful point to remember in pressure situations).
5. Hold (count of 4). Repeat as desired.

When you need to calm a racing mind, try deep breathing. To slow down your heart rate or thoughts, slow down your breathing. Building on this basic exercise, we now add a few variations. The first one is to imagine that with every breath in, you're inhaling life-giving energy, and with every breath out, all your cares, concerns, or worries are leaving your body. (You can also visualize the life-giving energy entering your body as a mist to enhance the picture.) Next we add positive thoughts to the breathing. In his book, *Coaching the Artist Within*, Dr. Eric Maisel has provided a powerful exercise he calls the centering sequence, the first of which is "I am completely stopping."

To turn off your mind, you'll say inside your head (on the inhale), "I am..." and (on the exhale) "completely stopping".

If you want, you can imagine yourself descending a staircase, slowly going down to a quiet, peaceful place. You're shutting down the system. There are a number of variations to try next. Replace "I am . . . completely

stopping,” with:

I am . . . fully present.

I am . . . focused and relaxed.

I am . . . calm and confident.

I am . . . letting go.

I am . . . brilliant and successful.

I am . . . an all-star.

I am . . . [add however you want to feel or be].

Focus . . . and enjoy.

Relax . . . and smile.

I Expect Nothing

There’s a mantra the samurai recited before going into battle: “Expect nothing, prepare for anything.” Expectations are a potentially large stumbling block in performance, causing tension and fear, taking you out of the present. By definition, expectation implies looking to the future. Centering exercises are done to bring your energy to your body’s center and your mind to the present. “I expect . . . nothing” is a powerful centering exercise that says you have no needs; you can handle any circumstance. You have no expectations about how things should be.

Here’s how you do it:

Take a long, slow deep inhale through your nose and say to yourself “I expect”, then hold for a few seconds, then exhale and silently say “nothing.” Doing this twice can reduce anxiety and make a real difference.

Imagine a samurai before a sword fight in which one person will die. To be his best, the samurai must stay focused and centered the entire time. He

especially cannot afford to be flustered by unforeseen circumstances. Expectation, as we use the word, has nothing to do with confidence, which is faith in the future. It is simply anticipation of future circumstances, which we want to avoid (we save that for visualizing). We prepare for the future everyday by setting process-oriented goals, repeating affirmations, and visualizing future outcomes. Otherwise, we want to stay fully in the present.

Learning to expect nothing and be prepared for anything is a good way to stay present and win the inner battle. It doesn't mean you don't expect abundance or to win, it means you're not attached to any circumstances that might arise.

Say, for example, you're driving to an important event. You start to get nervous. Your mind begins to race, and your heart rate speeds up. You pull over. You know this is not how you want to feel, so you decide to get centered. Your racing mind begins to settle down, and in just a few minutes your heart rate has returned to normal. You feel better—still nervous perhaps, but not so scattered. So you use the *I expect nothing, I can handle anything* mantra/tool. Now you've got more peace and presence.

Expectations are often the toughest when you've done something in the past (won a championship or landed a major account, for example) and feel you're expected to do it again. Perhaps your past performance resulted in the signing of a big contract or a promotion, and everyone has been saying how great you'll be. Now everything you do, large or small, comes with others constantly expecting the same success. It's easy to get overwhelmed. Sometimes in golf the five-foot putt is a lot harder than the ten-foot putt, all because of expectations.

Another option in centering is similar to the preceding exercise but slowly eliminate words until only one word remains. Let's use "Be here . . . right

now” as an example. Say these words inside your head:

1st breath

(Inhale) “Be here”

(Exhale) “Right now”

2nd breath

(Inhale) “Be here”

(Exhale) “Now”

3rd breath

(Inhale) “Be”

(Exhale) “Here”

4th breath

(Inhale) “Be”

(Exhale) *silence*

Another variant is to do the same exercise with different words: The first breathe is “Be still and know, that I am God.” The next breathe shortens to “be still and know.. I am.” Then it shortens to “be still” and “know,” then “be” and “still,” and finally just “be.”

When you’re getting centered, you might also add an image that represents how you want to feel. It may be a picture in your mind of one of your best performances, or it may be an image of your next performance.

Erica K., a dancer with the Mexican national ballet team, would go out onto the stage hours before anyone arrived and stand quietly at center stage. She would take some deep breaths and imagine reaching out to the entire crowd and giving them a group hug before a big performance. Then she’d

imagine energy coming from above, flowing through her to everyone in attendance. She'd become one with the audience and everything in the environment. Erica imagined perfect harmony and generated powerful feelings as part of her pre-performance routine. This allowed her to perform with confidence and grace.

Anchoring and Releasing Different States

Why anchor?

Remember when you had an amazing performance where everything felt right, and you were totally caught up in the moment? That's how you want to feel each time you perform. Before key moments it's very important to know how you want to feel and how to get that feeling. If you were to imagine your best performance again, every sight, smell, sound, taste, and feeling, you'd be able to relive your positive experience. You can access that positive experience, especially how it made you feel, by creating an anchor.

What anchoring is

An anchor is a sight, sound, taste, smell or touch that is linked to a feeling. Ivan Pavlov discovered anchoring with dogs back in 1897. He'd ring a bell and feed the dogs, ring a bell and feed the dogs, until just ringing the bell made the dogs salivate. This repeated pairing of stimuli became known as classical conditioning.

Your subconscious creates anchors to stimuli all the time without you knowing it. For example, when you hear a certain song from your senior year in high school, it brings back memories with strong feelings attached to them. The feelings are anchored to the song.

Here's how you can create an anchor:

1. Think of a moment you feel incredibly confident and powerful (with as much detail as possible to get a stronger feeling).
2. When the feeling approaches its highest point, perform a simple action that connects one of your senses with the feeling (i.e., smell something strong and soothing, like peppermint oil. The smell must be unique, or if it reminds you of anything, should be positive.)

In this example, you anchor confidence and power to smelling peppermint oil. In the future, when you may need to access those feelings, smelling the peppermint will help you bring them back.

You could try other anchors such as clenching your fist, doing a fist pump, or playing a song. While we all have our unique primary sensory modes of remembering and experiencing events, smell is usually the strongest anchor of any sense. Smell seems to have a direct pipeline to feelings.

There are times, of course, when frustration, anxiety or fear takes over, and we want to change how we feel. With training, you can learn how to hold on to positive feelings and release the negative ones.

How to release negative feelings

To release unwanted feelings, we need to learn how to disassociate from them. Disassociation involves changing unhelpful feelings to helpful ones. Here's an exercise you can do to disassociate from unwanted feelings:

Float Up Technique

1. Sit in a chair and get centered. Become aware of your body.
2. Imagine floating out of your body to the ceiling. See yourself and the room below in great detail.
3. Float above the room and over the building so that you can see the surrounding area.
4. Continue to float upward and see the entire city as well as any rivers or other landmarks. See the mountains, if there are any.
5. Remind yourself where you are below: see the building, and then see the surrounding area, the city, the state/province, and so on. Give yourself permission to leave ALL your problems and concerns down below. As you get higher and higher, feel how free and peaceful it is as you soar.
6. Soar higher through the clouds. Now you are up so high that you can see all the neighboring cities and mountain ranges, and even neighboring states/provinces.
7. Keep going higher and see the entire continent, and now the oceans and all the continents as you see the spherical earth.
8. When you're ready, begin descending. As you get closer to your chair, feel all your cares and concerns leaving as you drop down to earth.

Memories Versus Current Feelings

As I just mentioned, certain anchors will trigger unwanted memories. They may be tied to feelings that are not relevant or useful to how we feel today.

For example, when you hear a song on the radio that reminds you of a past relationship, you may miss that person and feel sad, even if you are currently doing well, are in a good relationship, and are happy. When you realize that it's just a memory of how you previously felt and not how you feel today, you can dismiss the feeling much more readily.

Think about a time when you performed poorly at a certain venue. The next time you're scheduled to be there, even if it's been several years, the Trickster will remind you of your poor performance: you may be beaten even before you get there. The Trickster always remembers past failures of similar events and projects them to the future, even if you're much better at what you do now. When this happens, remember that this is just a memory, not today's truth.

As you develop your ability to direct your feelings, you'll increase your awareness of them and be better able to figure out where they come from. This knowledge will help you develop better ways of dealing with your feelings. Let's say you're feeling down. If you have the awareness to realize that the feeling stems from the memory of a past failure, you can remind yourself that you are a much different person than you were back then. If you're frustrated because things aren't going your way, you can release that feeling with a centering exercise or the float up technique.

In the next chapter, we'll look at how to direct our desires and control our perceptions, so you can expand your vision and enhance the most important thing about you: what you believe.

Key Points from Chapter 6

- How you feel comes almost entirely from what you think.

- What you think and focus on is largely directed by your heart's greatest fears and desires.
- Your state is the combination of your greatest desires, your beliefs about yourself, where you place your attention, and your physiology.
- What we desire most greatly affects our ability to control our feelings—make sure those desires line up with your deepest values and the most powerful resources, like love, wisdom, and courage.
- We must focus our attention on that which empowers and control what we pay attention to.
- Getting centered is a way of controlling the flow of oxygen and your thoughts to bring your energy to the body's center.
- Expectations of how things should be are a future orientation, taking us out of the present, inviting doubts and fears. The key is to expect abundance and not be attached to it, so you're prepared to suffer.
- We can anchor the feelings we want and change to a more resourceful state when we're not feeling how we want to feel.
- Practice paying attention and focusing in a broader, more relaxed manner, which in turn helps you reduce stress and become more aware.

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- Take an inventory of past performances, good and bad, and look for

patterns in what you felt. How do feelings affect your performance?
How did those emotions come about?

- Think of your environment at home and at work. What are the images, words, and sounds in that environment? What can you do to put more empowering images and words into that space?
- Commit to getting centered twice a day this week for three minutes each time. Do it when you're frustrated, upset, nervous, angry, or anytime you're not present. Record in your journal how it affected you.
- How much time do you spend on empowering activities versus distracting activities? What do you need to sacrifice to balance the scales?
- Consider making a collage of your goals and dreams, or even a movie. Start collecting photographs and ideas of who you want to be, how you want to live, and the type of person you want to become.

The World Is Flat

How to Develop Beliefs in Line with your Dreams

In the sky, there is no distinction between east and west; people create distinctions in their own minds and then believe them to be true.

—Gautama Siddhartha, Zen master

Tyrone ran for the fence but didn't quite make it. The store owner unloaded his shotgun at the kids who he thought broke his window. Little Ty got hit multiple times. He was five years old. He grew up in the Lafayette Court Housing Project of East Baltimore. His father was a drug dealer and spent most of Ty's childhood in prison. It was a time of survival. Tyrone saw a kid get stabbed multiple times, another beaten to death with a baseball bat, and another shot in the back on the basketball court. When asked about his childhood, he said, "It wasn't an easy life, but it was the best for me." Tyrone "Muggsy" Bogues went on to play 14 years in the NBA, with pellets still embedded in his body from that day in East Baltimore.

Faced with overwhelming adversity, Muggsy found his way from the projects to playing in the NBA, from getting shot as a kid to shooting baskets for a living—a five-foot-three-inch miracle. He had talent—his forty-four-inch vertical jump attests to that—but his mind is what set him apart. The five-year-old boy who got shot was overshadowed by the kid with a dream, one that he kept alive throughout his childhood. Muggsy had to use his imagination every day to feed this dream and develop the story that would one day unfold, as impossible as it was, just as he had imagined.

Everyone has a story. You're the author and narrator of your story; you

choose which moments of life have meaning and how meaningful they are. Every moment provides you with an opportunity to decide in which direction your story will head. Every thought is part of the story line. *It's these thoughts, and how they get directed, that determine the course of your life.* The pictures in your mind and the meaning you attach to them lay out the story. It's all too easy to forget the story you once had, the amazing one that waits to be written, the one that still lives in your imagination, the one not toned down by setbacks, logic, and rationalization. It's ridiculous to think that a five-foot-three-inch kid from the ghetto can play in the NBA, but anything is possible in the imagination. If Muggsy can dream his life and live his dream, you can too.

In the previous chapter we learned how to control your energy and how you feel. Now we'll search for the wisdom needed to see the world the way it really is, and learn how to expand our vision. We'll investigate the most important factor that impacts everything about you, including how you perform, how you think, how you feel, how you communicate, what you achieve and who you become: your beliefs.

The X Factor

Remember, when we're walking around day to day, we're not operating in the world as it is, we're operating in the world that we've created in our minds. We're not looking at the world as *it* is, we're seeing the world as we are. What we see is a combination of our memories and beliefs. We're living out the story we've been telling ourselves over the years. That story is crucial.

Imagine you're an NFL kicker. There are a few seconds left in the Super

Bowl and your team is down by a point. You're called on to kick a 40-yard game-winning field goal. You'll be either the hero or the goat (the person who gets blamed for the loss—not G.O.A.T.). Which will it be? Will you succeed? The primary factor that determines whether or not that kick is successful is not your form, it's not the wind, not how the holder held the ball, or how the center hiked it. Those are all important, but the driving force for the result of that kick are the thoughts, feelings, and beliefs you've had in the months and weeks leading up to the Super Bowl. *The main element on which the success of that kick hinges is your belief about your abilities and whether or not you're the type of person who—in this case—kicks game-winning field goals in Super Bowls.* Which type of person are you?

If you want to know why some high performers consistently get good breaks and things somehow work out, their secret weapon and the main separator between them and everyone else is this: their subconscious beliefs about what's possible in their lives. Those beliefs determine what time they wake up, how they talk to themselves, how much they are willing to sacrifice, and most everything else about their lives.

The Nature of Beliefs

It's not about what you deserve, it's about what you believe, and I believe in love.

—Wonder Woman, DC Comics Superhero

To children, the world is full of exciting opportunities. As you grow up, that perspective changes. You have experiences that form your beliefs regarding

what you can and can't do. You touch a hot stove and learn not to do that. Many of your experiences “teach” you what you can't do. Your efforts get dashed; your beliefs get challenged. Perhaps you liked to sing as a kid, and the first time you sang in front of others, people made fun of you. That early experience taught you that maybe you're not meant to be a singer or you're not very talented. You “learned” in that moment and created a belief about your singing. That belief may stay with you the rest of your life. What happened was that you had an experience that caused you to feel a certain way—in this case, rejected—and that occurrence set the bar for your beliefs about that area of your life. Unfortunately, most people simply give up on that skill or area of life, never finding out how good they could be if they challenged their limiting belief.

A belief can be created quickly—sometimes in an instant— and often stays for a lifetime. Say, for example, you're an eight-year-old kid, and you see a dark, round shape as you climb into bed. Thinking it's a big spider, you scream, only to realize that it was just a ball of yarn. What's real doesn't matter. What matters is what you believe, and in that instant your brain believed it was a big spider. You reacted with fear, a feeling that your brain connected to the experience and filed away, in order to protect you in the future. For the rest of your life, your brain does its job, latching onto that fear whenever you see a spider or something that looks like one.

Thankfully, beliefs aren't set in stone. If that fear of spiders, or any other belief, is not serving you how you'd like, you can change it. It doesn't matter how logical, ingrained, or traumatic your experience was that created that belief: you can unlearn what you learned. (Chapter 9 will show you how.)

When you set a goal, examine your beliefs about that goal. You may ask

yourself directly, “What are the three main beliefs I have around achieving this goal?” Is each belief useful for you now, in this situation? What would you have to believe to achieve your goal?

In the case of the fear of spiders, meaning was assigned into the arachnophobe’s brain at the time of the incident. The same thing happens in other areas of life. With each new experience, your brain will attempt to assign meaning to the experience in order to understand how to respond. The subconscious mind goes through its checklist of questions: Is this relevant to me? What do I have in my databank of experiences that relates to this? Is this something I should be afraid of, or is it something I’ve mastered?

Beliefs set the boundaries for what’s possible in your life. They also attract situations that try to keep those beliefs intact. It’s called homeostasis—the effort of the subconscious mind to maintain a certain level of skill or achievement, whatever the individual believes is right for him or her. For example, if you’re performing above what you believe you are capable of doing, your subconscious will try to bring the performance down to your comfort level. By the same token, if you’re performing below what you believe you can do, your subconscious will work to bring the results back up to match your comfort level. You will always draw experiences into your life to support your beliefs.

Your experiences create your beliefs, and your beliefs bring more of those experiences. If, for example, you have a favorable experience with a group of colleagues, then you become more comfortable around them, and your belief regarding your acceptance creates more favorable experiences. Of course, it goes the other way too. The important lesson is that beliefs are created by everything you think, say and feel, but especially what you feel.

How to Create Beliefs

If you were in a traumatic car accident, your subconscious mind may have created a belief that cars are dangerous. The stronger the negative feeling attached to an experience, the more likely it is you'll create a negative belief from that experience. Whether it's a car accident, a missed putt, an own goal in soccer, or some other painful memory, the subconscious treats it all the same: it will create a belief out of it to protect you, that is, if the negative emotions around it were strong enough to derail any previous belief.

In 1992, head baseball coach Andy Lopez at Pepperdine University had a question: How can I get my players to be comfortable seeing themselves playing in the College World Series—and believe they can win—when we're such a small school competing against the powerhouses? Lopez decided to play a video of the College World Series on a continuous loop in the locker room every day, from the very first day of practice throughout the entire season. He wanted his players to constantly feel the intensity and atmosphere of where they wanted to be. Lopez's little school won the College World Series (watch it [here](#)).

Speak the Truth About the Past

One of the most important factors in developing beliefs in line with your goals and dreams is to speak the truth about who you are and what's possible in your life. It's especially important to speak the truth about the past, making sure you say everything that you *don't* want to continue as a past tense issue. The reason it's so important, no matter who you're talking to—even Charlie my rabbit—is that your subconscious is listening to

everything you think, feel, and say, ready to make a belief out of it.

The truth is, you may have screwed up or failed or struggled mightily with some part of your performance or life, but it's all in the past. Every single time you failed is in the past. So speak truthfully about it as past tense.

If you're a golfer and you tell yourself (or anyone) "I'm struggling with my putting," or "I'm struggling in pressure situations," or I'm struggling with _____ (insert any issue), then your subconscious mind goes into the past, looks for a pattern (proof), finds a memory/picture/feeling, and confirms what you're saying. It then takes you out of the moment (where unlimited opportunities exist) and brings the failures from the past to the present and future, continuing what you want to stop. This mental trap has prolonged countless slumps and ended many careers.

However, if you're a golfer and you tell yourself (or anyone), "In the past, I struggled with _____ but I'm getting better every day," or "This afternoon I failed at _____," you're speaking the truth, while making sure you say it as past tense (for everything that you don't want to continue). When you speak the truth this way, your subconscious mind doesn't go looking for proof of past failures to bring to the future, because you're not talking about struggles or failures in present tense. Remember this principle:

Speak the truth about the past to create possibilities in the future.

One Second Tingling Feeling of Excitement

One of the objectives I give every client is to visualize some aspect of their biggest goals and dreams every day, with the aim of really feeling it as if

it's real, so much so that they get a tingling feeling of excitement for at least one second. You don't need to meditate for an hour every day and sit cross-legged visualizing 30 minutes a day. That may be helpful, but what's most important is to see and feel your goals and dreams every day, even if for only a second.

Snap That Band!

If your goal is a challenging one, the Trickster will continually remind you of past failures, so you need a plan to override negative thoughts. Here are a few tools to use when your mind starts to think negative:

- Dismiss the thought immediately, knowing that a thought has power only by what you give it, and you give it power by letting it linger.
 - You might see it like a surfer waiting for waves, letting thoughts go by, riding only the ones you choose.
- Replace the thought with the opposite thought or a similar affirmation. (For example, "I'm terrible at ____" becomes "I'm great at ____.")
- Shout, "Stop!" in your head, and see an oversize red stop sign or see the giant letters S-T-O-P written across a whiteboard.
- Snap yourself back to the present. Wear a rubber band on your wrist and snap it each time a negative thought around your goal enters your mind.

Negative thoughts are strongest when we fail, or when we feel that we did. In those moments of vulnerability, we must be prepared to handle the negative thoughts that will come and that could escalate into further

mistakes or problems. The Trickster wants to say, “I told you so,” and if we’re not careful, those thoughts will have sufficient power (when we allow them to linger) to attract more negative thoughts, change our state, and internalize the failure (we feel like a failure). That feeling translates into a belief.

What’s really powerful is to learn how to change your state (as discussed in Chapter 6) so you’re not controlled by your emotions. Then you can stay on course to achieve your goals and dreams, continuing to expand what you believe is possible.

We need to be conscious of our goals and dreams at all times. This means learning to talk to ourselves throughout the day and imagining possibilities in line with who we want to become. One Olympic champion, for example, installed a forty-two-inch hurdle in his living room that he cleared as many as twenty-five times a day. Every time he did that, he put an image in his mind of hurdling and the success that would come.

As we learn to change our state to a consistently positive one, focused on our dreams and goals, we are better able to change how we see the world and our beliefs.

You Can Change Your Beliefs

“Failure is a feeling long before it’s an actual result.”

—Michelle Obama, *Becoming*

University of Texas softball star Cat Osterman threw a nasty drop ball to Callista Balko and struck her out for the ninth time in nine tries since the start of the season. The Women’s College World Series (WCWS) was under

way, and Osterman, one of the best pitchers to ever play the game, was once again throwing a no-hitter, with Balko another casualty. Texas was one of the favorites to win it all, relying on the dominant left arm of the team's masterful pitcher. In the sixth inning a runner walked and stole second base. Osterman walked the next batter to get to Balko, only to give up the game-winning hit as Balko's team went on to win the WCWS.

For Callista Balko, as with Lewis Gordon Pugh, there seems to have been a dramatic shift in consciousness somewhere along the way. Pugh had two major failures days before his world record; Balko struck out all nine plate appearances against Osterman that year. Then in the biggest at-bat of her life, she got the game-winning hit. What shifted for Pugh and Balko?

Their perceptions shifted. Their states changed. Beliefs can and do change all the time. Balko did it by creating a connection with what she wanted to achieve and continually shifting negative thoughts into positive, successful ones. She affirmed and visualized her goals daily. In the preseason she had begun visualizing the exact scenario that came up, and she did it just about every day for months. The scenario she visualized? With Cat Osterman pitching, the game-winning run on second base, and the World Series on the line, she gets the game-winning hit. Balko said that when they were walking the batter to get to her, she was filled with confidence. Then, when she was on first base, all she could think about was how she had visualized this for months and, sure enough, it all came true.

Affirmations

What Balko did was create a picture in her mind, one that seemed far-fetched at the time, and continually affirmed that picture. Affirmations are

statements about yourself regarding how you'd like to be in the future, as if it were true today. An affirmation should be stated in the positive ("I am," versus "I never" or "I don't") and fairly short. Here are some of Balko's affirmations:

- I am the team MVP (Most Valuable Player) She was!
- I am a dominating, powerful hitter.
- I am smooth and flawless in the field.
- I love pressure—the more intense, the better I play.
- I am an incredible two-strike hitter.
- I control my destiny.

Of course, this was all in conjunction with her tremendous effort at practice and in the weight room, as well as learning to be present on and off the field. Balko's mind regularly took her to the World Series in June, visualizing playing in front of the huge crowd, on national TV, with the pressure on, getting the game-winning hit. She had a script written out (before the season started) for her interview with the reporter after the championship game, including questions and descriptions about the big hit and how she was able to finally break through, along with her answers for each question. The script helped her visualize in detail the scene of her success. Balko continually visualized herself in the locker room after the World Series. When the actual event arrived, she had visualized it unfolding a certain way so many times, with the accompanying feelings, that she got those same feelings again during the game.

You don't have to believe your affirmation when you begin. In fact, it's most likely that you will not truly believe it; if you did, you would not need

to affirm it—it would already be a part of your consciousness. The reason you are affirming it is to make it into a part of your consciousness, and this effort requires a planned attack, working on it daily, just as if you were training your body.

One of the most powerful techniques for changing your beliefs is to model someone who has the belief that you want to have. If you can see the world the way that person does, you can learn to believe in the same way that he or she believes. For any situation, you can ask yourself, “What does [the person who’s best in the world at this] believe about himself regarding this sort of thing?” “What does he repeatedly say to himself?” Maybe your affirmation is, “I am an inspiring public speaker,” but right now you are scared to death of public speaking. You may imagine how your favorite ESPN reporter feels when speaking into a camera, or anyone else who inspires confidence as a speaker. Then you can imagine that you feel what your role model would feel.

One way to create powerful reminders of who you are and how you live is to put affirmations in your phone that silently pop up throughout the day.

Here are some affirmations I have on my phone:

- Something incredible is happening.
 - This statement directly counters the deceptions of the Trickster and the Critic. Sometimes amazing things are happening, in the best possible manner, but we just can’t see them.
- Jim Murphy is the best coach in the world.
- Extraordinary opportunities pursue me daily.
- I live my purpose every day, sharing God’s love, wisdom and courage with the world.

- My body is a fit, powerful machine.
 - We're often too quick to say, "That's my bad leg," or "That's my weak side." Remember, the subconscious just wants to make our beliefs real. When I tore my Achilles tendon a few years ago, I was really down and thinking negatively. One day I grabbed a magic marker and wrote on my cast: "My body is an incredibly powerful healing machine." My leg healed in record time.
- *Inner Excellence* is the best high-performance system in the world.
- I'm here to serve, not be served.

Whenever you're not feeling positive or confident, act as if you are. Stand tall, look up, and remember all things are possible to those who believe. Your beliefs are constantly being reinforced or created every day of your life, based on what you repeatedly think and feel, especially what you feel.

When you're standing in line or whenever you have spare time, if your mind is clear and your heart is free, your thoughts will drift toward an image of your goal, an affirmation, or some other positive idea. As your consciousness gets more and more in tune with your long-term goals and dreams, putting a possibility spin on negative or neutral events will become natural. If you repeat your affirmation like a mantra while you're standing in line or waiting in traffic, you'll find that your energy will change.

The Final Piece to Beliefs

One common hindrance to achieving your goals is a subconscious belief that reaching a certain goal will affect you negatively in some area of your life. For instance, say your goal is to be a star athlete or president of the company. How will achieving that goal change your life? You'll likely have

a lot of money, celebrity, and status. Does that outcome conflict in any way with your values? If you happen to feel that being financially wealthy is a bad thing, you may subconsciously sabotage your goal in order to preserve your values. An athlete may routinely get injured before big events if he or she harbors a subconscious belief that winning those events isn't congruent or is undeserved.

Take trying to quit smoking as an example. One reason many smokers struggle to quit is that their habit has social benefits: they belong to a group with a common bond that perhaps they would lose if they were to quit. The nicotine, therefore, is only part of the equation.

In order to expand your beliefs, it's important to make sure your goals and dreams align with your true self (i.e., how you want to live and who you're meant to become). Otherwise you may subconsciously sabotage yourself because part of you is afraid that if you achieve this big goal, you'll lose something important to you, (e.g. your social life if you smoke) or gain something that part of you feels would not be good for you (e.g. fame, or unwanted attention on social media).

Since I was a little kid, my dream, for example, was always to be a star in the NFL, NBA or MLB. When I was drafted by the Chicago Cubs, it was a dream come true—something I had imagined pretty much every day since grade school. However, I also grew up with a very strict Irish-Catholic father and intensely disciplined Japanese mother. While it was a loving home, becoming rich and famous were thought (perhaps rightly so) to be dangerous to a person's character.

Shortly after I signed my professional contract, I started to develop vision problems, which I never had before. The doctors called it a loss of dynamic visual acuity but couldn't explain the cause. I battled with it for five years

and it eventually ended my career. I believe there was a subconscious disconnect between my dreams of becoming an MLB superstar and something inside of me that agreed with my parents, or at least didn't want to disregard their opinions.

Learn from my experience. Visualize your dreams coming true, but also ask yourself what achieving your dreams will give you. Will it create changes in your life that may be incongruent to the person you want to become or how you want to live?

It's important to picture yourself living your dreams and the life you'll have after it's achieved for three reasons:

1. It's crucial for developing the grit (passion and perseverance) needed to overcome the obstacles that will come.
2. Your subconscious mind is continually connecting you with the pictures and feelings you have for your life, working to make those connections a reality.
3. It's important to deal with any disconnect that achieving your dream might create for you, in order to eliminate any subconscious sabotage.

As you learn to visualize, you'll learn to connect with your future self and the person you want to become. It's a story you are creating every day by your repeated thoughts and feelings. How will it unfold? Is your world flat? In some way or another, everyone has limiting beliefs, but you can change yours if you want to.

How Convicted Felons Transformed Their Beliefs

[The Delancey Street Foundation](#) is an organization that runs award-winning, multimillion-dollar businesses . The organization is extraordinary, and not just due to its success. All employees are convicted criminals, primarily illiterate drug addicts, who live together in a communal building. The average employee arrives never having held a job for more than six months. Upon entering Delancey, drug addicts must quit “cold turkey” and commit to staying a minimum of two years. No outsiders work for Delancey—residents “police” themselves. Mimi Silbert, CEO, runs the organization without government funding. She also lives in the facility and draws no salary. How do they do it?

Silbert, who has PhDs in psychology and criminology, is an expert at developing people. Chief among her abilities is getting people to feel what it’s like to be successful. She asks these violent criminals, who arrive with severely limiting beliefs, to “act as if” they believe they could become caring, productive citizens. She teaches them how to respect and care for each other and, especially how to take responsibility for their actions.

Delancey employees teach skills to each other, and, perhaps most beneficial of all, they gain a purpose beyond themselves. Each man and woman is taught that “though no one can undo the past, we can balance the scales by doing good deeds and earning back our own self-respect, decency, and a legitimate place in mainstream society.” Even the bottom five percent of society, as Silbert lovingly refers to the residents she calls her family, can achieve extraordinary goals with hope and a dream. Slowly, as they get a sense of what it would be like to reach their goals, they transform into the people they want to become.

The world is flat if you believe it is. It may as well be, because you’ll never venture far enough to discover the truth until you change your belief.

The reality you create in your mind is all that matters, in performance and in your daily life. As we continually learn to expand our beliefs, as Muggsy did, we must also learn to leverage those beliefs by being fully engaged in the present moment, where all extraordinary success happens.

Key Points from Chapter 7

- Beliefs are habits of behavior and expectation that are formed from how we interpret the events in our lives.
- We each have our own filter through which we view the world. We can control our experiences by adjusting this filter.
- Your beliefs come from your repeated thoughts and feelings; those beliefs attract experiences to match your beliefs.
- You can change your beliefs by continually changing your state to match that of the belief you want. If you continually model how someone else thinks and feels, you can match that person's beliefs.
- Beliefs create a comfort level of what's possible and what's not. This process provides a range of performance and expectation for the subconscious to stay within.
- Learning to recognize negative thoughts and immediately replacing them with what's true and possible is a powerful way to help change your beliefs.

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- Examine your beliefs about your goals. Pick a goal, and write down three beliefs you have about reaching it. Are those beliefs empowering? What do you have to change to achieve your goal?
- What do you need to set up in your environment so that you'll regularly get the feeling of success necessary to create a belief that your subconscious will relentlessly pursue?
- Practice observing your thoughts without judging them. What kind of patterns did you find?
- Wear an elastic band around your wrist and snap it every time a negative thought lingers in your head. Replace that negative thought with a positive thought.
- Write out, in full detail, article about yourself as if your goal had come true.
- Post photographs and affirmations of your goals and dreams on your walls where you'll see them every day.

A Clear and Present Beauty
The Five Most Powerful Ways to Be Fully Present

*The mind should be neither solemn nor agitated, neither pensive nor fearful
... the will should not be heavy, but the depth of one's awareness should be.*

—Miyamoto Musashi, samurai

Around the start of the twentieth century, Guglielmo Marconi sent a message across the Atlantic that changed history. He enabled people to communicate via radio waves—but what did he really do? Marconi (and his counterpart Nikola Tesla), only tapped into what was already there. They didn't invent radio waves, just as Benjamin Franklin didn't invent electricity. Radio waves and electrical currents were always there, always available, just waiting for us to get in tune with and connect with their energy. So it is with beauty, presence and confidence—they're always there, regardless of personal experience, patiently waiting for you.

Beauty is everywhere. Does the sun ever stop shining? Do the mountains ever cease reflecting glory? Our pursuit of achievement often leads to impatience that prevents us from seeing this beauty. We want success and we want it now. We chase after goals, immersed in activity, looking for ways of doing things better, faster, and more easily. Then we hit roadblocks and get knocked down. We pick ourselves up, get rolling again, and get hit again. Sometimes the obstacles are big and heavy and become brick walls. Most of us turn back dejected, but a few grab some rope and climb the wall. Those who persevere may have a limited line of sight, but their vision is still expansive, their eyes above the horizon as they climb. They're the ones

who have learned to be fully present amid the adversity.

In this chapter we'll look at how to increase our awareness so we can transcend our circumstances and be ready for the opportunities that always await. We'll discuss five of the most powerful ways to be fully present:

1. Get out of your head—and into your heart—and soul.
2. Focus on your routines and only what you can control.
3. Be grateful.
4. Focus on a mantra.
5. Ruthlessly eliminate hurry.

Before expanding on these five concepts, let's get clear on what it is to be fully present.

The Power of Full Engagement

To be fully present is to have a mind that is not thinking about the past or future. Whether you're anxious or angry, irritated or embarrassed, offended or afraid, those are all emotions caused by a mind caught up in the past or future.

When we're fully present, however, time changes (goes by quickly because we're caught up in the moment, or slows down as we see moments with more clarity), movements become effortless, awareness is heightened, and we may even feel as if we're spectators watching our own lives unfold. Artists, musicians, and athletes—performers—have all described moments like that.

Andrew Robb, Canadian national champion golfer and professional singer, described singing opera: "It's like playing golf. I want to be one with

the moment and get beyond the actual task. In one particularly transcendent concert I was giving, I almost blacked out. Not from fear or nervousness, but from being so removed from my body as to have temporarily forgotten I was even onstage.” To be fully present is to reach a higher level of consciousness, a more powerful vibration of energy.

The Monks in the Market

To be fully present is foundational for winning the toughest battle: the one within. This battle is a daily journey filled with moments that have more meaning and are more rewarding than the final score. International bestselling author John Kehoe (*Mind Power into the Twenty-First Century*) tells a story about a trip through Tibet, where he witnessed a sandpainting project in progress.

In a local market, maroon-robed monks worked diligently, day after day, creating the intricate forms that made up the mandala. Different colors of sand were used, and each detail was completed with the utmost attention. There were six or more monks working on it at any given time. Each day when he returned to the market, John looked forward to seeing what new designs had been created. It took more than a week to finally finish the painting.

An elaborate ceremony followed, and then something totally unexpected happened: all at once they destroyed the painting. The hundreds of man-hours that it took to create this beautiful masterpiece were wiped away in a single moment. John said, “I was stunned. This action defies our Western sensibilities. Our Western notion of labor is that we work in order to achieve a result. It is what we produce from our effort that is important. But

to the Buddhist it is the process that matters, not the final achievement. It is the attentiveness to each moment.”

Figure 8.1 shows various elements of being fully present and how all those parts lead to resonance, that powerful flow of energy in which frequencies align in effortless excitement.

Figure 8.1 The Expansive Power of Being Fully Present



In performance, desire is a powerful motivator. It pushes us to be disciplined and do the work that needs to be done in order to improve. Desire, however, can also prevent us from giving our best performances if it

is not controlled. We really want to be successful, but for that to happen, we must be so focused in the moment of performance that desires fade away. Don't confuse desire with passion. Passion is found in the present, while desire is focused on the future.

When you desire a certain outcome, you are constantly judging whether that outcome will materialize or not. When you're present your focus is absolute in the moment. Thoughts have diminished to the point where desires have moved to the subconscious, with the outcome no longer a concern.

Imagine Bubba Watson or Tiger Woods lining up a six-foot putt to win a major tournament. In the moment of execution, they, as well as the rest of us, would perform best with a clear mind and an unburdened heart. The desire for the ball to go into the hole is not part of a clear mind—it's a thought wishing to control the future, which cannot be completely controlled. The time to look into the future is before the shot, visualizing the ball going into the hole. During performance, there are no thoughts about the outcome whatsoever when you're fully present. Legendary martial artist Bruce Lee put it this way:

The great mistake is to anticipate the outcome of the engagement; you ought not to be thinking of whether it ends in victory or in defeat.

If you had to narrow it down to the two most important factors in peak performance, you would find that it's your beliefs about what's possible in your life, and your ability to be fully present. More specifically, it would be your ability to imagine, visualize and connect with the energy of great achievements, as well as developing a heightened awareness of your

environment while you're competing, without analyzing or judging it. This is also crucial in every area of your life.

Let's go through the five powerful ways to be fully present:

1. Get out of Your Head—and into Your Heart—and Soul

It is not daily increase but daily decrease; hack away the unessential... to obtain enlightenment means the extinction of everything which obscures the "real" life.

—Bruce Lee, martial artist

In our culture of comparison and information overload, it's easy to get distracted by the Monkey Mind. Our minds can process only one thought at a time, and if there's multiple concerns, the mind gets cluttered and anxiety follows. Anxiety is a mind that has too many thoughts, coming from too many concerns.

A mind with too many thoughts and concerns is the result of a heart that doesn't have one single, unifying devotion. The mind thinks, "What about this? What about that? Who will take care of this? How is that going to work out?" When the world is a click, tap or swipe away from our fingertips, it can be overwhelming. But don't worry. There's a solution.

Imagine it's New Year's Eve 2010. You live a typical busy life with its everyday worries and anxieties and tonight you're thinking about the year to come. Twelve days later Haiti has the most devastating earthquake in 200 years that takes the lives of hundreds of thousands of people. You get on a plane to Haiti and spend a week digging people out of the rubble. During that week when you're saving lives, how concerned are you about your

personal success, about the match you just lost or promotion you didn't get? Chances are you aren't. You are focused on saving this one person under the wreckage beneath you. Your focus is on the single moment in front of you. It creates a selflessness that is fearless. It makes you very present.

To reduce the effect of the Monkey Mind, one of the most powerful things you can do is simplify your life down to the essentials. Philosopher Dietrich Bonhoeffer wisely wrote, "Your heart has room for only one all-embracing devotion."

Perhaps you're thinking, "How can I have just one thing? I've got my family, kids, work, finances..." and so on. What I'm saying is that if you want to live with peace and confidence independent of your circumstances, and perform your best in each of those areas, you need to simplify your life. You need to sort out your heart. If you had to choose only one thing to devote your life to, what would it be?

Here's a place you can start: What if you were to devote yourself to raising the level of excellence in your life, to learn and grow, in order to raise it in others?

Say you decide to make that your life's focus, at least for now. Then you'll want to make it the first thing you think about when you wake up, the last thing you think about before bed, and use it to filter every decision in your life. With a clear purpose, it's much easier to be courageous (because you know what you're living for) and easier to narrow your life down to one focus and one moment—this moment.

In 2014, Michael Phelps got a ticket for drunk driving. It sent him spiraling into a depression so severe, he considered taking his life. Phelps, decorated with more gold medals all-time (23) than 173 countries, had struggled with anxiety his whole life. His anxiety masked another struggle

he was having with his identity: Who was he? Is this who he wanted to be? He shares what helped him:

I think the biggest thing is trying to get to that point where you get comfortable with who you are, of actually looking in the mirror and liking who you see. The biggest thing I had to do to get to that point was figure out what could I remove from my life to make my life simpler.

If you simplify your life, focusing on one thing that puts the needs of others before your own, you will be present and fearless. Then, this presence will be with you during ordinary tasks; when you're washing dishes, you can wash one dish, and focus only on doing it well; then do the next dish. If you're working out in the gym, you can do one repetition well (with your thoughts on the muscles you're working and proper form) and then the next. If you're writing, you can do as Hemingway said: write one true sentence. The focus is not on the past or future; the focus is on the most basic element of the current task.

Most people, most of the time, are living their lives in their heads. In other words, they go about their day analyzing and judging instead of feeling and imagining. There's an extraordinary life waiting for you, if you can get out of your head into your heart.

See if you can spend five minutes today outside of the monologue in your head—the one that's constantly analyzing, doubting, judging. Focus on your breath and feel your body. Practice using your peripheral vision. Here's a tool you can try:

- Stop and listen for the loudest sound you can hear. Focus on that

sound. Then focus on the quietest sound you can hear and focus on that. Then see if you can focus on both at the same time. Next, focus on one body part that you can feel right now. Then add the loudest sound and then the quietest so you've got three things to be aware of. What was that like? Were you able to stop the monologue in your head?

2. Focus on Your Routines and Only What You Can Control

Simplicity is the key to brilliance.

—Bruce Lee, martial artist

Inner Excellence is a series of principles and tools based on love, wisdom and courage that can be incorporated into our daily habits of thought and action. Those who embrace Inner Excellence devote their lives to developing self-mastery while living with purpose/serving others.

Two things to remember when focusing on your routines:

1. Routines are the foundation of *Inner Excellence*. Your life is a series of routines, intentional or not. The results in your life are mostly from the habits of thoughts and behaviors you've had up to now.
2. Let go of what you can't control. If you are unable to do your routine, that's how it's supposed to be on that day. Be meticulous about your routines but never attached to them.

Colorado Rockies performance coach Ronn Svetich shares a between-inning routine for a pitcher in baseball, what he calls having a simple mind.

I create a simple mind by being in control of what I can control, and what I can control is a simple mind,” he says. “A simple mind is to get the sign [which pitch to throw] from the catcher, see the pitch in your mind, and then throw it. When you’re starting to think about the umpire, the score, the base runners, the batter, your simple mind is lost.” Those other factors are things to be aware of intuitively, not things to analyze between pitches. He tells his pitchers, “Your goal while pitching is to have a simple mind. Throw one quality pitch. When you come back to the dugout between innings, ask yourself, ‘Did I keep a simple mind at least 80 percent of the time?’ If you did, now ask yourself what you have to do to keep this simple mind. If you didn’t, if some distraction took you out of the present moment, ask yourself what you have to do to get back your simple mind.

Here’s a powerful routine to kickstart your day:

The GPS Tool

Gratitude – Presence – Showtime

- 3 minutes – Be grateful. Go through the past 24-48 hours and recall small, specific grateful moments
- 3 minutes – Be present. With your eyes open, let go of all desires and concerns; let your thoughts come and go as you practice being present to the beauty always around you. You might incorporate one of the tools you’ve learned so far, to help you be present.
- 3 minutes – Visualize the big moments (showtime). Pick a goal or

situation in the future with all the pressure on and imagine what it would feel like under the bright lights and cameras, fully engaged, heart, mind and body.

- 1 minute – Inner Excellence Funnel
 - Go outside (ideally shoes and socks off), put your arms in a big Y (like a funnel), and imagine all the abundance of the universe flowing into you as you receive it with gratitude and joy. (Note: I generally say the Lord's Prayer when doing this, but you might say or visualize whatever fills you with positive energy.)

I asked Hall of Fame outfielder Ken Griffey Jr. if routines were important to him. He shared:

Absolutely. From January 1st until the last game of the season, I lived by my routines. I drove to the park the same way every day, listened to the same music on the way to the park, and I arrived at the same time [early enough to relax and take my time getting dressed]. Routines kept me sane.

For Griffey Jr., routines took the focus off the results and placed it on the process (i.e., what he could control).

Focusing on your routines and only what you can control can be very hard. If you're a high achiever who strives for perfection, then trying to control what you cannot has probably been a big challenge. Trying to control everything scatters your energy and creates concerns about things you do not need to be concerned about. It greatly slows you down because you have so much more to worry about. Ironically, surrendering control is

the key to gaining control.

If There's No Typos in This Section, I Published Too Late

Perfection is the enemy of presence. Trying to be perfect or control the outcome of your work is one of the biggest things that prevent us from having the presence needed to create great things and perform extraordinarily. Too often I've been slow to produce things to share with the world—perhaps even this book—in an effort to be error-free, to get it just right, to not send it out until it was perfect. Reid Hoffman, LinkedIn Co-Founder explains:

If you're not embarrassed by the first version of your product, you've launched too late. Years ago, it was helpful to measure twice, cut once, because it was a different world. Now you can (make adjustments) quickly according to customers' desires.

Anne Lamott, author of *Bird by Bird*, really helped me write the first version of this book. Her section “Sh--y first drafts” helped me stay present and stop judging my work (and myself).

All good writers write them (shi--y first drafts). This is how they end up with good second drafts and terrific third drafts. People tend to look at successful writers, writers who are getting either books published and maybe even doing well financially, and think that they sit down at their desks every morning feeling like a million dollars, feeling great about who they are and how much talent they have and what a great story they have to tell; that they take in a few deep breaths, push back their sleeves, roll their necks a few times to

get all the cricks out, and dive in, typing fully formed passages as fast as a court reporter. But this is just the fantasy of the uninitiated. I know some very great writers, writers you love who write beautifully and have made a great deal of money, and not one of them sits down routinely feeling wildly enthusiastic and confident. Not one of them writes elegant first drafts. All right, one of them does, but we do not like her very much. We do not think that she has a rich inner life or that God likes her or can even stand her.

Wanting to be in control and wanting it perfect are the same issue. Both are fueled by the fear of failure. Imagine a bull-rider demanding to be in control. He would get thrown off pretty quick. The irony is that when you try to control things that you cannot control, you have less control than if you surrender control. It's like micro-managing a team member or employee: the more you try to control them the more they push back, the worse they perform, and greater the struggle for both of you.

When you surrender control—of the people around you, of the circumstances you're facing, of the outcomes you want—you'll gain presence and open yourself to possibilities you would have missed trying to control what you cannot.

3. Be Grateful

A grateful person is a powerful person, for gratitude generates power. All abundance is based on being grateful for what we have.

—Elizabeth Kubler-Ross, *Life Lessons*

The path toward single-minded focus requires self-awareness in order for

you to recognize the Monkey Mind's chatter. It's common to multitask to get more accomplished, but the mind can process only one thought at a time. This is a good thing. You can't be anxious and grateful at the same time. You can't be judgmental and grateful simultaneously either. We need to develop awareness of our thoughts so that we can slow down the pace and direct them towards our purpose (and dreams). We need to let go of our attachments and the judgmental thoughts that so often go with them. We can do that by being grateful.

Have you ever been captivated by a stunning sunset or an inspiring scene in a movie that took your breath away? These significant moments take you out of yourself and force you to let go, replacing whatever you were feeling in that moment with an intense connection to beauty, and the gratitude that follows.

Gratitude, or thankfulness, and entitlement are at opposite ends of the spectrum. Gratitude is next to love, wisdom, and courage, and entitlement is next to anxiety, self-consciousness, and fear. Often you may feel down because all you see is rain (especially growing up in Seattle as I did). The problem isn't that the sun stopped shining, but that you cannot see its shine. There is never a lack of beauty, only a lack of vision.

Gratitude is learned best by focusing on small, specific moments. Maybe it's an unexpected smile, a call from a friend, or the meaning you find in seemingly unrelated objects. A blade of grass becomes a grateful moment when you see the color it provides the earth, the food for animals, the hiding places for ladybugs, or the contentment of a dog rolling on its back in the yard. The more grateful you are, the more beauty you will find.

A grateful mind is connected to beauty. Beauty exists even amongst the deepest anguish. As death camp survivor Dr. Viktor Frankl puts it, to be

worthy of our sufferings is beautiful. We cannot control everything that happens to us, but we can control how we respond to it and how we perceive the situation. We always have that choice. When you choose to focus your attention on gratitude, your vision expands and more beauty is available.

One trait that distinguishes top performers is their ability to recognize patterns and opportunities more quickly and more often than everyone else. A master chess player can look at a chess board and instantly find openings and opportunities and see moves far in advance. A novice will look at the same board and see nothing special. So it is with gratitude: with practice you'll be able to see the gifts, the grace, and wisdom in moments as you never have before. When you're more grateful, you'll find more links and patterns in your work and career that are connected to wisdom and beauty.

As you practice gratitude, you'll be getting more connected to beauty, and also more creative. Problem solving, a daily endeavor everyone faces, is markedly enhanced with creativity. Creativity comes from clarity and connection to beauty, just as connection to beauty increases clarity. Acting coach Konstantin Stanislavsky wrote, "Try to discover beauty everywhere: in every posture, position, thought, and scene. This exercise is very important. A creative person must be able to see and extract beauty from things which a noncreative person overlooks entirely; and he must see beauty first, not deformity."

When you arrive at your workplace tomorrow, you'll doubtless be subjected to things that have annoyed you in the past. Perhaps it's the hum of the air conditioner, a noisy coworker, or a line at the copy machine. There are endless possible annoyances, and you have good reasons to be annoyed. Good reasons notwithstanding, if you embrace everything in your

environment as if it were there to help you in some way—even if only to increase your patience—then your eyes will open to possibilities that might have been hidden before. You’ll also free up your mind for creativity. The problem isn’t the annoying event or person, the problem is the state created by your thoughts judging the event.

The Connection of Gratitude and Humility

I think a lack of humility is the greatest killer of potential, so we are not going to fall in love with ourselves just because we had a good game tonight. We understand what we’re up against.

—Rick Pitino, Hall of Fame basketball coach

Former Ohio State football coach Jim Tressel (five-time national champion) had his football players spend time in solitude every day. During that quiet time, each player must think of at least one thing for which he’s grateful. Gratitude and humility are important to an Ohio State football player. Tressel says, “If your most talented players are also your hardest workers, you’ve got a chance for real success, because everyone looks up to those guys who produce. And if those top players also have genuine humility, you really have a chance for something special.”

I flew to Coronado, California, the headquarters for the U.S. Navy Seals, the elite Special Forces unit, to interview some members as part of my research of top performers for this book. I was spending the day with one instructor, Joe D., and I asked him if humility plays a role in being a Seal. His immediate answer caught me off guard: “Definitely. Humility can defeat any opponent. We may have to enter a building to kill a bad guy, and

pride and false bravado will provoke busting down the front door, but that may get you killed. With humility you'll step back and see the situation clearly, and maybe you'll realize you need to slip in quietly through the back door."

Humility sees more of the big picture, whereas pride can make you careless. It can also get you killed. The samurai warriors cited in Chapter 4 could easily have allowed their egos to take over. Holding honor as a higher value than even their own lives, however, they couldn't risk the carelessness that giving in to ego would engender. Pride and arrogance chip away at your true self, leaving you constantly defending threats to your identity. Humility, however, creates room for learning and lays the groundwork for real confidence and inner peace.

Mimi Silbert, CEO of the Delancey Street Foundation, turns ex-cons into star businesspeople by teaching them to be humble and grateful in order to develop their sense of self. The philosophy at Delancey is based on whole-life learning, teaching each employee various vocations as well as the basic qualities of honesty, integrity, and service to others. Egos stay in check because even the CEO doesn't draw a salary. Silbert's outstanding team at Delancey has shown the world what's possible when you have a purpose beyond yourself and the courage to stay present when everything within you and society around you tries to keep you in the past.

The novelist C.S. Lewis shared this about the power of humility:

Consider the state of mind where one could design the best cathedral in the world and know it to be the best and rejoice in the fact, without being any more (or less) or otherwise glad at having done it than he would be if it had been done by another... to be completely

free from one's own bias.

This is the freedom of a mind that is fully present, a heart that is undivided and unburdened.

4. Focus on a Mantra

I am one of the best players in the world. I made sure I kept telling myself that all day. This is supposed to happen. It's okay to feel nervous, and no matter what I feel today, everybody else in the field feels exactly the same way I do. So go out there and get it done.

—Brandt Snedeker, after winning golf's biggest prize, the FedEx cup (2012)

In 2007, the Champion Golfer of the Year was up for grabs in Carnoustie, Scotland. Tiger Woods, World No. 1, was one of the favorites. Spanish golfer Sergio Garcia, however, was dominating the tournament. He had a six-stroke lead over everyone except second place Steve Stricker going into the final round. In the final few holes, Irishman Padraig Harrington crept into the lead and ended up in a four-hole playoff with Garcia.

During the playoff, Harrington had a mantra. He kept repeating the same words over and over in his head: "I'm going to win. I'm going to win. I'm going to win."

While focusing on the outcome is usually not helpful as it takes you out of the present, into the future, and onto something you want but cannot control, it worked for Harrington that day. The mantra took his mind off what could go wrong and the enormity of the situation, and onto a positive thought. He accomplished something he had never done before: he won the

British Open.

A few years ago I was invited to go motorcycle trail riding with some friends. I had a motorcycle license but had never been trail riding. After I accepted the offer, I realized that what I expected and what I got were two very different things. Rather than riding leisurely along wide logging roads, we were riding on a technical single-track trail filled with gravel and stumps and many twists and turns. I was afraid the entire time. I didn't want to let everyone else down, however, and make them wait for me. So, I used some *Inner Excellence* tools in order to stay present when my mind wanted to go to the future where fear resides. The tools I used were:

- Singing out loud. Singing out loud can be a powerful way to stay focused when the task is scary or demands complete focus. Ironically, singing a song out loud can actually improve focus on the task, as it stops the brain from going to the past and future. "I've never had someone who was on a tall building needing to balance try singing and it not help them," says Dr. Julie Angel, who did her PhD studying the mindset of the founders of parkour. "Personally, I sing the song Old MacDonald and it always helps, even though I don't particularly like that song," she says.
- Visualizing. I imagined ESPN was covering our ride and they were following me the whole time, amazed at how this rookie could keep up with the world's best. The ESPN announcers could not stop talking about this extraordinary performance taking place from such an incredible competitor.
- Mantra. I repeated this phrase over and over again; "I am the best

athlete in the world. I am the best athlete in the world.”

I used those three tools pretty much the entire time during the ride. I never really lost my fear, but I also never really let up on the throttle. I stayed with the pack and was exhilarated when I finished. Had I not used those tools, however, I’m sure I would have either totally backed off or gotten injured trying to keep up with the others.

How a Mantra Helped Me Overcome My Fear of the Cold

Wim Hof, the Iceman, is a multiple world record holder in cold exposure as well as other extraordinary feats (e.g. running a marathon in an African desert without water). Scientists have marveled at his abilities—they even injected him with an endotoxin to see if he was able to absorb it and not get sick. He did not. After his success, he then taught 12 others to do the same thing, to show it’s something that we can all learn.

In November, 2019, I participated in my first *Wim Hof Method and High Performance Training Retreat* with senior Wim Hof trainer Daniel Kluken and [Inner Mountain Expeditions](#). The purpose was to continue to deepen my understanding of mental toughness and high performance, as well as gain more tools to be present in the face of adversity to share with my clients. But I also had a personal reason: I’ve had a fear of the cold for as long as I can remember. I wanted to face my fears.

A Wim Hof Method retreat involves facing extreme cold. Our retreat was in central Norway in November, three hours north of Oslo in a small village. On day 1 we hiked about 20 minutes through the snow to a frozen creek. We then spent another 20 minutes breaking through the thick ice.

After that, we stripped down to our swimsuits and got in. It was crazy and scary and exhilarating (once I got out).

We also went on a long hike, in shorts and no shirt, without knowing where we were going or for how long. Just a little hike into the wilderness, with no expectations, and no attachments to what we thought was reasonable. The air temperature all week reached highs of eight to nine degrees below zero Celsius (15-17F). Talk about internal dialogue! Every step was another step away from “safety” and into the wild. We ended up hiking to a summit with an expansive view, although truth be told, I wasn’t enjoying the view a whole lot. The entire hike took two hours and seven minutes (not that any of us were counting ha-ha. My conscious mind definitely thought two hours was not reasonable!)

I had two mantras going during the hike: “My body is a sauna... my body is a sauna...” As well as, “My backpack is a heater... my backpack is a heater.” Those two mantras, plus my relaxed shoulders and long slow exhales, carried me to the warm cabin. The underlying power beneath it all, however, was this: A belief that all things are possible. That it’s cold only because you think it’s cold. That you are far more powerful than you think you are. We had already gotten into the frozen creek a few times, so I knew that I could do what I once believed I could not. I knew not to rely only on my eyes and logical mind. Essentially, although it was never vocalized, we were all asked a question on that hike:

Are you ready to face your fears?

As well as... Do you have faith? Are you willing to suffer? Are you ready to live moment-to-moment?

And we all learned the same thing: *You are far more powerful than you think you are. Get out of your head. Stop analyzing and judging. Your conscious mind doesn't know what's possible in your life.*

5. Ruthlessly Eliminate Hurry From Your Life

The most serious sign of hurry sickness is a diminished capacity to love. Love and hurry are fundamentally incompatible. Hurry is not a disordered schedule, it's a disordered heart.

—**John Ortberg, PhD**, *The Life You've Always Wanted*

Cardiologists Meyer Friedman and Ray Rosenman coined the phrase *hurry sickness* after noticing that many of their patients suffered from a “harrying sense of time urgency.” They defined hurry sickness as a continuous struggle and unremitting attempt to accomplish or achieve more and more things or participate in more and more events in less and less time. It's a behavior pattern characterized by continual rushing and anxiousness; it's the feeling of being chronically short of time, always trying to get ahead, and getting flustered when encountering any kind of delay. Sound familiar?

How do you know if you have hurry sickness? Here are a few symptoms often associated with hurry sickness:

- Trying to get in front of the car ahead of you when there's no reason to be in a hurry.
- Lacking patience with cashiers, other drivers, lineups, etc.
- Struggling to fall asleep.
- Feeling constantly stressed.

Have you ever found that you weren't in a hurry, but hurry was in you? Perhaps you had no deadline to meet or meeting to attend, but you were still anxious to get ahead of the car in front of you, or anxious for the lineup to go faster.

Professor Richard Jolly from the London School of Business found that 95 percent of the executives he interviewed over a ten-year period had hurry sickness. A sure sign is “repeatedly pushing the door-close button on an elevator,” says Jolly. “Half the time, those buttons aren't even connected to anything but a light bulb—they're what's called a ‘mechanical placebo.’ But even if they worked, how much time would they save? Five seconds?”

I used to think I would hurry so I could reduce my stress; hurry up and get things done so I could relax and not worry about those things anymore. The reality, however, was that hurrying was the *cause* of my stress.

Hurry is a mental and emotional state, not a physical one. Sometimes moving quickly and multi-tasking are the wisest choices—it's the mental clutter and judgment we want to drop. Hurrying comes from the belief that you are going to miss out somehow if you don't scramble. It shows a lack of faith.

Stress is a choice. You are not stressed because of your situation, you're stressed because of what you think about your situation. When you hurry, you choose stress. You choose not to believe that everything is working out for your good, that God hasn't got you, that you need to try and control things that you cannot.

Hurry eliminates joy and compassion. A deep sense of well-being, freedom and gratitude (joy) does not go with hurry. Compassion—which literally means “to suffer with”—also goes out the window when we hurry. Compassion interrupts our plans. The very nature of compassion is to drop

what you're doing and enter into someone else's pain. Hurry removes our ability to love, and without love, we need to hurry.

Hurry is a common by-product of busyness. Busyness—the lack of space in one's life—is one of the greatest barriers to being present. A study in the journal *Science* found that busyness has become so pervasive that people would rather feel pain than nothing at all. In the study, the participants preferred to shock themselves with electricity than be alone with their thoughts (and, of course, without their cell phones) for 6-15 minutes.

Trappist monk Thomas Merton said that busyness kills the root of inner wisdom:

The rush and pressure of modern life are a form, perhaps the most common form, of its innate violence. To allow oneself to be carried away by a multitude of conflicting concerns, to surrender to too many demands, to commit oneself to too many projects, to want to help everyone in everything, is to succumb to violence. The frenzy of our activism neutralizes our work for peace. It destroys our own inner capacity for peace.

A young PhD graduate of clinical psychology called his mentor one day (Dr. Dallas Willard) to make sure he was on the right track in his personal growth. Dr. John Ortberg asked Dallas what he needed to do to stay (spiritually) healthy. Dallas responded, "You must ruthlessly eliminate hurry from your life." John quickly wrote that down. "Ok, got that one," he said, "What else?" Dallas patiently replied, "There is nothing else. Hurry is the great enemy of spiritual life in our day. You must ruthlessly eliminate hurry from your life."

Hurry is the result of a lack of prioritizing the most important things in your life, especially, not prioritizing your *one* thing. When your life purpose or mission is not clear, many things can steal your energy. You'll be pulled in many directions and your boundaries will be unclear.

When you ruthlessly eliminate hurry, you're more intentional with your actions and attentive with your eyes. You'll see more. You'll realize that God didn't give you a life that you don't have time for. In our busyness we lose our true selves with our inability to be present; we eventually become numb to all around us, beauty and everything else. To be fully present takes time—there is no other way.

Busyness, for most of us, is really a compulsive search for affirmation and approval. The problem is, if we ever get the approval we want, it's always fleeting. It never stays because we're on the wrong path—searching for approval. When we're going in the wrong direction, we must hurry, because we're never getting what we truly want, but of course, the more we hurry, the more entrenched we become in busyness, and the farther and farther we get from fulfillment.

Henri Nouwen, professor at Yale and Harvard, describes why we live in compulsive busyness:

The answer is quite simple. Our identity, or sense of self, is at stake... The false self is the self which is fabricated, as Thomas Merton says, by social compulsions. "Compulsive" is indeed the best adjective for the false self. It points to the need for ongoing and increasing affirmation. Who am I? I am the one who is liked, praised, admired, disliked, hated, or despised. Whether I am a pianist, a businessman, or a minister, what matters is how I am

perceived by my world. If being busy is a good thing, then I must be busy. If having money is a sign of real freedom, then I must claim my money. If knowing many people proves my importance, I will have to make the necessary contacts. The compulsion manifests itself in the lurking fear of failing and the steady urge to prevent this by gathering more of the same - more work, more money, more friends.

Without a clear path and purpose, self will be at the center of your life, which means you need to continually gather more for self, because self is your primary concern and you can never have enough to be truly secure. With self at the center of your life (and no clear greater purpose), you'll continually circle around yourself but never find your true self. It's a dizzying, fruitless pursuit.

Just as time-outs are called in sports, you need to take time-outs in your life in order to be present. If you don't take time to sharpen the saw, as author Stephen Covey suggests, your productivity decreases. There must be gaps in the busyness, ideally every ninety minutes throughout the day, and one full day every seven days—no work, projects, shopping, or anything on the to-do list. And one full year every seven years (I'm overdue).

When we take one day a week to let go (of our attachments) and recharge, we can see with more clarity the beauty all around us, and gratitude follows naturally. If you're not grateful, there's a good chance busyness has squeezed it out of your life. Without gratitude, wisdom is not possible, at least not wisdom that understands the deep truth of who you are and what's possible in your life.

The best possible life—absolute fullness of life—is one where we're fully

present the majority of the time. This life follows a certain tempo. We can only function optimally when we live according to rhythms of work and rest, relaxation and celebration. To be our best we must walk by faith, not by sight, listen more than we speak, and have strict boundaries around our energy and routines. We need times of silence and times of celebration. Only then can we be fully engaged heart, mind and body.

True gratitude and humility are present only when you stop and really see, feel, and recognize all that you have been given to arrive here, as well as all that's possible tomorrow—even if tomorrow never comes. Self-consciousness and stress are greatly reduced when you take the time to orient your heart around what matters most so you can be fully present.

In your quest for extraordinary performance, make sure your desires are taking you where you want to go. If you aspire to absolute fullness of life, then focus your desires on love, wisdom, and courage. You'll develop a presence that will help you overcome obstacles and mental blocks—as you'll see in the next chapter—and teach you how to live.

Key Points from Chapter 8

- To be fully present is to be completely engaged in the moment, fully experiencing it, with no needs, no desires, and no thoughts of the outcome.
- Five powerful ways to stay present in pressure situations:
 - a. Get out of your head—and into your heart—and soul.
 - b. Focus on your routines and only what you can control.
 - c. Be grateful.

- d. Focus on a mantra.
- e. Ruthlessly eliminate hurry.
- In our busyness, we become numb to our senses and lose out on the creativity, insight, and dreams that come with being present.
- When you embrace what you cannot change, you free yourself to find opportunities.
- To live in non-judgmental awareness is to be free to be your true self. One of the main ways we lose our presence is from judgment (when we deliver a negative verdict on our circumstances, others, or ourselves.)

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- Observe your level of presence throughout the day. Notice times when you're frustrated or upset (or your mind is simply in the past or future), as well as the moments you were present. Keep an index card in your pocket, and check off the number of times during the day when you were present. See if you can increase that number the next day.
- Practice getting out of your head and into your heart. Imagine you are a neutral bystander, or perhaps a researcher or journalist, observing your thoughts. How does the act of observing your thoughts affect those thoughts? Notice how you can see and feel more beauty when you let go of control and get out of your head.

- Get in the habit of keeping a journal to collect data on your thoughts and feelings each day. How did those thoughts and feelings affect your ability to be present? You may start by listing a few things for which you're grateful. You may also simply write phrases or just words—whatever comes to mind in your stream of consciousness.
- Pick one of the five ways that help us to be present, and focus on that guideline for one full day. Do the same for each of the other four. On the sixth day practice getting centered and present with any of the five ways whenever you notice you're not present.
- Practice taking time-outs, from as little as one minute to a full day, during which you work on being silent, present and grateful.

Unstoppable

How to Overcome Mental Blocks, Fears and Phobias

He's not going to make it. He's not comfortable being uncomfortable.

**—Lou Piniella, Major League Baseball manager, speaking
about a rookie's frustration with failure at Spring Training**

In 1982, the Los Angeles Dodgers had a second baseman named Steve Sax, who earned the National League Rookie of the Year award. Early the following season, Sax made a relay from the outfield to the catcher that bounced off the catcher's shin guard, allowing the runner on third base to score. Sax recalls:

It was the kind of thing that could happen to anyone, but I started thinking about this error way too much. It really got in my head. Then I looked in the newspaper and saw that I had made a couple errors early in the season. I started to think, "Wow, I'm on pace to make 100-and-something errors this year." So I began to place all this horrible pressure on myself, and of course I made a throwing error the next day. Then I made a couple more throwing errors later in the week. Pretty soon I had this horrible monster in my head that I couldn't get rid of.

After a couple of months of regularly making throwing errors, I was sure that my career was in jeopardy. The more I worked at my throwing problem, the worse it got. Conventional wisdom says that if we work at something hard enough, we get over it, but that wasn't

the case for me. The team and I tried everything. The Dodger brass would bring me out to second base at Dodger Stadium in the middle of the afternoon when nobody was there, blindfold me, and have me throw the ball to first base. I'd throw it to first base without an error every single time blindfolded, but I just couldn't make the throw in the game.

My low point was when I made a humongous error against the San Diego Padres. We were winning, then they hit one to me and I threw the ball away late in the game and we lost. About a week after the Padres game, I called home to talk to my dad. I couldn't get my mind off my throwing problem—it was like a bad piece of luggage that never went anywhere—and so gradually every conversation I had always led to that issue.

My dad said, "Listen, I'm going to tell you something. One day you're going to wake up and the problem is going to be gone. I know because I went through this same problem when I played baseball in high school and it can happen to anybody." When my dad said that, I understood that if this same problem could happen to somebody as formidable as my dad, someone who is that big and ominous, then maybe I'm not so weird... it could happen to anybody.

Six hours after speaking to his dad, his father passed away. But strengthened by his father's counsel, Sax slowly regained his confidence and baseball became fun again. He didn't make an error in the last 36 games of the season, and in 1989, he had the highest fielding percentage

among second basemen in the majors. He went on to become a five-time All-Star, winning two World Series championships.

Although Sax's situation worked out in the end, similar mental blocks have often ended people's careers. This is very unfortunate, because while it took Sax months of sleepless nights to sort out his problem, a mental block like his, or a major fear, or even phobia, can generally be cured easily and quickly—sometimes in just one session.

In this chapter, I'm going to share with you how to overcome mental blocks like the one Steve Sax had, so you can learn and grow every day and be *unstoppable*. Perhaps you're thinking, I'm not a professional athlete; I don't need to know this. If so, I think you might want to reconsider. What happened to Sax happens in various ways to pretty much all of us. We all have subconscious minds that are always protecting us. This can lead to strange behavioral hiccups that can be hard to shake—like a professional baseball player losing the ability to do what little leaguers do easily (throw the ball from second base to first).

I'll show you how it works. First, let's go back to Sax and see how his mental block got started.

1. He made an error.
2. He felt bad about it.
3. He looked at his stats, then thought about the future and how he could feel really bad if he kept it up.
4. He made more errors.
5. He started to obsess about it (it became an *idée fixe*).
6. He developed a major mental block, one that could have ended his career.

The Subconscious Protector

As you're sitting here reading this book, or driving in your car listening to it, your subconscious mind is at work, attending to its three main jobs. These are:

1. Sift through all the incoming sensory information to decide what's relevant to you, and whether any of it is potentially dangerous (physically or emotionally).
2. Run your life in the background so you don't have to think about every little thing you do. (Just imagine if you had to fully think through every time you tied your shoes, brushed your teeth, or drove home from work!)
3. Line up your circumstances and results with your beliefs. For example, let's say you believe you're a golfer who generally shoots in the 70s. If, halfway through the round, you're on pace to shoot in the low 60s, your subconscious will try to get you closer to the 70s to match what you believe. Your subconscious doesn't care *what* you believe; it only cares that your life lines up with those beliefs.

The subconscious task with which we're concerned in this chapter is the first one described above: sifting through sensory information looking for physical or emotional danger.

The Brain That Changes Itself: We Can Rewire Our Brains

Every time you learn something new, a neural pathway is created that

thoughts and feelings travel along. Scientists previously thought that our brains were like machines: once they formed, they didn't really change. Now we know that our brains continuously evolve. According to Dr. Kurt Fischer, director of the Mind, Brain and Education Program at Harvard University, "There are a few broad principles that have come out of neuroscience. Number one is that the brain is remarkably plastic. Even in middle or old age, it's still adapting very actively to its environment."

In fact, new brain cells are being created over our entire lifetimes, through the process of neuroplasticity. Neuroplasticity is a fancy word to describe how the brain physically recreates and reorganizes itself in response to the environment. This dynamic process allows us to learn and adapt to different experiences. The brain literally changes its physical connections and behavior in response to new information.

What this means to you and I is that everything we watch, read, listen to and experience is having an impact on our actual brains. The good news is that this means we can literally rewire our brains by giving it new information, and we can embed that information, idea or feeling by repeating the same thought and feeling. The sky's the limit on what we want to embed and the neural pathways we want to create. It also means that strong feelings such as fear or anxiety can make new negative connections, and if we constantly think those thoughts and have those feelings, we create neural pathways that consistently take our minds and bodies places we don't want to go. Hello mental blocks.

How Fears and Phobias Form (Mental Blocks Too)

The first thing to know about your subconscious is this: it puts all danger in

the same file in your brain, whether it's physical or emotional. It doesn't differentiate between the fear of a tiger about to attack you and the fear of being attacked on Twitter or Instagram. To your brain, it's all the same.

When you have a traumatic or embarrassing experience in your life, especially in your youth, your subconscious will lock in the memory so it can warn you in the future. By locking it in, I mean it'll memorize the context of the situation—who was there, what was said, anything relevant to the circumstances—so it can alert you the next time you face something similar. It warns you with anxiety or fear, or simply by trying to stop you from doing whatever it is you're about to do that you've had a painful experience with.

Your subconscious doesn't need to protect you from good events, only painful ones. Thus, the painful ones get embedded in your psyche, so the subconscious can be on the lookout for them to protect you.

Let's say you're a tennis player and you double-fault, in a particularly important situation. You start to think about it and, with that image in your mind, you do it again in a crucial situation. The first one was not a big deal, so your subconscious gave it a pass. But the second one was emotionally distressing, so your subconscious locked it in. Why? To protect you. Because the experience was emotionally distressing, your subconscious remembers it so it can keep you from going through it again. This is helpful if you touch a hot stove, get bitten by an alligator, or tweet out something you regret, but not helpful if it brings anxiety and fear to situations you purposefully put yourself in.

It's this kind of anxiety and fear that can create mental blocks for us, even in (or especially in) situations where we are ordinarily masterful. PGA Tour golfer Tommy Armour came up with the term the yips to describe his issues

with putting, which got so bad he had to retire. He called it “a brain spasm that impairs the short game.” Wikipedia describes the yips as the loss of fine motor skills in athletes, with no known treatment or therapy. (Clearly, the Wikipedia people haven’t heard of *Inner Excellence*.)

Most often it’s the easy tasks, not the difficult ones, that become mental blocks. The mind puts more pressure on yourself for the easy ones (because of social pressure to not screw up something easy). Not too many NFL kickers are going to have mental blocks on 55-yard field goals, but a lot of them have mental blocks for extra points.

The second important thing to understand about the subconscious is what Sax realized in talking to his dad: if you have a mental block like he or Tommy Armour had, it’s not because you’re weird or strange. It’s actually the opposite. It means your subconscious is working *perfectly*. The same thing applies if you have a phobia of snakes or spiders, trains or trapezoids. When I say phobia, I mean an excessive fear or anxiety of an object or situation, a fear so strong that it can dominate your life. And as I mentioned earlier, just as mental blocks can be overcome in a single session, so can phobias. You may have had a phobia your entire life, and panic every time you see a flea or ferret, or think about flying. It doesn’t matter how long you’ve had the phobia, or how intense it is; no matter what it is, it can be cured forever.

Let’s say your friend has a phobia of spiders. How often does he panic when he sees a spider? Half the time? Eight out of ten times? No—he panics 100% of the time. This is because his subconscious is working *exactly* as it should, working to protect him from the object of his fear.

We’re not born with fears, except perhaps the fear of loud noises or falling. The rest of our fears, we’ve acquired, often in an instant. When you

know how the subconscious works, you can also remove them just as quickly. Phobias develop in a similar way to Sax's mental block:

1. An event happens that's emotionally painful or embarrassing.
2. The subconscious locks in the event—depending on the meaning you assigned to it and the feeling you felt—to protect you in the future.
3. The subconscious adds this event, and the context surrounding it, to the list of things it will warn you about or protect you from, by physically disrupting your behavior with anxiety or fear.
4. The subconscious embeds the memory as deeply and strongly as the emotional pain surrounding it.
5. Every time the subconscious recognizes a similar context, it replays the original painful event, to warn you.
6. A phobia or mental block surrounding the association is created.

Have you ever wondered why some situations are uncomfortable to you, without a logical reason? It could be a trigger or anchor (see Chapter 6). You know how that one song from high school always reminds you of that slow dance with Sexy Suzie or Handsome Harry? The song triggers a memory; the memory triggers a feeling. Cue the song and get the feeling. The song and feeling are connected for you.

The same thing happens all the time in our lives, often without our knowing it. For example, say you were threatened by someone wearing a certain kind of jacket when you were a teenager. Perhaps you've forgotten all about it. Then one day you feel uncomfortable around someone, not knowing that it's because the jacket they're wearing is similar to the one you had the painful memory about. In this case, your subconscious is

warning you on the basis of a past experience and you don't remember.

Before we move on to the specifics of how to deal with this issue, let's take a look at one more example from baseball.

The Phenomenon

In 1997, Rick Ankiel, from Port St. Lucie High School in Florida, was named High School Player of the Year by USA Today. He was drafted by the St. Louis Cardinals and received a \$2.5 million signing bonus. In 1999, at 20 years old, he made his Major League debut, and in 2000 played his first full season in the major leagues. He had a tremendous year, striking out 194 batters, (although he also walked 90 batters—both stats were top 10's). Ankiel was runner-up for the 2000 National League Rookie of the Year Award, 18 years after Steve Sax.

Cardinals manager Tony La Russa elected to start the rookie Ankiel in game one of the divisional playoffs (NLDS) against the Cubs, picking him instead of his star pitcher, 20-game winner Darryl Kyle. Ankiel was pitching well, when in the third inning, he threw a wild pitch past the catcher to the backstop. (A wild pitch is charged against a pitcher when the pitch is too high, low, or wide of home plate for the catcher to control it with ordinary effort, and a runner advances). A few pitches later he threw another one. Then another. Some of the wild pitches were so far off, the catcher couldn't get a glove on it. La Russa pulled him out of the game. (You can watch it unfold [here](#).) Even with Ankiel's wild pitching, the Cardinals won the series and went on to play the New York Mets for the National League Championship.

Days later, La Russa started Ankiel in game two of the series against the

Mets. After two walked batters and more wild pitches in two-thirds of an inning, Ankiel was again pulled out of the game. Several days later, with the season about to end and the game well out of hand, La Russa gave Ankiel one more chance to try to finish the season on a positive note. He struggled again. It was the beginning of the end for him.

Ankiel would wake up in the middle of the night with nightmares that he couldn't throw a strike. The following season, before his first game, he drank vodka before the game to try to deal with his intense anxiety. He was soon sent down to the minors, where he struggled for four years; he then climbed his way back to the major leagues, only to have his issue return right away. He decided enough was enough. He quit.

Ankiel's agent convinced him to switch positions and start over as an outfielder. Amazingly, he made it back to the major leagues in his new position and had perfect control, making 300 foot throws with laser accuracy (watch [here](#)). Ankiel is the only player in major-league history (other than a guy named Babe Ruth) to hit at least 75 career home runs and strike out at least 200 batters.

Ankiel explains how he felt after that fateful game in the playoffs, when one wild pitch turned into a monster:

I had this overwhelming feeling that I just let everyone down... my teammates, the coaches, the fans, my family, the Cardinal organization, and everyone I grew up with. Not being able to be the pitcher who I was rocked me beyond my core. I made the mistake of thinking being good at baseball was what made me who I was. When the glass shattered, there was nothing left. I was blindsided, and everyone can see right through you. I've never been bitten by a

big dog, but I'm sure if you have, every time you reach out to pet a dog, there's something in there that feels like, *this thing might bite me*. That's what it felt like on the mound. It's just this giant weight that's sitting on your shoulders. I felt loneliness, despair, what I wouldn't wish on anyone."

Let's do a quick review. We now understand that our subconscious minds are always working to protect us and are working perfectly when we have a mental block or the so-called yips. We also know that the subconscious works precisely from the knowledge it has. For Sax, it believed there was real danger for him if he threw the ball to first base; for Ankiel, it believed there was genuine danger for him pitching in a major league game. Every time these athletes thought about or attempted to perform the activity their subconscious minds had deemed dangerous, it did its job and stopped them.

So, what do we do to solve this problem? We update the subconscious with the truth and give it a new belief about the situation. The truth for Sax would have been that throwing the ball to first base was not a danger that needed to be monitored and protected. The truth for Ankiel would have been that pitching in the major leagues was not a danger that he needed protection from.

You might ask, how did their subconscious come to believe those things in the first place, such that it felt it needed to warn them with anxiety and fear? Good question. But the truth is, Sax's subconscious didn't care if he threw perfectly to first base or threw it in the dugout, nor did Ankiel's care whether he threw a perfect strike or threw it ten feet over the batter's head. In each case, the athlete's subconscious only cared about protecting him from danger—or the feeling of danger—based on the information it had at

the time. Our subconscious minds are always scanning our environment and our emotions, looking for danger and trying to sense if there's something new to protect us from. The more each of these athletes analyzed and worried about his issue, the more his subconscious believed there was in fact danger in that activity.

If Sax and Ankiel had never become concerned about how they threw a baseball, neither would their subconscious. It's the same thing in golf or tennis. The subconscious doesn't care whatsoever if you miss a two-foot putt in golf, or double fault in tennis three times in a row. It does care, however, about protecting you from the feeling of embarrassment and emotional trauma. Ironically, in order to protect you from those things, it invites further anxiety and trauma.

How to Remove the Yips, Mental Blocks, and Phobias

When your mindset is to raise your level of excellence, learning and growing in order to raise it in others, you're far less prone to mental blocks.

When I start with a new professional athlete or executive, we generally begin with a three-day retreat where I share the basics of the *Inner Excellence* mindset and the principles I've shared with you. In our first few days together, we remove the pain from their most painful memories, as well as remove any mental blocks, fears, or traumas. This is significant, and this alone can dramatically change or save an athlete's or executive's career.

When I say trauma, I mean anything from embarrassing moments in grade school to extremely serious things like abuse and assault. When we remove the trauma, I don't mean we change what happened or forget about it. I mean we (the client and I) reprogram how their subconscious mind

processes the event so it's no longer painful. What happened doesn't change, but the pain associated with it does. When the pain is gone, the mental block goes with it (because the subconscious is no longer in self-protection mode).

We find the most painful memories in their life (as uninviting as that sounds, it's often life-changing) and we reprogram them. I ask them to re-experience the pain—just for a moment to see how painful it is—and give me a rating on a scale of 1-10, 10 being the worst possible pain. I look for 9s and 10s. If you're walking around with 9s and 10s (and as adults we've all had some traumatic experiences), then undoubtably you're walking around with limitations you may not be aware of.

Once we find the most traumatic experiences, we do the work with the subconscious and remove the mental block, fear, phobia or trauma—*forever*. This may sound quite extraordinary; perhaps this is why *Inner Excellence* clients around the world have had extraordinary results.

After doing the work to remove the pain, we momentarily re-experience the memory, exactly as it happened, to make sure the pain is gone (I ask them to give me another numerical rating—this time we're looking for the number to be closer to zero). If it's not completely gone, or close to it, we continue to work on it. (Note: when we do the work, we don't get into the details of the painful memory—in fact, no details are shared at all. We just re-program the way the subconscious views the event, creating a new belief in the process.)

The principles involved in removing mental blocks, and all other mental breakdowns in our daily lives, are fairly straightforward:

1. Take the emotion out of it.

2. Find the smallest change that would have made a difference (if possible) in the situation.
3. Insert a positive, high-energy feeling—as well as the small change—into the context of the mental block.
4. Anchor that positive feeling into the original painful context, creating a new empowering association (and belief) with it.

Let's investigate how to accomplish these steps, one by one. (Note: It's a fairly involved process, so if you're not in a space to do the work, you might skip to the next section on page 205, *High Fiving Freedom for World Class Athletes*).

How to remove the emotion from a painful memory

The best way to take the emotion out of a memory is to distance yourself from the remembered event by seeing it from an observer's point of view. This is called viewing the memory in third person (or third position), taking the view from the outside, watching the event happen. It's like the view a passerby might have. First person or first position is the view you have when you're actually experiencing the situation yourself.

If we consider Sax's throwing errors, first-person view is the view from Sax's eyes. He may well have been feeling anxious and self-conscious from that viewpoint. Third-person view would be the view of him from someone in the dugout, in the stands, or watching on TV. In general, the farther the viewpoint from the person taking part in the action, the less intense the emotion will be. A casual fan watching on TV may have found Sax's throwing errors interesting or boring, depending on the person. There are exceptions: for Sax's mother, the third-person position of watching him on

TV may have felt to her like *she* was actually throwing the ball (i.e. the first person view). To reduce the emotional impact of the event in general, for Sax, his mother, or any of us, we need to move our viewpoint from super close to the action to distant from it.

One technique for accomplishing this is to imagine floating up out of your body and into the sky, as in an air balloon. As you take off, you see yourself down on the ground, with all your concerns and problems down there with you. The higher up you float, the more you see the rest of the world, and the smaller your problems become.

Another way to remove the emotion from a problem or painful event is to close your eyes and watch what happened in the form of a black and white movie. Here's how you might go about it:

Hollywood Helper: The Movie Theater Visualization

(A tool to remove the emotion from painful memories or mistakes and not carry them with you.)

Note: It might be easier if you have a partner read the instructions to you while you do the following exercises, or switch to the audio book. You can also voice record these questions, then follow the audio at your pace.

1. Close your eyes and imagine a movie theater. Any theater that comes to mind will do.
2. See yourself walking into the theater and observe a picture of yourself, in black and white, on the big screen. Find a seat in the empty theater, and then float out of your body, up and behind you, into the projection

booth.

3. Once you're in the booth, standing next to the projector, put your hands gently on the glass and feel the coolness of it. Look down and see yourself sitting in the empty theater, looking up at the picture of you on the big screen.
4. Once you do this, turn on the film projector. Imagine the film in black and white, maybe even flickering, like those old black and white movies do. The film is going to be a recording of the event you want to take the emotion out of. Once you start the projector, you'll stand there behind the cool glass, looking down at your body in the theatre, which is watching the movie play on the big screen. So you're watching yourself watching yourself.
5. After you've watched the movie, speed it up and watch it again—first twice as fast, then four times as fast, then eight times as fast, each time watching from behind the glass in the projection booth.
6. When you've watched it eight times faster than it was originally, float back down into your body and go up into the movie and put yourself *in* the film (first-person), at the very end of the film. Then, when you're ready, play the movie backwards in double speed, this time experience it in first-person. Still reliving the movie backwards, play it three more times, faster each time (four times, eight times, and sixteen times as fast).

Find the smallest change

Often in our painful memories, there's some small thing we could have

done differently that could've made a big difference. Maybe Sax calls his dad and has that conversation right away, rather than waiting months to do so. Perhaps after his first wild pitch, Ankiel calls time out and chats briefly with the catcher, and they talk about a time he had perfect accuracy, allowing him to visualize it. It doesn't have to be the perfect solution, just a potential solution to allow the subconscious mind to let go of the pain or its need for protection from the pain.

When our subconscious minds don't know how to fix a problem that's painful, we may hold on to the pain or fear to keep us from forgetting to deal with it. If we don't present a solution that allows the subconscious to resolve that feeling, then it will continue to hold on to the pain or fear.

(Note: In the case of abuse or other serious trauma, there may not be a small change available and there may be more work to do. Part of that work, for example, often entails stepping into the shoes of the abuser, to feel the fear and pain they had when they were doing this awful thing. Doing so doesn't justify the abuse, it simply helps the abused person (perhaps yourself) understand how someone could do something so terrible out of their own fear and pain, and thus distances the abused person from the experience.)

Insert a positive, high energy feeling—and the small change—into the memory

Once you've taken the emotion out of the memory and visualized the smallest change, you'll want to create a new neural pathway for the subconscious to choose when it pictures the problem. We want to create a new association—like the bell to Pavlov's dogs—that is empowering.

One way you can do this is to gather some resources to create a new,

healed memory. Remember, the subconscious mind cannot tell the difference between what you feel and what's real. Just think of the last nightmare you had, or perhaps your child had—it certainly felt real. Using this knowledge, we can heal the memory by bringing in the precise energy you would love to have in the given situation. We do that in one of two ways: by recalling a time when we had the energy we want, or by creating that energy on your own.

Say, for example, that Ankiel felt anxious and afraid every time he thought of pitching in a major league game. Let's assume he would rather have felt calm and confident. One step he could have taken to make this change would be to first recall a memory where he felt calm and confident, and then anchor that memory (see Chapter 6 for an in-depth discussion of anchoring). Then, working through a basic movie theater visualization, he'd insert that same calm, confident feeling into the film of himself in game one of the NLDS (divisional playoffs). This time, in step four (see below), instead of distancing himself from the situation, he would immerse himself in it, first person, with the new, empowering feelings he just anchored.

To embed these powerful feelings in the painful experience, we would have him bring in the feeling, add the smallest change that would make the experience a positive and resolved one, and experience it over again with the new feeling (in first-person) five to seven times. Here's how to do it:

Insert and anchor positive feelings (in this instance, calm and confidence)

1. Recall a time when you felt calm and confident. Go through all your senses to put yourself back into that experience, so you can feel exactly what you felt when it first happened. Remember all the sights, smells

and sounds, tastes and/or touches that help you recall the memory and get these feelings.

2. Once you get the good feeling, notice where you feel calm and confident in your body. Focus on this part of your body and ask your subconscious to remind you of another time you felt this way. Could be anytime in your life. Do the same thing with your senses with this memory as you did with the last memory. Repeat this process one more time to get a third memory where you felt calm and confident.
3. Once you go through these positive memories and feelings enough times that you really feel what you felt back then (calm and confident), bring those memories with you into the situation where you want to feel calm and confident.
4. Go back to the black and white movie in which you wanted a new feeling. This time, you're going to go into the movie first person (so you're experiencing it, not watching it), and you're going to bring in the feeling from your confidence memories (the three memories you found above) as well as the smallest change. The movie will start exactly the same as the original black and white movie you watched, but this time it will be in color, with the small change ready to be made, and the good energy from your confidence memories.
5. Play the movie five to seven times with those four changes (in color, first person, small change, and calm, confident feelings).

Generally, if everything is done correctly, that would be enough to make the change permanent. Our subconscious minds will always accept the new

feeling associated with the painful memory, and will let go of the pain, as long as we can present the subconscious with a new belief and solution that has a stronger connection.

The other method to bring peak performance energy into a memory is to create it on your own. For example, Ankiel could create a sense of calm and confidence through a meditative and visual exercise, as follows. Try this energy transfer “app”:

Power APP (Anchor Peak Performance)

1. Pick a spot on the floor to put the painful memory.
 - a. Picture the painful memory or problem situation out in front of you somewhere physically near, within 10 or 20 feet of you. Once you’ve done this and see the memory in that space in front of you, walk over and step into it. As you step into the spot where you’ve put the painful memory, you’re changing from third-person observer to first-person experiencer. This should make the painful feeling stronger and/or more vivid. It’s like cleaning a wound—first we need to expose it so we can get at it.
2. Shake it off.
 - a. Now step out of that painful memory. Step away from the spot on the floor where you pictured the memory. Shake off the memory and feeling by literally shaking your body and jumping a bit.
3. Get into a high-performance state (fully engaged, heart, mind and body)
 - a. Go back to where you were standing originally, perhaps 10 or 20 feet away from the spot you pictured the memory. Create peak

performance energy within yourself by using a centering tool or meditation, and perhaps by adding a positive image/memory to focus on.

- b. You might use the *countdown breathing* technique: Take a long, slow deep inhale through the nose, counting backwards from ten to seven, pause, then exhale counting six to one. Do this for a minute or two, until you feel calm and relaxed.

4. Step back into the painful memory with the good energy.

- a. Once you get into that calm, clear, meditative state, start to walk towards the spot where you put the painful memory. Take your time. Focus on your breathing. Only start to walk when your breathing is calm and relaxed and in rhythm again. If it's not, stop and breathe until you're calm again. Then, at your pace, when you are ready, step into the spot. You'll now be bringing newfound good energy with you into the painful memory.
- b. Look around and experience the past, painful situation with this new energy. Turn in a circle to see the situation from all angles, feeling this new, positive energy the whole time. Stay in that spot, feeling good energy in the problem situation, for about three or four minutes. Once you've seen the problem situation from all angles and feel good about all of it, step out.

Anchor the positive feeling

With a mental block, the subconscious goes into self-protection mode and anchors a negative feeling (the feeling that causes the block) to the action we want to do. To remove the block, therefore, we need to reduce the

emotion (ideally remove it altogether), insert the smallest change that could have helped (if possible), then get the feelings we want to feel instead and anchor them to the problem.

You might think this sounds too easy, that there's no way that going through this process removes the pain forever. I didn't believe it at first either, but in 11 years of experience removing mental blocks and painful memories, it's been amazing to watch. Once you learn how the subconscious mind works, you have a lot of power in your hands. It may take some practice to get the process figured out, but now that you know these things can absolutely be cured, sometimes in one session, and know that the cure can last forever, you should feel a weight lifted from your shoulders.

Whether you gather some good memories (and the feelings associated with them) and use those to replace the painful feelings, or you exchange the unwanted feelings with the Power APP, either way the goal is to create a new neural pathway/association for the subconscious to use rather than the old painful one. It sounds too good to be true.

In fact some who read this will believe just that, which is totally fine. You get to believe whatever you want to believe. I'm just telling you here's something you can believe in that is very powerful and can change your life, as it has for many others.

High Fiving-Freedom for World-Class Athletes

One of my PGA Tour clients (one of the top 10 golfers in the world) hit the ball into the water on a par 3 the first day of the tournament. I asked him to rate his confidence level as he pictured himself playing the hole the next

day. He said, “Very low—I see it going into the water.” We spent about 15 minutes on the phone using a similar method as above; he played that hole effortlessly for the rest of the tournament (birdies and pars).

Another PGA Tour client was playing in the Masters tournament, and the night before the event started, I asked him if any holes were uncomfortable or represented areas he lacked confidence in. He said yes, so we worked on those holes for 20 minutes or so. He birdied or parred those holes the entire tournament and finished in the top 10.

One of the top-ranked players in the world suffered physical abuse growing up (which he shared publicly). We spent the day working on his past and found the four or five most painful memories of his life, each of which he rated at an 8, 9 or 10 out of 10 on a 10-point scale (10 being the most pain). After we worked on each painful memory to remove its stranglehold—and any mental block that may have been tied to it—he rated them all afterwards as zero, one or two pain levels. It was intense work, but well worth it. He was ranked world No. 1 within six months.

Whether it’s a fear of throwing a wild pitch, a fear of not being able to throw to first base, or a fear of hitting the golf ball into the water, it’s all the same problem. The subconscious mind has linked a strong negative emotion to that event and anchored to it. If you know how to collapse the anchor—and even better—anchor a positive feeling to replace the negative one, all kinds of situations that have stopped you in the past will no longer scare you or stop you.

Final Thoughts on Mental Blocks

For most of us, the subconscious works mainly with two things: images and

feelings (although for some, words and sounds are equally important). If we were to add up all the images you saw in your mind and feelings you had today, we would have a good idea of the direction your life is headed. Ankiel and Sax had daily images and feelings associated with precisely the opposite of what they wanted. The subconscious mind, however, doesn't care what you want, it only cares about the information it has to work with and how it relates to your beliefs. If you're constantly seeing images of what you want (or don't want), and constantly having feelings of what you want (or don't want), your subconscious will work to create those results.

Remember, the images and feelings you see and have are the direction in which you are headed—and *those images and feelings are the result of your thoughts*. What you do with your thoughts and how you direct your thoughts are very important, because when those directions are constantly repeated, they become beliefs. And beliefs are what separate the best from the rest. Beliefs are the cause of mental blocks and mental toughness alike.

By now you're probably realizing that in order to maximize your potential in whatever profession you're in, and limit your susceptibility to mental blocks, you must train your whole self: heart, mind and body. To perform extraordinarily, over an extended period of time, you must develop yourself as a person—the kind of person who embraces adversity, who has non-self-conscious awareness, and who surrenders self-interest for a purpose beyond self. Here are a few questions to help you guard your heart against mental blocks:

- Are you willing to be uncomfortable?
- Are you willing to look foolish and laugh at your foolishness?
- Are you willing to fail?

- Are you willing to face the feeling of failure, or even panic?
- Do you have a purpose beyond success in your profession?

An extraordinary performer with a fulfilling life is focused on the journey, not the destination, and if we listen closely and see clearly during that journey, life teaches us lessons on how to navigate the potential mental blocks along the way. If we can abandon our self-consciousness and our attachment to the past and future, we can do extraordinary things. We can be unstoppable.

Key Points from Chapter 9

- You move towards what you think about. Mental blocks gain power because of the constant thoughts on the very thing you don't want.
- Beliefs are the thermostat of your life, setting boundaries around who you become and what you accomplish. These boundaries are greatly impacted by mental blocks and limiting beliefs that came from trauma, embarrassments and the ego's need for self-protection.
- Most people, including professional and Olympic athletes, live their entire lives with (subconscious) mental blocks and don't know it, or if they do, have no idea they can be eliminated often in one day.
- The subconscious has three primary roles:
 1. Protect you from physical and emotional danger.
 2. Run your life in the background so you don't have to think about every little thing you do.

3. Line up your circumstances and results with your beliefs.

- The yips, mental blocks, and phobias are common and are not flaws in our minds—actually they are the opposite. They represent a mind working perfectly; every single time the context appears, the mental block happens. It's a flawless mind.
- Mental blocks can be scary if you don't understand what's happening. These obstacles can be removed, forever, allowing you to perform with freedom and confidence.

Follow Up Questions and Activities

- The easiest person in the world to deceive is yourself. Ask several people who know you well (and will be honest with you) what mental blocks you have that you may have overlooked or not been aware of, in any area of your life.
- Visualize your greatest goals and dreams as if they were accomplished. Try to really feel it as real. Is there anything that comes with that achievement that may be uncomfortable or undesirable? If so, there may be a mental block that you are unaware of.
- Look back on your career and/or your life, has there been a pattern of injury or illness or anything that has repeatedly stopped you from the success you dream of? There may be a mental block that needs to be addressed.

The Hero and the Goat:
How to Have Poise Under Pressure

Find a place within yourself where success and failure don't matter, a place where you can engage in battle without compromise.

**—Jim Steen, Kenyon College swim coach, winner of 31
consecutive national championships**

Chesley Sullenberger made an announcement to the passengers and crew, ninety seconds before hitting the water: “Brace for impact.” When U.S. Airways flight 1549 lost all power, the former fighter pilot said he experienced “the worst sickening, pit-of-your-stomach, falling-through-the-floor feeling” he had ever had.

Captain Sullenberger (“Sully”) had three and a half minutes to accomplish what few commercial airline pilots had ever pulled off. Landing an airliner in the ocean has led to many fatalities (e.g., Ethiopian Airlines flight 906 landed in the Indian Ocean in 1996, killing the majority on board). As Sully recounted all that needed to be done in order to survive—touch down at a descent rate just over minimum flying speed but not below it, keeping the wings exactly level and the nose slightly up, all simultaneously—he noted that his focus was absolute. “I thought of nothing else,” Sully said after landing safely in the Hudson River the morning of January 15, 2009. Despite the pressure of 155 lives in his hands in a situation that held a high probability of death, he said, “I was sure I could do it. The physiological reaction I had to this was strong, and I had to force myself to use my training and force calm on the situation.” It wasn’t a hard

thing to do,” he said, “it just took some concentration.”

Sullenberger acted fearlessly in a moment of crisis. What about the rest of us? Is this something that can be taught? By now you probably know the answer. Performing extraordinarily under pressure can be learned, as Sully himself did.

Pressure arises when the stakes are high but the outcome is uncertain, which prompts the mind to jump to the future, where fear resides. Pressure also provides the scenario that elite athletes seek: risking failure for the chance to feel incredibly alive, competing in a sport in which they love and are talented at. It’s the essence of competition—to be challenged in something where you can put your gifts to use, not knowing what the outcome will be. Pressure is the reward given to those who seek excellence.

In this chapter we’ll discuss pressure and presence, belief and mental toughness, and how resonance is the ideal state for peak performance under pressure. Let’s clarify some terms first:

- Belief: an idea that your subconscious holds true about who you are and what you can or cannot achieve
- Presence: having a clear mind and unburdened heart
- Resonance: the excitement and presence that comes from being fully engaged in your natural state (true self).
- Goat: the person who gets blamed for the loss (as opposed to G.O.A.T. - Greatest Of All Time)

Wikipedia states that in music, resonance comes when strings start to vibrate and produce sounds *without direct excitement from the player*. In

other words, the strings do nothing on their own, but get excited by the frequency around them. This sort of effortless excitement (*resonance*) is the source of extraordinary performance under pressure.

Before we get into how to perform with grace and poise under pressure, let's break down the elements of performance:

1. The circumstances around your situation or performance.
2. Your beliefs about your ability to perform how you want.
3. Your thoughts (before, during and after your performance).
4. Your state (how you feel before, during and after your performance).
5. Your performance.
6. Your results.

Whether you're negotiating a deal with your career riding on it, about to perform your first brain surgery, or playing a game of tennis, these elements of performance apply.

To have poise under pressure is to get these elements sorted out so you're not thinking about the results—they take care of themselves. The three most important elements—beliefs, thoughts, and state—are all unseen. It's these unseen elements in your heart and mind that have the greatest impact on your performance and your life.

In other words, peak performance is almost entirely the result of what's not visible to the eyes: *the beliefs* that you've had going into your performance along with the *predominant thought patterns* that created *the state* you've had going into the performance (and of course during the performance itself).

You may recall from the presuppositions at the start of the book that the

quality of your performance is based on three elements: Your belief about who you are and what's possible for you; your ability to be fully present (fully engaged in the moment, heart, mind and body), and your freedom to play like a kid.

Your beliefs directly impact every area of your life, which is why you're going to want to keep a bookmark in the beliefs chapter (7). Since we've already covered beliefs, we're going to spend this chapter discussing the performance itself—how to perform with freedom and presence, fully engaged in the moment.

The Essence of Resonance

Wouldn't you like to be the skater who wins the silver, and yet is thrilled about those three triple jumps that the gold medal winner did? To love it the way you love a sunrise? Just to love the fact that it was done? For it not to matter whether it was their success or your success. Not to care if they did it or you did it. You are as happy that they did it as if you had done it yourself – because you are just so happy to see it?

—Dr. Timothy Keller

Resonance is the freedom and passion that come when we're fully present and in sync, feeding off the energy—and potential adversity—that performance under pressure may bring. World-class performers and athletes describe the feelings of their best performances with words such as effortless, relaxed, focused, heightened awareness, and harmony. Each of these words illustrates the feeling of being fully present. Resonance is most readily available to those who pursue excellence over success (success is

always the by-product), mastery over ego, and love over fear; this allows them to be fully engaged, heart, mind and body. In this state, they embrace every part of the performance, even the most difficult or painful parts, knowing that it's a package deal.

Extraordinary performance is a subset of a great experience, one where the performer is lost in the moment (perhaps better said, found in the moment—fully alive). Great experiences occur when we remove all judgment and vibrate with positive, powerful energy.

The foundation for having positive, powerful energy under pressure is an empowering mindset. If you're just pursuing a trophy or promotion, the pressure can be immense, because so much is out of your control. But if you're focused on raising the level of excellence in your life, to learn and grow in order to raise it in others, you'll have an incredible foundation for mental toughness and resonance. To raise the level of excellence in your life is to raise the level of love, wisdom and courage in your life—to be wholehearted and have integrity (be complete).

When your goal is to be wholehearted, whether you're playing a violin concerto or in the octagon for an MMA (mixed martial arts) fight, you're really competing to develop yourself. When you're wholehearted, you yearn to be a worthy opponent, someone who is worthy of their sufferings, someone who courageously faces all of life's challenges with honor and integrity.

This pursuit is a far more empowering battle than simply trying to win the event or perform your best. It's a battle you have much more control over, and one that pays much greater dividends. It's also a battle that gives you the greatest freedom to do your routines and be fully engaged, unattached to the results of your performance.

Most people want to succeed so badly because they feel it will enhance their lives. That's faulty logic. What would enhance your life the most would be the desire to be complete more than to win. Then you can live with fullness of life *and* compete with confidence and courage.

The aim:

- to learn and grow to become a worthy opponent, someone who brings out excellence in others
- to learn how to be worthy of your sufferings, and to be worthy to share excellence—and the moment—with others.

Consider this coaching mantra (watch it [here](#)) from *The Great Debaters* (2007). It's a movie based on the true story of a 1930s all-black college debate team that went on to beat the best of the Ivy League white schools:

Debate coach: Who's the judge?

Team: The judge is God.

Coach: Why is he God?

Team: Because he decides who wins or loses, not my opponent.

Coach: Who's your opponent?

Team: He does not exist.

Coach: Why does he not exist?

Team: Because he's merely a dissenting voice to the truth I speak.

Coach: Speak the truth.

When you're able to let go of ego and attachments, all things are possible. You can live the truth. Adversity becomes your helper; you free up to receive abundance. In order to do great things and live an extraordinary life,

we must be good receivers. We cannot receive all the abundance we are meant to receive when we're holding onto little lollipops. We need to drop the little lollipop so we can get the bigger lollipops. Don't be the ignorant child who wants to keep making mud pies in the slum because he can't imagine the holiday at sea. The whole candy store is waiting for you. Believe and receive.

Nah, Don't Got It This Week

The 2009 British Open was a special one. Fifty-nine-year-old Hall of Fame golfer Tom Watson looked like he was about to shatter the record for oldest major winner ever. He bogeyed the 72nd and final hole of the tournament, however, to face an unlikely opponent in a four-hole playoff, Stewart Cink, who had never won a major. Stewart missed the cut his last tournament, and the week before in Ireland didn't shoot any rounds under par. He didn't get to Scotland until Tuesday afternoon (two days before the start), and Wednesday night was asked by golf announcer Mike Turico if he had "it" this week. Cink said, "Nah, don't got it."

What Cink also didn't have was fear. So often our fear is not of failing, but *the feeling of failing*. What will people think? What if I embarrass myself? He didn't have those fears—not that week anyway. He also didn't have much confidence, since he hadn't been playing that well. On one swing during the event, he swung and completely missed the ball. This may have caused stress or embarrassment in the past, but he just shrugged his shoulders and took another swing (the ball was sitting high up on some grass and he swung completely under it, so the ball just dropped straight down without going anywhere).

So how did Cink win? He won in large part because he was grateful to be there. He wasn't afraid of embarrassing himself by hitting a poor shot or missing an easy putt. Cink also wasn't afraid of the feeling of failure. He embraced every part of the experience, even Watson's epic performance. "Like everyone else, I was a fan as well. It was exciting to watch Tom's amazing performance." Cink had a positive, fearless energy. He had resonance, though not a lot of confidence.

Performance carries constant threats to resonance. In fact, the purpose of competition is to create threats to take us out of our comfort zones. Competition is built-in adversity to increase challenge and enjoyment. It ceases to be enjoyable, however, when we take our focus off the task and put it on the end result, where uncertainty resides.

In my practice working with world-class athletes, teams, and businesses, I've identified four keys to help you perform with freedom and presence during performance:

Four Keys to Resonance (and Poise) Under Pressure

1. Share your heart, not your ego.
2. Pursue mastery, not the score.
3. Love your opponent.
4. Visualize presence (but not perfection).

Resonance Key Number One: Share Your Heart, Not Your Ego

Love, as I can see it, is the strongest energy on earth. I love hockey all the time, I've always loved it, and had no problem to sacrifice anything to it.

That's the most important thing.

**—Jaromir Jagr, Voted Top 100 Greatest Hockey Players of
All Time**

Simon Sinek, author of the book *Start With Why*, shares how a musician can have mental toughness and grit:

If your goal is to play the piece perfectly, I don't believe you can have mental toughness. If your goal is to give the audience something beautiful to listen to, that's when I think you have mental toughness. It's always the passing on to someone else. Mental toughness comes from letting go of your own ego.

If you're focused on what you can get from your performance (a trophy or promotion), it's hard to perform well when the pressure is on. However, if your goal is to share something you love with others, it's very empowering, because you can always do that, even if you're not at your best.

Dawn Staley, the Olympic gold medal-winning basketball player profiled in Chapter 4, played to win, but it's not why she played. She played for the incredible experiences she had on the court. Her dreams were in the playing, performing with passion and joy—winning was secondary to fully engaging in her performance. She loved to play basketball, and she was most excited to do it with the best players in the world, because they offered her the most challenges and the best experiences. It was her love for basketball and desire to share it with other high-level performers, that seemed to propel her.

It's like Clara Hughes sending her Olympic medals to her mom in the introduction. Her medals are “not what provide the deep sense of

accomplishment, which, she says, which “fills my sense of self, in turn teaching me how to live.”

Dawn and Clara both played to win but recognized that winning isn't the reason they play—they played to feel alive and learn and grow, as a person and an athlete. This mindset helped them perform with poise under pressure, which then put them in a position to win. Winning is their goal, not their dream.

Dreams are feelings you can control; goals are outcomes you cannot (not completely). Living your dreams means experiencing the amazing feelings you get—such as passion and love and being caught up in the moment—while you pursue your goals. It's not based on the outcome of your goal. Living your dreams means pursuing your biggest goals, embracing all the adversity that comes with it, and dancing along the way. It's loving the journey more than the outcome.

Bonnie Blair, the most decorated speed skater in U.S. history, had a perspective on her sport that allowed her to compete with passion and focus, unafraid of failure. At one Olympics she finished fourth in a race, but that result was more important to her than one of her gold medals because it was her personal best in that event. Dr. Jim Bauman, U.S. Olympic team sport psychologist, talks about Bonnie Blair and other world-class athletes:

Their perspective about what they're doing and why they do it is just different. [At] the Winter Games over in Torino [Italy], we had athletes over there that really didn't necessarily compete for the gold medal and all the fame and fortune and da, da, da. They're really in it to see what they can get out of their own system.

A powerful perspective focuses on the experience more than the goal. The goal may be to win a gold medal or reach a certain sales number, but the focus is on the moment-to-moment experience and how you can learn and grow (and have more of these experiences in the future). Top performers who perform exceptionally and live balanced, fulfilling lives want challenges, and they want them to be meaningful. The results are simply feedback.

Rather than trying to beat the opponent, the best competitors are sharing their unconditional love for their sport with the world. They're not performing to see what they can get out of it, they perform to see what they can share and who they can become in the midst of it. In doing this, they feel most alive.

Resonance Key Number Two: Pursue Mastery, Not the Score

The ultimate goal of karate lies not in victory or defeat but in the perfection of the character of its participants.

—Gichin Funakoshi, Shotokan karate founder

To pursue mastery, it helps to remember the *Inner Excellence* mindset: *I compete to raise the level of excellence in my life, to learn and grow in order to raise it in others.*

If your highest goal is simply tangible success (to win), then the pressure often becomes the opposite of a reward—a heavy burden. When you're desperate for something beyond your control, it often brings with it fear and anxiety. That's why focusing on the score is actually one of the biggest obstacles to achieving a good result or score.

When you're not attached to the outcome, it's easier to visualize possibilities and see yourself living your dreams. With *Inner Excellence*, we don't talk about the score or results (since it's always in the past and future and not in our full control); we leave that for visualization (Key Number 4). Instead of obsessing about the score, we spend our time hyper-focused on the components of mastery: surrender and sacrifice, presence and gratitude, and especially, our daily habits and routines.

When your life gets beyond temporary and surface-level things (like wins and losses), and has a clear purpose, your perspective switches from short-term gains (like the score), which seesaw up and down, to developing mastery and fulfilling your purpose. As a result, everything changes. No longer do you "have to" win this event, impress your boss, or make your quota. Competition goes from "have to" to "get to," which is a far more empowering pursuit.

Mastery is the endless pursuit of self-awareness, self-discipline and personal growth, where winning and achieving are only by-products. Each day has the same importance as the day before, with the same questions being asked of you:

- Will you be present and grateful today in each moment, and see what that moment has to teach you?
- Are you going to be true to yourself when the world around you is trying to make you like everyone else?
- Can you drop your attachment to your ego and listen and learn?

If you want to achieve great things, remember this: all great success is first created within you. The greatness that comes from mastery is not from

ability, but from availability—the willingness to sacrifice, to face your fears, to surrender self-concern for the needs of others.

Because mastery is focused on growth rather than outcome, it helps you to stay fixed on the process rather than jump to the end result. Mastery embraces suffering and failure as keys to improvement. Mastery does not obsess about results but rather focuses on the specific details of the process that move experience (and performance) from ordinary to extraordinary. Mastery transcends circumstances because it is not attached to the outcome.

The greatest obstacle to mastery is the ego. The ego is attached to the five ingredients of the affluenza virus: possessions, achievements, looks, money, and status. Mastery gives the feeling of control, ironically by giving up trying to control things. The ego, however, is controlled by results. Mastery has freedom and ego has tension and anxiety. Mastery has few needs, while the ego is very needy.

NBA Basketball coach Phil Jackson said that as a player, ego and emotions ruled his life. He was attached to winning and fearful of losing. Once he got into coaching, though, he saw everything differently. He realized the fleeting nature of success: “Even as we’re being handed the trophy to the NBA championship, we are no longer a success. The moment has passed.” Mastery understands the human element of life, by which we can do everything right and still “fail,” whereas the ego has no grasp of learning and growth, it’s only caught up in winning and losing.

Pursuing mastery (above and beyond winning) means you prioritize learning and growing and who you’re becoming over who gets the trophy when it’s over. This allows you to take the risks necessary to be your very best, part of which includes the willingness to be the goat (blamed for the loss), in order to be the hero (as your ego would call it). In fact, in order to

be the G.O.A.T. (greatest of all time), you need to be willing to be the goat. Pursuing mastery, not the score, is the most powerful way to do this.

Resonance Key Number Three: Love Your Opponent

The opponent is not the enemy—they're our partner in the dance.

—Phil Jackson, 11-time NBA championship coach

Imagine two great athletes are best friends and they love to snow ski. They have the mountain to themselves with absolutely perfect conditions. One friend says to the other, “Shall we finish the day with a race to the bottom?” So off they go, in and out of the trees, over some jumps, all the way down, with a photo-finish at the bottom. They high-five each other after an epic run.

Then a photographer comes over and says he took a photo of the finish and asks if they want to see who won? Yes, they say. Now imagine you're one of the skiers, and it's you and your best friend. Then imagine that the picture shows your buddy beating you by inches. What do you do now? Do you slam your helmet and storm off, realizing that you just lost?

I told that story to Hall of Fame golfer Phil Mickelson at the 2016 Ryder Cup. I finished the story and asked him, “What do you do now, do you slam your helmet and storm off?” He said, “Yes!” Then he laughed and said, “I know what you mean. The skiing and the process are what's important.”

It seems silly, doesn't it, to think of storming off after such an amazing moment you shared with your best friend? Were you skiing just so you can call your mom and tell her you beat Billy or Bobby Sue in a race? Or were you skiing because you love to ski, you love to be out in nature, and you

love to feel alive? And you love to share experiences like this with your best friend who loves the same thing?

When feeling fully alive and having extraordinary experiences are more important than bragging rights or trophies or even money, then you can experience resonance and do something extraordinary.

Understand that your opponent is a key element of the experience you're chasing. The more you love and understand your opponent as a person, the more you can experience and be fulfilled by the competition—by the dance.

—Ryan Dodd, world-number-one-ranked water ski jumper

To reach your potential as a competitor, you need someone better than you who can push you to grow. One of my clients was top ten in the world, but he would consistently lose to world number one. Every time they competed, he desperately wanted to beat him. When he started with *Inner Excellence*, he gradually shifted his mindset to loving his greatest opponent. The biggest threat to his dream became his partner in achieving his dream. Here's what changed:

1. Gratitude for his opponents—he realized that without his opponents he could not do what he loved.
2. Respect for his opponents as people and competitors.
3. Wanting the best for his opponents.
4. The realization that his greatest opponent was necessary for him to reach his potential and have the experiences he loves most.

With this new mindset, and learning the principles and tools of *Inner*

Excellence, he became World Champion. Rather than resisting his greatest opponent, he began to see his opponent as a crucial element of his success.

So often we want our opponent to make mistakes or not be their best, but that's a mistake. It creates negative energy within you. While some superstars have succeeded with anger or hatred or just a burning desire to beat their opponent, there are many factors as to why they could do that. If that gets them what they want most, that's fine. But if they can be successful and enjoy it at the same time, who wouldn't want that even more? What if you can keep the burning desire to be your best without the negative energy? Not only is that possible, it's much easier and more powerful.

I tell our guys if you can get to the place where you love your opponents, it's a completely different experience. Flow state comes from loving the people you're in the dance with because love drives out fear. You'll desire the challenge, you'll look forward to the moment, and your focus will be elevated. Love the fact that you get to face Verlander and Kershaw, or you get to pitch to Mike Trout. If you're looking forward to facing Gerrit Cole, it will elevate your focus and attention to be your best. Their best brings out your best.

—Derin McMains, Director of Mental Skills, San Francisco Giants

Take a moment to think about when you performed your very best under pressure. What was your mind like? Was it clear? How was your heart? Did you have freedom? How was your body? Was it strong?

The question is, how can you repeat that more often? How can you get to

that point where pressure situations make you feel fully alive, caught up in the moment, heart, mind and body, unattached to your results?

Or, as McMains said, how can you consistently get into that flow state? By now, we know there are three main things that get in the way (of the flow of resonance):

1. Overanalysis (a cluttered mind).
2. Self-consciousness (concern for what people may think if you perform poorly or choke).
3. Constant judging of circumstances and results (a mind that jumps to the past and future, judging circumstances and outcomes and reacting emotionally).

These three obstacles create a lack of belief, focus, and freedom. So how do we overcome them? First, let's look at some key characteristics of the flow of resonance:

1. A clear mind
2. An unburdened heart
 - a. freedom from how your performance might affect your worth in other people's eyes, or your own.
3. Non-judgmental awareness
 - a. When you're unattached to the results of your performance, you can see opportunities for greatness with clear eyes.

So how can we develop an inner life that has a clear mind, an unburdened heart, and non-judgmental awareness on more of a regular basis?

There is one thing that lies at the root of the solution, as mentioned by

Jaromir Jagr, one of the greatest hockey players of all time. It's fearless and present, and is the most powerful, positive energy in the universe. It's love, the unconditional kind. Love does things not for what *you* can get out of it, but for what *others* can get and who they can become from it. It's a selfless journey—the most powerful one.

When you get to the place where the journey itself is the reward, then you can have resonance. Then you can do amazing things.

Georges St. Pierre, mixed martial artist world champion, would pray for his opponent before every match, thanking God for the person who made it possible for him to compete. The value in loving your opponent is that it is generally the most powerful way to create a positive, fearless energy that gives you the freedom to take risks, to fail, and to be the best you can be—especially against the best opponents, under the most pressure.

When you realize that what you want most is fullness of life, and you recognize that you don't know for sure that winning this event is going to give you that, or even is the best thing for you, you can relax and focus on the process of competing—and loving the moment, as well as your opponent.

“When I broke the world record, I was unconditionally going to love giving it my best shot, no matter what happened.”

—Ryan Dodd, World Champion

Loving My Opponent Is the Best Way to Beat Him

Sometimes when we really want to win, we also want our opponent to lose. In other words, my ego wants both a win for me and a loss for you (if

you're my opponent.) This creates comparison separation, where we compare ourselves and I have the upper hand. Now we're separate; there's a winner (me) and loser (you), and so I can feel better about myself. Or so my ego would like me to believe.

Personally, I love to compete. Whether it's ping pong, horse (in basketball), strategy board games, or a game we make up on the spot, I love to play. And I love to win. However, when I've thought deeply about it, I've realized that what I really love is playing and competing, getting caught up in the challenge, in the fun, not bragging when it's over.

I've noticed that when playing a game like ping pong, if I (my ego) really want(s) to win—perhaps there's a crowd watching, or maybe my opponent is a professional athlete—if I focus on the score and winning, it doesn't help, and often hurts my performance. What has helped my performance the most is to remind myself that what I really want is:

- A. to feel alive and enjoy the moment,
- B. to have a great connection with others—even if it's only my opponent—especially if it's my opponent.

Say I'm an MMA fighter training for the world championship. Is there anyone on earth who knows what I've gone through, what my life is like, what the highs and lows are, better than my opponent? If we're competing for the same prize, that means we love the same thing. Your opponent will know some things about your life that few others could ever know.

And the truth is, I don't know if it's truly better for me to win the event or my opponent. Perhaps the best thing that could happen to me is for my opponent to win at the last second. Joy, for me, does not come from being

able to tell people that I beat so and so in ping pong or played professional baseball. Joy comes from fully experiencing the moment and feeling totally alive. Focusing on loving my opponent creates a powerful, positive energy that helps me do that. It gets my heart fully engaged.

How do I love my opponent? I honor him or her by bringing my best so I can provide good competition for them, so I can raise the level of excellence in their life. If I focus on loving my opponent, it always helps me stay present and focused, since love is present and not self-conscious. If I focus on winning, it almost always makes it harder for me to win since it is a future thing, not in my full control, and repeatedly takes my mind out of the present.

Unconditional love and resonance are highly correlated. Unconditional love is fearless. When you can love your work, sport, yourself, and your opponents unconditionally, then you can have a positive, fearless energy that resonates deep within you. To love someone or your sport or job unconditionally means to love even when it's painful, not just in the easy times. When you're prepared to share in the suffering, then you can share in the glory.

Speed skater Apolo Anton Ohno says he creates a sort of mental bubble around him when he's training or competing so he can be fully present with no distractions. Trying to beat your opponent is a distraction, especially if your opponent is really good and you really want to win. Staying in your bubble, however, eliminates distractions. It's easier to stay in your bubble with unconditional love—for your teammates, your sport or profession, and the opponent as well. Especially your opponent. Who knows what he or she might do or how great they might perform? Trying to beat your opponent can easily turn into wishing they make mistakes, or hoping for good results,

both of which take you into the past and future and out of your power, which is to remain fully present.

In 2005 Bode Miller became the first American in twenty-two years to win the overall World Cup in Alpine ski racing, following that up with another World Cup title in 2008. Bode loved to ski, and the greater the challenge, the greater the opportunity he had to push himself to the point where every part of his mind and body were intensely focused, deeply feeling the sport he loves. His definition of success seems to be based more on great experiences than on the outcome of the race. In one notable moment of Miller's career, he revealed a technical advantage to some international opponents (to the dismay of his U.S. ski team members) because he didn't want an unfair edge. It's like the guy who fights you tooth and nail in a race to the bottom of the mountain for a case of beer and then, after beating you, says he doesn't drink. He races to win, but more than that, he loves the race.

Hoping that your opponents won't have their "A" game not only generates negative energy but also is not sound strategy. For you to improve and play at your highest level, having a talented opponent who is playing in top form often gives you the maximum opportunity to do it.

Embracing your opposition as an essential component of your growth is a key part of, as Dr. Cal Botterill says, "keeping the 'want-to' greater than the 'got-to.' Want-to allows you to perform with passion and freedom. Got-to is restricting, because if you've got to win or get this sale but you cannot fully control it, there's no freedom.

If it's true that extraordinary performance is a subset of extraordinary experience, and I believe it is, then positive energy is important. If, in your quest to reach your goal, you focus on extraordinary experience—

performing with passion and vividly experiencing the moment—you're giving yourself the best shot at extraordinary performance. When you see your rival as a component of your success rather than an impediment to it, you can have a powerful focus and energy.

Resonance Key Number Four: Visualize Presence (But Not Perfection)

I think the most important thing you can do (when just starting out) is don't go for perfection. Go for speed. Just get a really sh---y product out there.

**—Nolan Bushnell, founder of Atari, Inc. and Chuck E. Cheese
Pizza Time Theater**

Bushnell was answering a question about the key to success in starting a new venture. His surprising answer is helpful to remind us that the greatest achievements and greatest businesses are great because they were bold, and they didn't let the fear of failure slow them down. They also, importantly, didn't need things to be just right before they launched, or before they presented their product or service.

The greatest have a different view of success and failure than the rest of the world. The world sees failure as a personal setback, a chink in the armor of success. The master sees failure as an important part of progress, just like the cartoonist Stephen McCranie said, "the master has failed more times than the beginner has even tried."

If you want to develop more peace and confidence under pressure, let go of your need to be successful and look the part. Instead visualize the path of mastery, seeking to be wholehearted and fully engaged in your life, rather

than successful in it. Those who are most successful are those who would rather be wholehearted and their true selves than get a trophy or corner office. Those things are added to the ones who seek first the things that matter most.

What matters most is to be present to what's possible in your life, to who you're created to be, to the beauty and glory surrounding you at this very moment. When you do, that's when you feel resonance.

Resonance comes from connecting with the performance so intimately that you become one with the action. The artist becomes the art. The dancer becomes the dance. Movements are effortless, thoughts are minimal, and feel is maximized. This is greatly enhanced through visualization: seeing yourself performing with your ideal performance state and feeling how you want to feel in the middle of whatever chaos may arise in competition.

Every noteworthy achievement started as an image in someone's mind. Excellence is within you, waiting to be accessed. Artists bring to life some beautiful and/or painful moment, or thing they've imagined; gold medalists see themselves winning the medal before they win it, sales people see themselves getting the major account before it actually happens. Visualization is creating a mental picture and imagining the associated feelings in order to put your heart, mind and body into the state you want. Getting the *feeling* of living your dreams, amidst all the adversity and nerves, is super important.

When we visualize, we want a picture of presence (not perfection) a readiness for anything, with no attachments, needs or demands. To visualize well is to feel exactly what you'll feel under the most pressure; to get those same (often) nervous feelings and see yourself embracing the adversity and using the principles and tools of *Inner Excellence* to resonate with the

challenge. One of the critical aspects of visualization is to become emotionally prepared for pressure and stress. There should be nothing you can encounter in a performance that you're not ready for emotionally (which is why we exaggerate potential adversity we might face, and see ourselves poised in the midst of it).

World champion martial artist Georges St. Pierre spent about 80% of his visualization focused on what he wanted to do and how he would do it, and about 20% of it was focused on seeing himself facing and overcoming adversity.

To visualize well is to feel exactly what you'll feel under extreme pressure, then see yourself using *Inner Excellence* tools, principles and routines to be present and fully engaged.

A cluttered mind can't visualize well; you need a mind that is calm and ready to dream. This starts with creating space in your life (moments of solitude). More space makes room for clarity. When you have a clear mind and an unburdened heart (the product of a purpose that transcends circumstance), ideas will come; most notably scenes related to your goals and dreams. There's a constant battle between clutter and clarity in which images compete for a prime spot in your mind. With space and clarity, clear images of your goal fill your mind, possibilities open up.

As you learn to control your state and keep your biggest goals foremost in your mind, you can move toward those powerful images. In Lewis Pugh's attempt to do what many experts said was humanly impossible, he had to override logic and rational thinking. His coach, Tim Noakes, told CNN, "The moment you dive into cold water, your temperature drops and the brain sends a message to get out of the water. The first thing Lewis has to do is control that response." Pugh spent four hours a day visualizing, along

with one hour a day swimming in cold water. He visualized his swim from beginning to end. “I can taste saltwater in my mouth. I can hear the sounds of the engines, of Tim Noakes screaming at me. I can feel ice burning my skin; I can smell the sea air. I absolutely live that moment. I have swum the North Pole hundreds of times in my mind,” he told CNN.

No matter what business you’re in, the ability to still your mind and imagine your future is paramount. Everything happens twice: first in your mind and then in your life. The results you’re getting are directly tied to the images in your mind, the beliefs you have about those images, and your ability to connect with images that uphold successful feelings and outcomes. What are the pressure moments in your day and in your business? Are you subjected to an overbearing boss or perhaps an extremely competitive job market? Whether you’re trying to make a team, run a thriving business in a slow economy, or simply get a good job, your success is affected by your ability to see these events unfold the way you want in your mind beforehand. If you can see the stressful events in your mind before they happen, and can then imagine your own confident response, you’ll give yourself the best chance of staying focused and confident when the time comes.

Here are a few visualization techniques to help you get those feelings and create empowering beliefs of success under pressure:

Preview. Visualize the events and circumstances of your upcoming performance. Use all your senses to imagine how it will feel. This should be done not just the night before a big game or performance, but every day, ideally for five minutes before every time you sleep (including naps). See yourself performing well, doing the things you know you will be called on

to do. You can do the same thing before a negotiation, meeting, or presentation. Imagine all the supporting details surrounding your performance or presentation—who will be there, what they might say and how they will act, before and after you crush it.

Confidence memories. Remember a time when you felt exactly how you want to feel while performing. If you're an athlete, recall your best performance. If you're a musician, relive hitting the notes perfectly. If you're a salesperson, go back in time to a successful pitch to a challenging prospect. Once you got that memory, recall all the sights and sounds so you can feel it again. Focus on where you feel it in your body, then ask your subconscious to bring another memory where you had a similar feeling in your body. Repeat, stacking those memories on top of each other to create one powerful memory.

Presence under pressure. Visualize a situation where you're under extreme pressure, and exaggerate it to make it even more pressure-packed. You can make it ridiculous (it's easier for the subconscious to remember crazy pictures). For example, I ask my PGA Tour guys to see themselves at the Masters on the back nine on Sunday, in the lead or close to it, with gale-force winds and/or driving rain, with countless cameras in their personal space, and/or whatever they can imagine. *There should never be a real-life situation you can experience that is more intense, unexpected or pressure-filled than one you've visualized.*

See yourself feeling the tension, excitement and nerves, embracing it, and excelling, using *Inner Excellence* tools.

Relax. There are two types of relaxation visualization. One is relaxing as a

way to clear the mind (for example, imagining a peaceful nature scene), and the other is seeing yourself relaxed in pressure situations. Learning to relax is always paired with learning to breathe deeply and slowly, slowing the heart rate.

Reframe. If you're plagued by the memory of a mistake, you can change the memory in order to diminish the negative residual effects. Replay the event in your mind, seeing it the way you wanted it to go. (See Chapter 9 for the reprogramming sequence.)

Scene of Success. Picture in your mind all the details of what your day is like before and after extraordinary success. You might start by visualizing the 20 seconds immediately after you finish, in vivid detail... then visualize the next 20 minutes... who said what, what you felt, and what you think would happen. This visualization captures all the things that you would see if it was all recorded on video, before and after your extraordinary performance (this visualization does not include the actual performance).

Role Models/mentors. In this visualization, imagine that whoever is the best in the world (past or present) at the specific skill you want to improve—is encouraging and inspiring you and your work or performance. For example, you might visualize yourself having a court-side seat to their best performance ever, and they take a timeout to come over and ask you for advice.

Before I write, I use a mentors visualization. I see myself entering an exclusive, ivy-covered building. I nod to the guard, a U.S. marine, who escorts me to my office, where I know that six or seven people are waiting for me. As we make our way to the office, the marine, in full uniform,

walks purposefully and, in his professional manner, says how much he respects me and that it's an honor to escort me each day. I try to use our two-minute walk to encourage him in some way. We arrive in a beautiful room with vaulted ceilings and walls lined with brilliant books. In the center of the room is a table around which are seated Martin Luther King Jr., John Wooden (legendary basketball coach), Nelson Mandela, John F. Kennedy Jr, and some current world leaders. They're discussing the concepts in this book and how to apply them. The marine pulls my chair out for me, I thank him, and the people around the table take turns asking my opinion on various issues they're facing regarding focus, poise, leadership, and solving the world's problems. After a few minutes of this, they get up to leave and all line up to give me a big hug and thanks.

I have a song that I listen to (same song every time) that anchors the visualization. This exercise forms a connection with the writing that helps me start each day with a clear mind, poised and ready to create.

In all of these visualizations, it's crucial to feel the heightened energy; see yourself embracing every aspect of the competition, especially the adversity, and feel yourself being fully present.

Getting Into the Rhythm and Feel

Developing awareness of the feel of your body in pressure situations is important for peak performance. Our North American way of life has desensitized us. Clutter has taken the place of clarity. Your ability to see, smell, feel, and hear needs to be rejuvenated, enough so that when you visualize, you can taste victory. We want to experience our senses so vividly that the imagination needs little effort to get back to that feeling when we

re-create it in our minds.

It's an interesting paradox: on the one hand, extraordinary performances come with incredible feelings, but on the other hand, developing those moments requires discipline and control of your feelings and emotions. Understanding the interplay of heightened awareness, confidence, relaxed intensity, and performing to succeed (but not being fixated on success) takes a lot of work. It takes a commitment to learn about yourself. It's not easy, but it's well worth it.

Doug Newburg, PhD, is a former University of Virginia basketball player who has conducted in-depth interviews with hundreds of elite performers, from professional and Olympic athletes to rock stars and surgeons. He studied what they had in common when they performed their best and how they developed their confidence and focus. His research resulted in five pertinent questions:

- How do I want to feel?
- What does it take to get that feeling?
- What keeps me from that feeling?
- How can I get it back?
- What am I willing to work for?

As you become more in tune with how and what you want to feel, you'll be able to create routines and a lifestyle that will put you in situations where you'll have the feelings you want. All outstanding performers have routines that prepare them for game day. Tom Trebelhorn, Major League Baseball manager and coach, said he never managed a Hall of Fame athlete who wasn't meticulous and compulsive about his routines. They get to the park

at a certain time, take a certain number of ground balls, and/or listen to certain music, sometimes down to the minute. The trick with routines is to use them to help get the feeling of resonance, but whenever you are interrupted or cannot stick to your routine, tell yourself, “This is how it’s supposed to be today.” Accept this interruption as if you chose it.

To truly connect with the performance, we must learn to be fully engaged moment-to-moment, so we can be that way while under extreme pressure. Your posture—how you stand, move and walk—is an easily overlooked element to visualize. Posture greatly impacts energy and focus. Kevin Towers, general manager of the San Diego Padres, noted, “If I was scouting a prospect and did not know what he looked like, I could spot him walking off the bus just by how he carried himself.”

Expect Abundance, Prepare to Suffer

When Sullenberger’s plane hit the birds that destroyed the airliner’s engines, immediately he knew it was very bad: “My initial reaction was one of disbelief.” The jumbo jet had lost all power over one of the most densely populated areas of the planet. Obviously, Sully was surprised at the sudden life-threatening situation he was facing, yet instincts took over and he grew calm, focused, and confident. Sully had a consciousness of poise under pressure, which prepared him to handle anything.

The feelings you experience under pressure present extreme challenges in performance. Feelings are magnified in pressure situations, and unexpected events can throw you off balance quickly. Consider a situation in which you have a make-or-break presentation to give. When you arrive at the site, there’s no projector for your PowerPoint. All your notes are on the

software. The Critic immediately reacts negatively, judging the circumstance. It can easily throw you off, but if you're emotionally prepared, you can adjust to anything.

When Ryan Dodd is walking towards the dock (to do his ski jump) before he flies over two hundred feet, he repeats the samurai mantra: "I expect nothing... I can handle anything." Ryan doesn't want any clutter or negative thoughts getting in his mind before performance. That mantra keeps his mind clear, erasing any needs and quieting concerns of how things should be.

It may sound confusing—should I expect abundance or nothing? They actually go together perfectly. To expect abundance is to realize that life has far more beauty and excellence than we can see or possibly imagine. Like the sun and the moon, beauty and abundance are always there, shining brightly, whether we see them or not. To expect abundance is to have hope and excitement for unseen truth and beauty.

One of the biggest challenges in performance is trying to meet people's expectations. Expectations are a future thing that you want but cannot control. To say "I expect nothing" is to tell yourself (and your subconscious) "I have no needs. No matter what happens or what circumstance I encounter, I can handle anything." Try it next time you're nervous before a performance or presentation. Ryan found it so helpful that he incorporated it into his pre-game routine before every performance.

To summarize, the most powerful mindset is to expect abundance in your daily life ("something incredible is about to happen") while letting go of attachments and needs for certain things to happen ("I expect nothing; I can handle anything").

Golfer Kyla Inaba was playing in a tournament and faced challenging,

unforeseen weather conditions. Hail mixed with snow and driving winds made most of the golfers miserable. She remembered some *Inner Excellence* principles:

- Anything that you can't control is how it's supposed to be.
- So-called "bad" weather is always a good thing for *Inner Excellence* athletes. The more adversity the better.
 - Most competitors will take a negative view on it, thus reducing their focus and engagement one notch. If you stay neutral, you're one notch above most of the field of competitors.
 - If you embrace the adversity as sent specifically for you to learn and grow, now you're two notches above the field, and the tournament hasn't even started.

That's what the greatest have learned to do, to see adversity as an important part of their growth, not a setback. When everyone else was complaining and wondering if and when the tournament would be canceled, Kyla stayed present and embraced the situation exactly as it was, with no desires for more clement weather. She won the tournament.

Dr. Curt Tribble, head cardiac surgeon at the University of Virginia School of Medicine, brought in a resident physician in a life-and-death operation, and the patient seemed to be slipping away. The resident, however, had prepared himself for such a situation. Dr. Tribble explains:

The resident performed a highly unorthodox procedure in order to get air to the patient. The attending anesthesiologist said, "Wow, have you ever done that before?" The resident with absolute honesty, and not even a hint of sarcasm, looked at him and said,

“No, but I’ve thought about it a lot.”

In other words, the resident had dreamed of various situations that could come up and saw himself performing with poise under pressure. The best among us never stop dreaming or imagining new and more intense pressure situations and the solutions we’d manufacture. We must be prepared to roll with “bad” calls from the umpire, turbulent weather, nervousness, fear, anxiety—anything. To do this, we need equilibrium—a clear mind—one with no expectations of how things should be, and one that daydreams of contingencies, as exemplified by Charles Sullenberger and Dr. Tribble’s resident physician.

Pressure gives us the opportunity for growth and extraordinary experiences, which is the core of a courageous life. In our affluenza culture of instant gratification, we tend to lose perspective on what gives meaning to life. When we seek mastery, however, we are preparing ourselves for a life of growth and learning that sets the stage for resonance—adversity and all. We can then transcend our day-to-day circumstances and the need to beat our opponents and instead focus on being our best selves. We thereby forge a connection with the performance, which provides incredible experiences. We win more often and are prepared for the unexpected. In crisis, danger becomes opportunity.

If you really want to perform extraordinarily under pressure, you can learn to do so, no matter how you’ve done in the past. If your foundation is the *Inner Excellence* mindset, focused on raising the level of excellence in your life, to learn and grow, in order to raise it in others—you will reach levels of performance you’ve never dreamed of.

Key Points from Chapter 10

- Poise is a learned ability, one in which the performer feels resonance, vividly experiencing the moment.
- Poise is a reflection of a strong inner world; the strongest is one that is wholehearted.
- The wholehearted competitor uses their sport or work to seek self-mastery and personal growth. He or she strives to be a worthy opponent. Winning is always the by-product of developing Inner Excellence, not the focus.
- There are four keys to the resonance that powers extraordinary performance:
 1. Share your heart, not your ego.
 2. Pursue mastery, not the score.
 3. Love your opponent.
 4. Visualize presence, not perfection.
- When you feel resonance, everything else fades away: the score, the outcome, and possibly even your opponent. The pressure becomes energy that propels you.
- Focusing on connecting with your performance and fully experiencing the event is crucial to achieving resonance.
- Embracing your opponent as a vital component of your growth and experience elevates your focus.

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- When have you felt the balance and focus of resonance in a performance? What kind of habits and routines will help you repeat that experience? What prevents you from getting that feeling?
- How can you incorporate the three mastery concepts of self-discipline, self-awareness, and personal growth into your daily life?
- Consider some of the best moments in your life (where you felt love). Now consider your greatest rival. Visualize that powerful energy within you (the presence and fearlessness of love) as you compete (while he or she does everything they can to try to beat you). How does that loving energy affect your ability to be present and focused?
- Visualize your next performance. Feel the pressure and the nervousness that usually accompany it. See unexpected events happening and the chaos that may ensue. Immerse yourself in that feeling, and then get centered and relaxed in the pressure. See yourself coming through with poise and confidence.
- Pick a group of mentors and visualize them in your ideal work setting, encouraging and inspiring you.

Maslow, Michael Jordan, and the Navy Seals
Three Hallmarks of Extraordinary Leaders

The difference between champions and near champions is the ability to play for something outside of self.

—Lou Holtz, Hall of Fame football coach

Jim Tressel, head football coach at Ohio State University, took a trip to the little town of Gambier, Ohio. He went to speak with Jim Steen, Kenyon College swim coach. Tressel, who has guided the Buckeyes to five Big Ten championships in eight seasons, sought out Steen, who has won forty-nine national championships (yes, forty-nine). Tressel and Steen have both learned a few things over the years, including how to develop leaders, how to focus on the process of high performance, and, perhaps most of all, how to build a family.

Phil Jackson became head coach of the Chicago Bulls in 1989 and inherited the best basketball player in the world. Michael Jordan was great, but the team was not. Jackson instilled the values of compassion and selflessness in a league of egos and false bravado. The Bulls went on to win six NBA championships, and Jackson won five more with the Los Angeles Lakers. Tressel, Steen and Jackson's success came from understanding that leadership is really about understanding human behavior and what drives people to sacrifice themselves for something greater.

The best leaders see what's possible for the group and empower the group members to reach that level. They know the details of performance extremely well and communicate those details in a way that inspires. They

use their sport or work to convey new ways of seeing the world; what's possible, and how to live more fully, love more deeply, and experience life in ways that promote learning and growth. When people have an inspiring vision for the future and are given tools to learn and grow, they'll do whatever tasks they face with a higher level of proficiency, as well as with incredible loyalty.

Hall of fame NFL coach Dick Vermeil on the importance of understanding human behavior on leadership:

It has always been my philosophy, and I really believe this sincerely, that a football player is a person first, a tennis player is a person first, a swimmer is a person first. Then you go ahead and coach the activity that he's participating in.

Leadership is developing people to be their true selves so they can help others do the same. You may recall your true self is always looking to raise the level of excellence in your life, to learn and grow, in order to raise it in others.

There are certain things leaders do, beyond the areas of technical expertise and disciplined practice, that make all the difference in the world. In my experience, the greatest coaches and leaders adopt these three approaches in their lives and teachings:

1. Redefine success
2. Connect individuals with a vision beyond themselves
3. Seek self-mastery—and help others do the same

The best leaders create a culture that develops people to live fully,

wholeheartedly, and have fun along the way. Through the daily message of their own lives, they set the tone because they live what they teach. Whether it is teaching athletes or executives, in the field of baseball or business, the basic principles of extraordinary performance are the same. It starts with a leader who, far beyond the Xs and Os of strategy and tactics, learns how to empower and enrich the lives of those he or she leads.

Redefine Success

Hall of Fame basketball coach John Wooden won ten national championships at UCLA, including seven in a row. He defined success as “peace of mind, which is a direct result of self-satisfaction in knowing you made the effort to become the best of which you are capable.”

Jim Tressel slightly adjusts Wooden’s definition for his Buckeyes: “Success is the inner satisfaction and peace of mind that comes from knowing you did the best you were capable of for the group.” Tressel’s definition of success focuses on inner satisfaction, peace of mind, and doing your best—for the group. You might summarize Tressel’s definition as having a powerful spirit (inner satisfaction and peace), giving it your best shot (the best you were capable of), and having a purpose beyond yourself (for the group).

“[Tressel] builds his program around, first, morals as a team and as a man; second, closeness; and then football,” said Malcolm Jenkins, one of Tressel’s all-Americans.

In our culture, success is often measured by what you have, what you’ve done, and how you compare with others. In Wooden’s and Tressel’s definitions, those are never even mentioned. The best coaches create an

inspiring vision of selflessness and self-mastery that empowers the group to be who they've never been before. Then they create a system of daily habits and routines to reach that vision.

Frosty Westering, four-time national champion football coach, focused on the development and growth of his athletes as people, first and foremost. According to *Sports Illustrated*, for Westering, conventional measures of success are unimportant. "Winning is a by-product of learning to live decently", Westering says. Westering is less interested in football than he is in "shaping players lives and influencing their hearts and minds."

Before a big game, one of Frosty's players stood up and said:

They're here to beat us—we're here to be us.

Such an empowering statement. It's similar to a text message I sent to a PGA Tour star:

The purpose of golf is to learn and grow and develop yourself, not to make birdies. Stop trying to make birdies. Try to be who you are—it takes zero effort.

My purpose in sending that text message was to help him stop obsessing about tangible outcomes that are always in the past and future. Success takes care of itself when you take care of yourself.

Every goal you ever set, and every result you ever get is in the past and future. If you want to be great, you need to visualize greatness and then work every day to develop your beliefs about what's possible, your ability to focus and be fully present, and your freedom to play like a kid. Greatness is always a by-product of the process of developing *Inner Excellence* in

your life.

Frosty's teams were dominating because his players learned that the best possible life was pursued by being their true selves and serving others. They learned to love and respect each other, as well as their opponents, which created powerful energy that enabled them to perform their best.

John Wooden didn't scout opposing teams. He didn't want to know what others were doing. This allowed him to be innovative and focus on development. He was determined to make his team the best it could be, regardless of how they compared to others. You may think that was easy for him—he had the best talent. But Wooden didn't recruit, either. The talent came to him. His ability to develop people was a great draw. He was much more concerned with personal and team development than comparison to others. W. Chan Kim and Renee Mauborgne echoed the same idea in their best-selling book *Blue Ocean Strategy*: “The only way to beat the competition is to stop trying to beat the competition.”

Trying to beat the competition is the biggest mistake teams and coaches make. They'd do far better to focus on the process of high performance, which is quite different. When you focus on defeating an opponent, you're focusing on something largely out of your control, which creates tension and easily takes you out of the present. (If it were completely in your control, it would be on your to-do list and not a goal.) In order to achieve the goal, we must stay fixed on the *process* of achieving the goal. Jim Collins, bestselling author of *Good to Great* and *Built to Last*, listed twelve myths regarding great companies. Myth number ten: “The most successful companies focus primarily on beating the competition.” The reality, Collins says, is that “visionary companies focus primarily on beating themselves.”

Or as I say it, the best teams and companies focus on being their true

selves. To be your true self is to overcome your natural self-centeredness and the limits it imposes. Phil Jackson worked on this with his teams by focusing on selflessness and compassion. These powerful virtues help silence the judgment of the Critic, the endless chatter of the Monkey Mind, and the lies of the Trickster. Rather than making “winning” or “profit” their ultimate goals, top organizations focus on using their sport or business to make a difference in the lives of their team members and the world we live in.

The Four Team Values of the NBA’s Golden State Warriors:

1. Joy
2. Compassion
3. Mindfulness
4. Competition

Steve Kerr, head basketball coach of the Golden State Warriors, has won the NBA finals eight times, five as a player and three as a coach.

Professional teams may win without empowering values or vision, but it’s almost always short-lived. It’s hard to be consistently great when you have talent or money without a system of developing deep connection, joy and confidence.

We all have a deep need to be a part of something greater than ourselves, beyond profits and losses, winning and losing. Many of us go through life and never connect with that need, constantly trying to fill that longing with more wins, more money, more promotions. Tension and anxiety ensue,

because we never have true freedom in performance when we're dependent on the outcome to fill our deep needs.

Goals are important but it's important to understand that people are not defined by their goals and whether or not they reach them. A win or a loss does not make you or me a better person. We have to separate who we are from what we do . . . it's vital to distinguish between purpose and goals. Understanding the difference between purpose and goals is essential to understanding the true definition of success.

**—Jim Tressel, President, Youngstown State University, 5-time
national champion football coach**

Whether in reference to family, friends, teammates, or anyone else, when the central purpose of your life revolves around loving and serving others, a powerful series of events begins to unfold. Fear loses some of its grip, since fear is self-focused, while service is focused on others. You develop relationships that carry you in tough times. Life becomes more meaningful, which promotes the inner peace needed to grow, see more beauty and more possibilities.

Great organizations have a servant-oriented focus. Jim Collins's research on visionary companies reveals a recurring theme: they focus on making a contribution to society, with profits as the by-product. In other words, their definition of success revolves around a powerful purpose, and that purpose is to make a difference in people's lives.

A clear and meaningful purpose allows us to be more present in our performance because we become less attached to the outcome of our goals.

Dawn Staley and the many other Olympians who experience vividly and live fully are stellar examples: they play to win, but winning is not the reason they play.

Connect Individuals with a Vision Beyond Themselves

I told them tonight, the difference in the game is going to be love. It's been my word all year. We're going to win it because we love each other.

—Dabo Swinney, Head Football Coach, Clemson Tigers, after winning the 2017 national championship

When Lewis Pugh set out to swim at the geographic North Pole in only a Speedo, he was driven by a meaningful purpose. Success for him was doing his part to highlight and make a difference in the fight against the devastating effects of global warming. With this powerful purpose, he set out a vision of what he wanted to accomplish (swim one kilometer at the North Pole), and it guided him every day. The very real fears he faced each day were met with the strength of his purpose and the daily focus on his vision.

A vision beyond yourself is a goal with a direct outcome that serves the greater good. A meaningful purpose is more of a statement of who you are and what defines you. The purpose provides meaning and inspiration; the vision provides direction and focus.

Another group of people who regularly confront extreme danger and must come to terms with their fears are the Navy Seals (U.S. Navy Special Forces Unit). To become a Seal, you need to graduate from BUDS (Basic Underwater Demolition Seal training). BUDS is a six-month training

program infamous for Hell Week, in which the majority of the enlistees drop out. During that five-day week, each potential Seal gets four hours of sleep total. The rest of the time they're being pushed to the limits, mentally, physically, and emotionally. When you've got a drill sergeant in your face, hosing you down with water as you're trying to eke out a few more push-ups, and everything within you wants to quit, there must be something deeper to prevent you from giving in. When I asked Navy Seal Jeff N. what got him through Hell Week, he said, "I focused on my team. I didn't want to let my team down. The other thing was that quitting was not an option. Nothing was going to stop me except my body literally breaking down."

In whatever role you have or work you do, there's the opportunity to face your fears, challenge your limits, and overcome doubt and anxiety. It doesn't matter if you drive a truck for a living or a Formula One race car, if you're a CEO or a shoe salesman. No matter what you do during the day, assuming it doesn't go against your values, you can focus your energy in a way that creates an incredible presence. And if you can combine love, wisdom, and courage with your vocation, it's possible to reach a state of resonance so compelling that you would give your life for it.

Nicolas Herman, born a peasant in 1614, joined the army as a way of surviving poverty. He was captured by the German troops and became a prisoner of war until the Germans released him "due to his great courage." He became a sandal-maker, cook and dishwasher, but described himself as "a great awkward fellow who broke everything." His lack of grace, perhaps, contributed to what he did have: humility and peace.

Herman's warm energy attracted so many people that after he died, his letters and conversations were compiled into a [book](#) that sold millions of copies, and does so to this day. His position was low, but his peace and joy

were so high that 400 years later, Herman's ability to be present in the most mundane work is studied to this day. He had a very simple vision—be present to the love of god and share that with others—but his impact has gone on for centuries. Brother Lawrence (as he became known) was a study in the flow of resonance.

The greatest leaders help us find that resonance. They help us choose what to think about and where to place our attention. They focus on connecting with each individual in order to help them feel positive about who they are, what's possible, and their significance to those around them. Resonance is built on relationships, between your values and your actions, your mind and your heart, yourself and others, and yourself and the environment around you.

To be a great leader is to study and learn how to build those relationships to their full potential. Building a relationship with another person starts with a connection on some level. A strong bond starts by building rapport.

Rapport is based on empathy, which is a connection with what the other person is feeling. The best communicators understand that communication is mostly nonverbal and that everything you do and say communicates something—you cannot “not communicate.”

According to a UCLA study, 7 percent of communication is the words you use, 38 percent is your tone of voice, and 55 percent is your posture and physiology. Dealers in Las Vegas, for example, aren't allowed to stand with their arms crossed, because this is an uninviting posture. To gain rapport most effectively is to match the other person's posture and physiology, tone, and words in a subtle way. It's called pacing.

If, for example, someone who reports to you is angrily stomping around and talking loudly, sitting and speaking quietly would not put you in a

position to match that person. If, however, you were to walk with him, match his volume, and actively listen to what he says, then you could eventually lead him to sit down, talk in a more relaxed manner, and go from there. First pace, then lead. More specifically, pace, pace, pace, lead. They need time to see and feel the resonance between you before they'll follow.

To really build a connection with someone is to connect with what the person really cares about. Say you're working with a new team or organization, and you want to build rapport on an individual basis. You meet with an employee and ask, "What is most important to you about your job?" She may respond, "I want to be challenged." Next you may ask her, "What does being challenged give you?" Perhaps she'll say, "It allows me to be creative and gives me a sense that I'm needed and useful." You may then ask, "What's important to you about being needed and useful?" Perhaps she'll say, "It gives me security." The idea is to continually ask what is important to her and what that gives her, until she expresses the root of what she really wants.

Usually, when you hear either the same answer or an answer with nothing more beyond that comment, you've found the person's highest value in that area. The higher the value you can elicit (such as security, love, or peace), the more options you'll have to satisfy that need. In this example, now that you know security is important to this individual, you can connect the vision of the group and the purpose of the team with security.

The pursuit of a single goal often inhibits the risk taking and creative thinking necessary for personal growth.

—Jim Steen, Kenyon College swim coach

With larger groups, you may not be able to connect individually with each person on the team. If you're the leader, your goal is always to help those you lead continually see opportunities and ways to grow personally and professionally, while giving them a vision of what's possible in their lives and with the team. As the head of your division or general manager, you can't always visit with everyone, but you can develop a culture in which people sincerely connect with and support each other. If the culture of your organization is based on a meaningful purpose, a clear vision for the group, and self-mastery, then you've got a great chance of doing just that.

Coaches Corner: The Pink Elephant That Does Backflips

The language you use as a leader is crucial. You're constantly putting images in the minds of your team members, the question is, are those images helpful or hurtful?

Davey Johnson, three-time MLB World Series Champion, told me, "When a coach is yelling at one of his players, he's not just yelling at that guy, he's yelling at every single person on the team."

The precise words that you use, whether speaking to yourself or someone else, are crucial, because the subconscious mind is always taking in what you're saying and making a belief out of it.

The key is to share images and feelings of what you *do* want your athlete to do, not what you don't, especially in crucial situations. That's because the brain works in images and feelings, and doesn't picture the word don't.

Don't think of a pink elephant doing a backflip. While it may be hard for the elephant to do, it's very hard for us not to think about the elephant doing it (or trying to). The "don't" word is like the silent k in the word knock.

Don't gets ignored by our brains, just like the sound of the letter.

In baseball, for example, pitching coaches often encounter situations where it's important that they don't walk the batter. If the coach points out what he doesn't want, "don't walk this batter," he just put the image in the subconscious mind of his player precisely what he doesn't want (walk this batter). Far better would be to share images and feelings of what he does want.

Same thing goes for (American) football. The football coach might tell the running back "hold on to the ball" or something similar, and not "don't fumble." The first sentence gives a picture (and feeling) of holding on to the ball, and the second sentence puts the picture of fumbling the ball into the player's mind, exactly the opposite of what the coach wants.

Seek Self-Mastery—and Help Others Do the Same

When Abraham Maslow studied the lives of extraordinary people—those who performed at extremely high levels and lived balanced, fulfilling lives—he found that they had an ability to fully experience sacred moments and to live deeply. If we revisit Maslow's characteristics of extraordinary people (self-actualizers)—total absorption in the experience, personal growth, self-awareness, Gemeinschaft (community), gratitude, authenticity, solitude, purpose beyond self, and lack of ego defenses—we can see their relation to self-mastery. Self-mastery is mastering the ego, through selflessness. This is developed through self-awareness, self-discipline, and personal growth. The pursuit of self-mastery is the quest for freedom, out of which awareness, discipline, and growth bring extraordinary experiences.

In 2002, before the football season began, Jim Tressel flew down to the

University of Miami to pick the brain of the reigning national champion head coach, Larry Coker. Tressel's Buckeyes ended up in the national championship game, against Coker's Hurricanes. The Buckeyes won in double overtime. Tressel knew he must keep learning or stop growing.

Self-mastery is a crucial pursuit in leadership, because in order to elevate the performance of the group, the leader must learn to humbly serve the members while maintaining his or her self-assuredness.

Phil Jackson cites the book *The Tao of Leadership*:

The wise leader is of service: receptive, yielding, following. The group member's vibration dominates and leads, while the leader follows. But soon it is the member's consciousness that is transformed. It's the job of the leader to be aware of the group member's process; it is the need of the group member to be received and paid attention to. Both get what they need, if the leader has the wisdom to serve and follow.

A major part of serving the group is teaching personal development. The "goalless" quest of self-mastery is to learn self-control in order to grow, which is a process that never ends. You may ask why the concerted focus on growth when there's no end, but that's like asking why you should live when you know you will one day die. Growth is the end, or you could say that it's the meaning central to truly living.

Some of the best moments in life are the times when we're striving, learning, and growing; we're challenged in something at which we're talented, pursuing something meaningful. The games and practices, the presentations to coworkers and to major clients, all become the same

opportunity: the chance to fully engaged in an extraordinary experience. Michael Jordan was asked what he loved most about playing basketball. He said he loved to practice, because practice was pure basketball. In practice he was challenged in what he was good at doing, he could connect with his teammates, and he could just be Mike. No crowds, no score, no frills. Michael was able to perform masterfully under pressure because practices and games became one and the same for him—an opportunity to feel resonance.

Self-mastery strips away everything that's not us and gets us in tune with who we really are and how we want to feel. Pursuing self-mastery is seeking to be fully present and having both a clear mind and an unburdened heart. To maintain this presence 100 percent of the time is unrealistic, especially with our natural human tendencies to live in the past and future. Therefore, to continue to grow, we need constant renewal.

Here are some renewal activities to develop into the type of person people will follow:

- focus on what you know to be True and *Inner Excellence* principles and tools that help you stay with that Truth
- fill your mind every day with the love, wisdom, and courage available in books and podcasts, lectures and sermons—and memorize key principles and ideas
- train your heart to desire most what is most worthy and empowering (similar to training your appetites to desire what is best for you).
- spend as much time as possible with those who have much more

wisdom than you as well as with those who have much greater tangible needs than you

- review your day before bed, looking for grateful and learning moments, then let go
- continually monitor your ego, that part of you that wants to keep comparing and staying in self-protection mode instead of self-expression and gratitude
- take one day out of every seven to recharge mentally, emotionally, spiritually and physically
- get honest feedback from others

The best leaders, as with the best performers, have vast imaginations and regularly exercise them. It's nearly impossible to be a great leader without regular renewal, because leadership involves constantly providing fresh ideas and motivation so that team members believe in themselves and each other. Thus, leaders must have the self-awareness to know when they're not present, when they need to get centered, and when their preoccupation with themselves is blocking their view of possibilities. Leaders must be able to see the group's success in their mind's eye as well as the path to get there—and then pass that vision on to the team.

Above all, a great leader serves the needs of the group. How? By redefining success in his or her own life to become someone in which love, wisdom and courage overflows into others with the least amount of words... by seeking self-mastery so that they are not led around by society's impulses and comparisons, but by the truth of what's possible and

the glory that awaits each person. An extraordinary leader inspires others to seek self-awareness, self-discipline, and personal growth in order to connect them to a vision beyond themselves. In doing so, they create a family that inspires each other to pursue excellence.

Key Points from Chapter 11

- Extraordinary leaders do three things beyond the areas of technical expertise and disciplined practice:
 - they redefine success
 - connect individuals with a vision beyond themselves
 - seek self-mastery in order to help others do the same and live with fullness of life
- Success in our culture is often measured by what you have, what you've done, and how you compare with others—but that's not how the best leaders measure success.
- The best coaches and leaders define success by effort and growth and a meaningful purpose, one that serves the greater good.
- Extraordinary organizations focus on being their best selves, not beating the competition.
- A powerful leader inspires individuals to connect with something bigger than themselves, helps members grow as people, and enables the members to grow together as a unit.

Follow-Up Questions and Activities

- What do you need to do or change in the team environment in order to facilitate personal growth and reduce comparison and self-centeredness?
- Which principles, presuppositions or ideas do you need to put on the walls and windows of your team room?
- What is the redefined definition of success for yourself and your team?
- What do you need to do to gain the rapport of your team members to guide them to a common vision, one that they're ready to sacrifice for? How well do you know their current personal goals and vision?
- In your own pursuit of self-mastery, what do you need to do to increase your self-awareness, self-education, and self-discipline?

Conclusion

A New Way of Life

This time, like all times, is a very good one, if we but know what to do with it.

—Ralph Waldo Emerson

In our journey together we've seen the seductive influence of Western culture and how we're exposed every day to the affluenza virus. This inhibits the pursuit of what we really want: great experiences, deep meaningful relationships, and a life of peace and purpose, and the power that comes with it. We looked at how we get in our own way more than anything else. We discussed how love, wisdom, and courage form the foundation for extraordinary performance and the amazing energy of resonance. We also saw how suffering, discipline and joy are intertwined and how our default mindset places ourselves at the center of our universe, which moves us towards fear and prevents us from truly living.

For most of us, our past self-centered lives have disrupted our flow. Our performance, in the office, on the field, or on the court was merely a means to an end: the pursuit of winning no matter what the cost. Winning the next game. Making the next sale. Getting ahead. Being happy. Somehow, in this fervent quest, we lost ourselves—or at least, the love of working and competing for the pure joy of the moment. We've been socialized to pursue the achievement-oriented path of promotions and victories at any expense, even with all the attachments of worry and concern and loss of integrity. The pats on the back we got gave us a feeling of validation, despite being accompanied by the self-consciousness and anxiety that came from trying

to please others. In pursuing a better life, we lost our freedom and gained a divided heart.

Our freedom got stymied by an endless stream of thoughts, most of which were negative or useless. We bounced back and forth from the past to the future, analyzing, pondering, hoping, doubting. It was like a never-ending seesaw, with perfect balance being the present moment, where extraordinary moments exist. We experienced it and knew it was there, then quickly jumped to the past or future, joining our doubts and fears.

For most of us, those moments were so unfamiliar and uncomfortable that we rushed back to pursue society-defined achievement and status. Sacred moments were unsettling because they imparted an awareness of our potential, and often we didn't want to face it. Perhaps we were afraid of what we might find and the fears we would have to confront. The possibility that we weren't living up to our potential, combined with the knowledge that the effort to do so may have required some degree of suffering and discomfort, was scary. Amazingly, we were more comfortable with the transient feelings of the seesaw than the grounded appreciation of what's possible: a life of extraordinary experiences and peak performance.

Now, however, you have the tools to counter the Critic, Monkey Mind, and Trickster that used to block your progress. Armed with the knowledge of self-centered human nature and its limiting effects, you have the option each day to move away from fear and toward peak performance and long-term fulfillment. You can choose to lead with your heart, expand your vision, and be fully present. To lead with your heart is to connect with your true self—that is, to rid yourself of all that's not you and learn how you're meant to live, feel, and compete. To expand your vision is to continually adjust your map of the world to see the unseen: the ideas, beauty, and focus

that redefine each moment. An expansive vision is only possible when we stop clinging to our lives (and all the needs and fears that go with it) so we can capture the wisdom that leads to learning, growth, and great experiences.

As you continue to learn, you'll challenge your old beliefs and pursue a purpose for your life that serves the greater good. This will empower you to have a clear mind and an unburdened heart as you connect with the beauty and excellence of each moment. For this you need to streamline your focus and reorient your affections, to love most what is most empowering. A transformed heart that selflessly loves others—first—including your opponents—allows you to live with absolute fullness of life. It takes courage to surrender your life, but in doing so you'll connect with your true self and experience the sacred moments of resonance.

Resonance is the reward, one unwritten about in magazines and newspapers but immeasurably valuable in your heart. It's the electric feeling of being fully present and congruent being your true self.

One of my goals with this book has been to share with you what's possible when you live authentically and courageously, beyond your external ambitions, pursuing resonance and zoe (absolute fullness of life). Perhaps by now your ever-expanding vision has offered a glimpse of the incredible journey ahead—the one that compels you to be fully engaged, heart, mind and body, unattached to your circumstances or results.

As you embrace this path, more authentic moments will begin to unfold, where nothing exists except the here and now and your mind, body, and spirit flow together as one. Ordinary moments become extraordinary. Excitement arises as you have more sacred moments, times where peace and passion come together, where effort becomes art.

As you learn the principles and practice the tools and exercises, you'll gain confidence to take more risks, to face your fears and fully experience sacred moments in both your career and daily life. You'll live with passion and courage, confronting those times of fear and the desire for social acceptance with a determination to be your true self and live each moment fully. Now you have a new mindset, a new skill set, and new tool set. You know that at any moment, you can transform your state, and live with more freedom, vision, and resonance.

Together, you and I and our little *Inner Excellence* community, will commit to continuing our search for truth in how to live, how to feel, and how to compete. We'll rise above our ever-changing circumstances, and the wins and losses, and get steadily more in tune with excellence, seeing the beauty and abundance around us, unconstrained by our emotions and perceived limitations.

Through this lens, our faith will continue to grow, and sacred moments will unfold. Our perspective will continue to broaden, which will enable us, like an *Inner Excellence* golfer standing over a six-foot putt for the win, to have a steady hand, a clear mind, and an unburdened heart. It can be a scary path as you learn to be comfortable being uncomfortable and lose your attachment to the superficial. But the reward—living wholehearted with fullness of life—is absolutely worth it.

If you pursue this path with me, *with all your heart*, you'll find the secret to everything you've ever wanted. Seek first to develop your inner world—and all your relationships—and everything else will be added to you. So keep asking...seeking...and knocking. The door will open. I guarantee it.

If *Inner Excellence* resonates with you...

Sign up for the VIP list for more tools, techniques and interviews delivered to your email inbox at www.innerexcellence.com.

If *you find this book five-star worthy*, please click on this [Amazon link](#) (takes you directly to the review page) and give it your honest rating, and *why you believe it's important to read this book*. I read every review and am so grateful when you share the love. Every positive review allows me to spend more time in research and writing.

Your encouraging review helps more people around the world live with love, wisdom and courage, as well as support *The Inner Excellence Freedom Project*, which receives at least 10% of the profits from this book.

About the author

On Dec. 21, 2003, I moved to the Sonoran Desert in Tucson, Arizona to find a purpose to which I could devote my life. My career as a professional baseball player in the Chicago Cubs organization was over and I felt like I was spinning my wheels.

I had a Master's Degree in Coaching Science from the University of British Columbia where I started the baseball team (which became a varsity sport across Canada) and played free safety on the football team (after an eight-year layoff). As a graduate student I did two years of research on how to build a championship team. I interviewed 38 Major League Baseball general managers, field managers and coaches in-person so I could learn how they developed their players' beliefs, set goals and built a championship culture. But on this day, I decided to simplify my life.

I got rid of my television, left my girlfriend, and gave away over half my possessions. I went to live a life of solitude, to put aside all that was not me so I could see who I truly was. I limited my social and dating life, and without a television, life was often lonely.

Towards the end of December after my first year I was sitting in my empty house writing in my journal. I heard a noise and went outside and saw fireworks. I suddenly realized it was New Year's Eve. I knew it was December but hadn't known which day it was. I walked back in the empty house and wondered, "What am I doing here, alone, in this empty house, when I could be back home having a good time with friends? Who does this kind of thing?"

I took a part-time job with my former teammate in pro baseball, Ricky Scruggs, at his newly formed Centerfield Baseball Academy. While there I

decided to become a personal coach to pro baseball players and teach them how to have poise under pressure. My first two clients did extraordinarily well, so I decided to put together a little mental toughness manual to give to future clients.

I called up a sport psychologist and asked him, “How can an Olympic athlete train for four years for an event that may last less than a minute, and have peace and confidence in that situation?” That brought more questions than answers, so I called another. Then another. Then another. I spent the next five years in full-time research and writing, 60-80 hours a week. I interviewed sport psychologists, Olympic coaches, mental skills coaches for professional sports teams, and some of the best athletes in the world. This book is the result. The first edition of the book came out in December 2009 and went in bookstores around the world early 2010.

In the fall of 2011 PGA Tour golf caddie Jude O'Reilly from Dublin, Ireland read the book. He told his boss (pro golfer Henrik Stenson) I might be someone who could help him achieve his dreams. Henrik became my first PGA Tour client. Soon after, I got a call from Sean Foley who was coaching some of the best golfers in the world, including Tiger Woods. He read the book and wanted to see if I could work with one of his clients who had been struggling, Hunter Mahan.

The next year and a half I traveled to about 16 or 17 countries, working with Hunter and Henrik, as well as with corporate leadership teams around the world. Both golfers went on to have extraordinary success over the next several years, with Hunter winning two big events (including the World Golf Championship) in our first six months.

During that time I got a call from David Novak, CEO of *YUM Brands* (*Taco Bell, KFC, Pizza Hut*) who read the book and shared it with his

executives. We did an *Inner Excellence* offsite retreat for the KFC Western Europe leadership team. It was an extraordinary week and led to more offsite retreats and many great relationships that continue to this day. I've been traveling around the world coaching world-class athletes and leaders ever since.

In 2018, I realized I had learned so much in the past nine years (the first edition of *Inner Excellence* was published in 2009). So I began two more years of writing 30-40 hours a week on this revised edition of the book.

Now I get to share the *Inner Excellence Revised Edition* with you, and for that I am extremely honored. This book is my life's work—what I've learned and the principles that have completely changed my life. I look forward to hearing your story.

Inner Excellence FAQs

1. What if I don't care about anything besides winning an Olympic gold medal, becoming world champion, or being the best Fortnite video game player in my neighborhood? Do I still need to clarify my life purpose and focus on love, wisdom and courage?

I totally get it. This is how I've lived most of my life—obsessed with success. The answer is no, you don't have to do any of those things. Many people have won world championships without ever thinking about what their heart wants most or why they want to be successful. However, if you're not naturally one of the most gifted performers in the world who also outworks everyone, you're going to want every edge you can get. Also, what good is it if you gain the whole world only to lose your soul? Wouldn't you want to go for what you want most anyway, a meaningful, fulfilling life with great experiences and great relationships, peace and joy, AND extraordinary results (the whole candy store)? Why settle for the Olympic gold medal or world championship (the little lollipop) when it may not bring joy and fulfillment? If you pursue *Inner Excellence*, you'll have the best chance of getting everything you could possibly want, and perhaps more than you ever dreamed.

2. I've always believed confidence is crucial to performing well under pressure. Shouldn't I have some ego and pride to bolster my confidence?

It depends on what you mean by ego and pride. If you mean, "Shouldn't I tell people how good I am?", usually you're just trying to convince

yourself. If so, there's far better ways of doing that. If you mean, "Shouldn't I walk tall and act confidently even though I may not feel it?" Yes, that is a much more empowering way to be confident. Essentially when you're saying you want more confidence, what you really mean is you want to perform better, especially when the stakes are high. If that's the case, even more empowering than confidence is to be fully engaged in the moment, heart, mind and body. You can be confident and perform poorly, which happens a lot. How many times have you thought, "Today I've got it—it's going to be a great day," and it ends up not being what you hoped for? But if you learn what your heart deeply wants, beyond the temporary cheers and trophy, and pursue that, and learn to train your mind and body to be fully engaged, then you will succeed far more often.

3. How can I relentlessly pursue my dream of becoming world champion (or whatever your dream is) and be content at the same time? Aren't they conflicting?

Great question. A lot of professional athletes wonder the same thing. I think what you're getting at is that in order to maximize your potential, you need to be obsessive in your pursuit, not "content" on a couch. I totally agree. In order to do anything extraordinary, which is what this book is about, you need to sacrifice and be prepared to suffer, continually learning, growing and improving, in order to become someone you've never been before.

The question is, how can you best do that? How can you maximize your daily training so that you are improving as much as possible every day?

The most efficient and powerful way to do that is to overcome your fears and self-consciousness, and have the freedom necessary to take risks and courageously pursue your dreams with passion and perseverance (what Stanford professor Angela Duckworth calls grit).

If you're *not* content, it might help you get up earlier, work harder, sacrifice more, etc. So we want to keep that fire *and* go one step beyond it. We want to have that sort of obsessive pursuit of excellence, while also not being bogged down by neediness... not "needing" love and acceptance from others, recognition, money or status. If we have deep contentment, joy and confidence, then we can dream great dreams, see new horizons, and not be caught up in our needs. Most people driven by discontent find that, in the end, their discontent was a deep need for love and acceptance, which can greatly distract from the process of daily improvement.

4. How can I have a strong sense of self if I am selfless?

Ironically, the most powerful way to have a strong sense of self is to be completely selfless. Our biggest challenge in life is our own self-centeredness, our own ego. We get in our own way with self-consciousness and overanalysis, and being attached to what we want but cannot control. These things bring stress, anxiety and fear.

To be your true self is to recognize that you were created for glory (infinite, inherent worth) and that the route to that glory is surrendering your "self" and all your needs, fears and concerns, for a purpose beyond self. Wouldn't that be amazing? Then you can have compassion, peace

and joy, independent of circumstances, because there's no part of you that needs those things. You would have deep connections with others and it would be far easier to be fully engaged, heart, mind and body when you perform, as well as when you're just... sitting on the couch.

5. What types of clients do you work with?

I work with professional athletes in all sports, business executives, performing artists—anyone who wants to maximize their potential at work and in their life. Often I'll be contacted by agents of highly talented performers who know their clients are not getting the most out of their abilities. Other times, a performer may have developed a mental block that needs to be sorted out right away.

6. You mentioned the extraordinary performance of *Inner Excellence* clients. Can you share a bit more?

While my current client list is private, I can tell you that since I started coaching professional and Olympic athletes full-time over 11 years ago, the majority of my clients (individuals and teams) have had the best year of their careers our first year together, or at least in the past five years.

7. How do I start creating routines and habits to live a life of *Inner Excellence*?

1. Go to <http://www.innerexcellence.com/> and sign up for my VIP list
2. Join the [Inner Excellence Academy Facebook group](#) (open to everyone that has purchased the book).
3. Subscribe to the Inner Excellence podcast.

You'll get the latest tips and tools to help you live an extraordinary life. You'll also be the first to hear about upcoming *Inner Excellence* retreats around the world that you can join or an online course or webinar that I occasionally offer. You'll be sure to catch all the latest updates, principles and tools that I teach to the best performers and leaders in the world. You can also follow *Inner Excellence* on other social media.

8. How is *Inner Excellence* different from sports psychology?

Sports psychology is important because it teaches essential mental skills (like ones I've shared with you) such as visualization, self-talk, affirmations, relaxation techniques, etc. *Inner Excellence* takes the best of sports psychology and adds depth and *fullness of life*, as well as an extraordinary way of eliminating mental blocks, fears and painful memories from trauma. The in-depth training of the heart and mind, combined with eliminating the mental blocks that come from trauma is a combination that has transformed lives around the world, as well as helped athletes and leaders achieve extraordinary success.

9. An *Inner Excellence* Retreat sounds amazing. Can you tell me more?

At the retreats, you'll learn more in 3-7 days (depending on the length of the retreat) than you would in a year of monthly coaching. We have amazing food, incredible fellowship, and every person clarifies their life purpose as well as learns the principles, tools and skills to live an extraordinary life. The feedback from the retreats has been amazing, most of which have been corporate leadership retreats or family retreats.

10. What is *The Inner Excellence Freedom Project*?

The Inner Excellence Freedom Project (IXFP) is the name of the 501c3 non-profit charity I started in 2019. This charity is devoted to providing choices to those who live in poverty or prison or just do not have freedom to do basic things. When I am sick, I go to the doctor. When my roof leaks, I get it fixed. Much of the world does not have those options. I want to change that.

We choose various projects to help those living in poverty by providing tangible goods like building a house for a family in need, or leading an *Inner Excellence* retreat in prisons.

The purpose of my life is to share God's love, wisdom and courage with athletes and leaders around the world. The *Inner Excellence Freedom Project* (IXFP) is one of the primary ways I do that (besides sharing *Inner Excellence* with you all). Ten percent of the profits of this book go towards IXFP. I'll continue to donate greater and greater personal funds for these projects, with the goal of 95% of my income donated by 2028.

Since 2013 I've been on the board of directors for the Father's Heart Foundation, a non-profit charity/orphanage in El Salvador. I've also been sharing *Inner Excellence* retreats at prisons as well as building houses in Mexico with a group called *Youth With A Mission, Homes of Hope*.

For more information, please go to
www.innerexcellencefreedomproject.org.

11. How can I order multiple copies of *Inner Excellence*?

If you would like to order 10 or more copies of *Inner Excellence*, please email livedeep@innerexcellence.com and my assistant will send you signed copies at a discount.

To reach me personally, email jim@innerexcellence.com. Generally I respond to all emails within 3-4 days.

Appendix A

12 Steps of Alcoholics Anonymous

1. We admitted we were powerless over alcohol—that our lives had become unmanageable.
2. Came to believe that a Power greater than ourselves could restore us to sanity.
3. Made a decision to turn our will and our lives over to the care of God *as we understood Him*.
4. Made a searching and fearless moral inventory of ourselves.
5. Admitted to God, to ourselves, and to another human being the exact nature of our wrongs.
6. Were entirely ready to have God remove all these defects of character.
7. Humbly asked Him to remove our shortcomings.
8. Made a list of all persons we had harmed, and became willing to make amends to them all.
9. Made direct amends to such people wherever possible, except when to do so would injure them or others.
10. Continued to take personal inventory and when we were wrong promptly admitted it.

11. Sought through prayer and meditation to improve our conscious contact with God *as we understood Him*, praying only for knowledge of His will for us and the power to carry that out.
12. Having had a spiritual awakening as the result of these steps, we tried to carry this message to alcoholics, and to practice these principles in all our affairs.

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Note: I included the 12 steps because they have been extraordinarily successful in transforming lives when no other solution worked. In my experience talking with AA members, perhaps the biggest thing that turned around their lives is surrender. Surrender to a power greater than self that can restore you is the heart of excellence. Learning the power of selflessness and unconditional love are two of the greatest things one can ever learn.

Acknowledgments

God has blessed me incredibly the past ten years since the first edition of *Inner Excellence* came out. Thank you to all the athletes and leaders—some of the best in the world—who invited me into their lives to pursue, together, a life of excellence.

Special thanks to my former teammate and roommate in pro baseball Ricky Scruggs, who invited me to the desert in 2003 and got me started on this amazing journey. His weekend invitation led me to take the risk to leave the safety of my family and friends and pursue a meaningful life. Many of the ideas in this book started out during countless hours of discussion with Ricky. Thank you also to:

Natasha McCartney, my first Vancouver-based editor, who incredibly and selflessly donated her time, energy, and talent when I was just starting out. Natasha's generosity and conscientious care were evident again for this second version of the book as she spent many late nights giving immensely valuable feedback. Natasha you are a gift from God.

James Carpenter who helped me make this updated version of *Inner Excellence* simpler and more powerful. Your insights and feedback were hugely important.

My literary agent, Rita Rosenkranz, who helped edit the first edition and connected me with McGraw-Hill, and shared her expertise for this edition as well.

Professional athletes Ryan Dodd and Stewart Cink with whom I've had many amazing discussions on pride and ego, love and fear, and all the things we encounter in the pursuit of peak performance and fullness of life.

Olympian Heather Brand, who contributed so much to the first edition as

well. Her insights, feedback, and support were an incredible gift.

My early readers and great friends Jamie Osborne, Lise Lavigne, Ricky Scruggs, Connie Geier and De Thompson. Thanks to Stacy Shaneyfelt who also provided insightful feedback and editing.

Paola Zamudio, who generously translated the original version of *Inner Excellence* into Spanish.

David Bentall, who hired me years ago when he was looking for a Christian sport psychologist. Our time together has brought incredible experiences and a deep, engaging relationship as we seek together to share Inner Excellence with those who need it most.

Jude O'Reilly, PGA Tour caddie/coach who introduced me to Henrik Stenson.

The many other PGA Tour caddies who welcomed me into their world and offered insightful questions and discussions that have been immensely helpful, especially: Brandon Parsons, Teddy Scott, Mark Carens, and John Wood.

Dr. Gaston Cordova, who endlessly researches biohacking tools and ideas and shares them with me.

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Derin McMains, mental skills coach for the San Francisco Giants; Dr. Jack Curtis, mental skills coach formerly with the Seattle Mariners; Ronn Svettich, of the Colorado Rockies, and Tom Trebelhorn, Major League Baseball manager and coach, for the many conversations we've had on high performance. Trebelhorn, McMains and I watched many spring training games together, with Tom patiently answering all my baseball coaching questions.

Dr. Cal Botterill, Dr. David Coppel, Dr. Ken Ravizza, Dr. Jim Bauman,

Dr. Jim Loehr, Dr. Matt Brown, and the many other sport psychologists who contributed their thoughts and wisdom.

Dr. Timothy Keller, Dr. Darrell Johnson, and Dr. Dallas Willard, whose concepts and ideas have shaped my life more than any other teachers.

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My parents, for their love and guidance my entire life, and for reading the first edition of *Inner Excellence* and giving feedback. My brothers, Dave, Pat, and Mike, and my sister, Naomi, the incredible inspiration. Most of all, thanks to God, who has blessed me greatly.

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Glossary

abundance mindset: A frame of reference that is able to see possibilities, opportunities, and fullness of life. An abundance mindset comes from gratitude, humility and constant learning.

affirmation: A positive statement about who or how you want to be or what you want to achieve in the future, as if it were true today. For example: I am an incredible public speaker. I live in a world of abundance. I am poised under pressure.

affluenza: The insecurity that arises from placing your identity in possessions, achievements, looks, money, or status. This “virus” causes an endless desire for more of any of those five symbols because it never truly satisfies. Many people carry the virus unknowingly until their deaths.

anxiety: a general sense of unease or apprehension based on an unknown threat; often linked to a threat to the sense of self. On an EEG, anxiety is a mind that samples the environment too often, commonly linked to over-analysis (whereas depression is displayed on an EEG by sampling the environment too seldom).

BFF: acronym for belief, focus and freedom (not just best friend’s forever); these elements are the foundation for extraordinary performance and fullness of life; based on the three most powerful resources in the world: love (freedom), wisdom (belief), and courage (focus).

belief: an idea that your subconscious holds true about who you are and what you can or cannot achieve; the subconscious story you have about

yourself in every area of your life

best possible life: a life filled with love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control; the full extension of the beauty, grace and glory you were created for; comes from having an undivided and understanding heart (wholehearted); absolute fullness of life (zoe).

Note: the abbreviation for *Inner Excellence* is IX, which represents the nine attributes of the best possible life.

best self: the person within that emerges when you rid yourself of all that's not you; you when you're most powerful; your true self, the one with the undivided and understanding heart that lives fully and loves greatly.

bitterness: resentment and anger over what you feel is unjust treatment of yourself. Bitterness is the natural outcome of the unchecked ego that allows pride and entitlement to grow; eventually someone will say or do something, or something will happen or not happen that you cannot control that will cause resentment or anger over your unjust treatment. If your reputation or success is the most important thing in your life, you are one word, phrase or accident away from bitterness.

centering (getting centered): the process of bringing your energy to the center of your body, just below the belly button; clearing the mind through deep breathing and focused concentration.

compassion: to suffer with; compassion is the love, wisdom and courage that comes from humility; compassion interrupts our lives; you cannot be

compassionate when you are busy or in a hurry; an extension of empathy (where you take off your shoes and step into another person's shoes) then taking the next step, walking—perhaps barefoot—with them in order to help them.

conscious mind: The part of the mind's workings of which you are aware and that does the thinking.

contentment: freedom; hope, peace and gratitude that comes from love, wisdom, and courage; unfettered-ness of spirit (CS Lewis)

courage: the ability to be fully present to what matters most, especially in the midst of distractions, temptation or fear.

Critic: the part of the mind that judges everything and delivers a negative verdict, to which you then react emotionally. The Critic is attached to your circumstances.

discernment: to use wisdom to decide the best course of action in any given circumstance

dreams: The intense feelings that come when you're fully present doing what you love. Goals are set in order to feel the dream.

ego: The part of the mind most susceptible to the affluenza virus, finding identity through possessions, achievements, looks, money, or status. It is the great barrier to the extraordinary life because it is constantly comparing, always under threat, never satisfied, and one step away from fear.

emotions: a subset of feelings; there are seven basic emotions: happiness,

interest, surprise, fear, anger, guilt, and sadness.

empathy: to take on the perspective of another person and feel what they are feeling; the gateway to compassion

extraordinary life: a life filled with deep contentment, joy and confidence independent of circumstance. To overflow with love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control.

faith: confidence in what we hope for; assurance in what we do not see; it's the only thing that really matters (expressed in love). To walk by faith is to be guided by your purpose and deepest beliefs; most powerful when fueled by love, wisdom and courage

fear: 1. an unpleasant self-focused, future-oriented emotion caused by the belief that you are threatened; predisposed result of (usually an unaware) preoccupation with self; separates and isolates 2. awe and reverence for the Creator of the universe that comes from wisdom and humility. Note: like all basic emotions, fear is inherently good, created for your protection. Two kinds of fear: the one that comes from self-centeredness that leads to a threatened ego (how you compare) and the fear that creates the growth of personal surrender.

feelings: The state or condition of your mental, physical, and emotional self. Feelings include emotions, sensations, and desires. In our discussion we've used feelings and state synonymously to make things easier (see state)

fixed mindset: The mindset that personal talents, skills, and abilities are

mostly genetic. For example, your IQ cannot be improved. To a person with a fixed mindset, a failure comes from a lack of talent or skill and there's not much they can do about it (see growth mindset)

fully present: A moment of peace, focus, and clarity; a heightened awareness, with no needs, concerns, or thoughts of the past or the future.

goals: external objectives set in order to live your dreams. There are outcome goals (not in your full control) and process goals (focused on the process of achieving an outcome; much more in your control).

glory: the brilliance and weightiness of infinite, inherent worth, for which you were created.

growth mindset: The mindset that natural talents, skills, and abilities are just the starting point; everything can be improved; your success is mostly determined by effort, perseverance, and learning.

guilt: a feeling of remorse for some offense (real or imagined) against one's values towards another person; usually tied to an event. See shame.

happiness: a positive, temporary feeling attached to a circumstance; good feelings based on good circumstances (what's happening). When circumstances are bad there is no happiness (although there may be forced smiles); happiness is always a by-product of circumstances (see joy).

homeostasis: balance within; the efforts of the subconscious mind to maintain a certain level of achievement, whatever you believe is right for you. For example, if you are performing above what you believe you are capable of doing, your subconscious will try to bring the performance down

to your comfort level; it also works in the other direction when you're underperforming.

humility: an accurate view of self; to be free from self-inflation or self-rejection; the product of a clear mind and understanding heart

Note: A humble person knows that inner strength and fearlessness comes from selflessness. They also know that every good thing in their life is largely the direct or indirect result of things they had nothing to do with: the century they were born, their country, parents, coaches, friends...as well as their mind, heart, and physical health, the list is endless; a truly humble person is a very grateful person; humility and gratitude, wisdom and surrender are closely linked; they lead to joy and peace. A humble person knows that our days on earth are like grass; like wildflowers, we bloom and die. The wind blows and we are gone, as though we had never been here.

indifference: the opposite of love, the far end of hate. Martin Luther King Jr. called the white moderate's devotion to order over justice a bigger obstacle than the KKK (read his Letter from a Birmingham Jail [here](#)).

joy: a deep, pervasive sense of well-being, freedom and gratitude, independent of circumstance (deeper and broader than any pleasure); sense of delight that comes from awareness and anticipation of the beauty, grace and glory you were created for

Note: Joy, the by-product of love, is the fundamental attribute that leads to all the other attributes of the best possible life: peace, patience, kindness, goodness (integrity), faithfulness, gentleness and self-control. Joy is possible when unhappy about the circumstances (see happiness), even in the

midst of suffering—indeed it's the strength to get through suffering.

judge/judgmental: v. to lay down a (negative) verdict of someone, something, or yourself (even though we don't have all the information—though we often think we do). The measure you use to judge others will be used to measure yourself; when you judge others, you are also judging yourself (see discernment).

love: selfless devotion to the greater good; a powerful energy focused on putting purpose and others above self; love (others-focused) overcomes fear (self-focused). Unconditional love is the most powerful force in the universe; it is fearless and unstoppable.

mindset: the reason you are doing what you're doing and how you're pursuing it; overall attitude and way of thinking that comes from how you perceive yourself and the world.

Monkey Mind: The endless flow of thoughts; cluttered mind. Most of the time the majority of those cluttered thoughts are some form of self-concern or protection.

PALMS: acronym for the five factors of the affluenza virus: possessions, achievements, looks (physical appearance), money, and status. Merriam-Webster defines palms (in one sense) as symbols of victory or superiority; to impose by fraud.

peace: deep contentment, awe and wonder; profound rest and harmony that comes from having relationships in their proper place (see righteousness); offspring of joy.

pride: self-conscious concern for self, or as Oxford scholar C.S. Lewis calls it, ruthless, sleepless, unsmiling concentration on the self. Self-absorption; leads to comparison and self-consciousness and the need to have more or be more than the next person. With pride there is constant calculation on how one is perceived. Pride is the great barrier to excellence because it is the biggest obstacle to learning from failure. Pride is concerned about perception because protection of the ego is its greatest concern, and the ego is only concerned with comparison (see ego). Since learning and growing is the greatest goal in the process of mind and heart transformation (to *Inner Excellence*), pride is the great obstacle. A proud person can be easily angered or embarrassed whereas a truly humble person cannot be humiliated. Pride and bitterness go together because there is no bitterness without pride. Pride and fear go together; thus, self-protection and humiliation are always a concern (see humility).

purpose beyond yourself: A purpose that directs your life and gives it meaning and power. With a strong enough purpose, people will give their lives in exchange for it.

reset: an *Inner Excellence* tool (also known as reboot) used whenever one is not present or feeling how one wants to feel; involves one or two deep breaths, inhaling through the nose, belly expanding, then exhaling longer than the inhale, doing so while staring at a spot above the horizon, relaxing the jaw and facial muscles on the exhale, letting go of all concerns and desires. Doing so stops the Monkey Mind; it's part of getting centered.

resonance: the state in which frequencies align; excitement and presence that comes from being fully engaged in your natural state (true self); when

you're fully present you can experience resonance; often occurs when you lead with your heart, expand your vision and are fully present.

righteous: to be right-related (to have your relationships in the proper place and priority), especially the big four relationships: God, yourself, others, and your work; being right-related brings a clear mind and undivided heart, and most of all, joy and peace.

scarcity mindset: the belief that there is a limited amount of resources and one must accumulate for themselves; a fearful mindset that sees problems first and gets weighed down by unconstructive thoughts.

self-acceptance: Peace of mind that comes from realizing your unique value regardless of money, possessions, achievements, or status.

self-actualization: The journey toward zoe; a life experienced fully, vividly, and selflessly, with full concentration and total absorption; the feeling of long-term fulfillment, accompanied by a purpose beyond the self; the peace and fulfillment present when life is spent learning and growing in love, wisdom, and courage in order to serve others.

self-awareness: Consciousness of your thoughts, feelings, and actions and the ability to see them objectively, in order to grow. The ability to see your own beliefs, patterns of thinking, feeling, and behavior and how they affect your life and those around you. Self-awareness is the first step toward growth and zoe.

self-care: Controlling your energy in order to be your best self. Eating healthily, exercising regularly, loving others, visualizing, and getting

centered are all examples of self-care.

self-centeredness: Attachment to your past; preoccupation with self; the natural limited viewpoint that fuels self-consciousness and the ego; with constant self-focus, your limits and failures continually emerge.

self-concern: The focus on self that leads to self-consciousness, doubt, anxiety, and eventually fear.

self-conscious: concern about what others think of you; the feeling of discomfort from being noticed and feeling judged by others.

selflessness: Putting the greater good and what's right in front of individual desires or needs; to continuously develop self while simultaneously forgetting about self.

self-mastery: The self-control and presence that come when your life is focused on love, wisdom, and courage. It's the pursuit of self-awareness, self-discipline, and self-education in order to grow to be your best self. The journey toward zoe which supersedes external achievements or worldly success. Closely associated with mastering the ego in three ways: to become unembarrassable, unoffendable, and unirritable.

self-renunciation: to put honor, virtue and the well-being of others ahead of oneself. It's not self-rejection but rather selfless rejuvenation into a person of unconditional love. As Leo Tolstoy put it: "the whole world knows that virtue consists of the subjugation of one's passions, or in self-renunciation."

self-rejection: Personalization of failing to live up to some standard. Rather

than objectively analyzing a setback or an unwanted outcome, it feels as if you not only failed in the task but also are a failure as a person; viewing self as less worthy because of some external event or opinion (see shame).

self-talk: The internal dialogue that goes on in the conscious mind; these words that become thoughts create neural pathways that become beliefs and are constantly forming our hearts.

sense of self: Your feeling of value; your sense of identity. If you have a strong sense of self, you are comfortable being uncomfortable, need no validation, are comfortable in your own skin, and do not rely strictly on successful outcomes to feel good as a person. A person with a weak sense of self lives in constant comparison with others and continually looks to satisfy the needs of the ego. Your strongest sense of self only comes by surrendering your ego fully to the power and grace of love, wisdom and courage.

shame: an intense feeling of being flawed, unworthy. Whereas guilt is tied to an event (I *did* something bad), shame is tied to a person (I *am* bad).

state: The combined status of your heart, mind and body at any given moment; how you feel overall—physically, mentally, emotionally and spiritually (see feelings).

subconscious mind: The part of the mind that works beyond your awareness, allowing you to function and not think of every little thing (such as tying your shoes, walking, and breathing). Immensely more powerful than the conscious mind, it's continually being programmed to make your habitual thoughts and beliefs reality. The subconscious and the heart work

closely together.

surrender: Giving up your needs, fears, concerns and attachments for the greater good; selflessness of unconditional love; trading in your little lollipop for the whole candy store.

Trickster: the deceptive voice that reminds you of all your failures and projects them as future probabilities; the part of the mind that tells you why you cannot improve, win this match, or achieve your goals; the Trickster has two main tools: deception and accusation, both of which lead to self-rejection (you are not enough).

true self: to have an undivided heart (wholehearted), one whose greatest goal is to grow in love, wisdom and courage, constantly seeking to rid oneself of the fear and self-centeredness that isolates. The best part of you that emerges when you rid yourself of all that's not you; the part of you unattached to worldly success; your best self that becomes fearless from loving others more than self (see best self).

unconscious mind: see subconscious

wisdom: keen insight on how to live with absolute fullness of life; an understanding heart; the expanded vision that sees unobstructed views of beauty, opportunities, and connections with others; to know who God is and therefore who you are, what God is doing in the world, and how you can join in; closely related to (unconditional) love and courage; the greatest thing one could ever seek.

zoe: absolute fullness of life; the state of being possessed of vitality; life,

real and genuine; vigor and vibrancy of life; the culmination of love, wisdom, and courage; self-actualization.

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